
THE STORY OF A
GOOD MAN
A NOVEL
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The Story of a Good Man

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English translation

2026

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The Story of a Good Man

English reading edition translated from the Russian original.

About the book

Dear reader, expect strong emotions. This book is for the thoughtful and reflective.

What if your kindness were a fatal disease?

The Story of a Good Man is a book about kindness that destroys and saves at the same time. The first book in a duology.

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Denny

He had always felt what drove him,
had known his true self since childhood;
he had never needed to search for his purpose.

Prologue

December 1948

The frost had held for three weeks and showed no sign of relenting. Sunlight filtered through gaps between the charred boards, barely reaching the stone walls of the old cellar. These ruins were all that remained of an old mansion in the center of a small European city called N.

The cellar had become the last refuge of our hero and his companions.

A group of teenagers who had ended up on their own during the war was surviving there - yes, surviving was exactly the word. Orphanhood had come to them at different times, like a postman bearing terrible letters: earlier for some, later for others. But grief, pity, or the belief that everyone was on their own was not what bound them together. They were held by a simple, animal will: to survive. At any cost. To make it through those brutal years.

They chose the place for one reason: thanks to an old trick of the stove builders, part of a chimney, complete with its ash pit, ran down into the cellar. The young but nimble lodgers knocked bricks out of the wall and built a crude hearth. The chimney became their shared lifeline, drawing smoke up into the sky and offering the ghost of a chance that they would not suffocate. They slept huddled together beside the stone structure that gave off heat, one tangled, breathing mass.

But today the fire was consuming something other than wood. It was devouring the emotions seething in that dark, clammy room, saturated with damp and despair. They were arguing over whether a boy named Denny could stay in their foul-smelling “paradise.” He was sixteen. But time moved differently for him, as it did for everyone who had lived through the horrors of war. His years were

measured not by age, but by the wear on his soul. In those days, life left its marks and scars much deeper.

What could he possibly have done to offend them so, you might ask? In those hungry days, after everything they had endured together, what could make the only people you were close to - the ones with whom you had shared your last ration of bread and fought side by side to stay alive - point you toward the door, out into the white December haze, onto a road ruled by death?

The answer was simple and monstrous: the boy was ill. He suffered from the strangest sickness of the age - or perhaps it had nothing to do with the age at all. To these angry, hardened children in a cruel world, it looked like gangrene that had to be cut away if they were to go on living. Their diagnosis: “kindness of the soul.”

While their verdict hangs in the air like the smell of smoke from damp logs, let’s rewind the film. Let’s see how Denny caught this rare affliction: a boy with the kindest heart, who always seemed to respond to life’s twists in exactly the wrong way.

Chapter 1

Denny was born into a respected family in the once-bright, green city of N. His father, William, was a lawyer; his mother, Sophie, a writer. William was a hard-headed pragmatist who taught his son to look for explanations and see every situation from more than one side. He was strict, but he loved Denny and believed that reason was the best education.

William was often away on business, so Sophie raised Denny. She was the kindest woman in the world. Toma, their maid, a woman seemingly made of country bread, practically lived with them as well, along with her daughter, Lilith, whose green eyes were like little pools in a forest. Toma brought the smell of wax into the house, along with echoes of ancient words from the Bible. Each night she read them to the children, as if speaking a charm over their lives.

From the time he was little, Denny had a remarkable gift for getting into trouble. But his kind of genius had nothing to do with breaking rules; he was no wild child or bully. He simply saw things differently. He had a gift for a goodness that could wreak havoc. The boy seemed too human for this world: too trusting, too guileless, and too fond of everything around him.

His first serious mishap came when he was five. Toma had received a rare treat from her relatives: a large piece of salt-cured meat, dry at the edges and fragrant. She was supposed to take it to her brother, who was in the hospital. Toma tucked the parcel into her bag, then stepped out to the pharmacy for medicine, telling Denny in no uncertain terms to “guard the kitchen.” She meant: keep the cat out.

Denny took the assignment seriously. He watched the yard for the neighbor’s huntress, standing guard as solemnly as a sentry.

Then a stray dog wandered through the gate with her puppies. They were thin, their sides sunken, their eyes showing no malice -

only the endless weariness of hunger. Denny looked at them, then at the parcel on the table. He remembered Toma's instruction, and then a passage from the Bible she had read to him before bed not long ago: the one about helping those in need.

What could be kinder than feeding the hungry?

Denny unwrapped the cloth and, with a little grunt of effort, broke off piece after piece, tossing them to the delighted, tail-wagging little pack. He fed them until the meat was gone. Once they had eaten their fill, the dogs settled beside him on the doorstep. He knew that with guards like these, no cat would get into the kitchen now.

Toma's return became a quiet tragedy. She did not shout. She sat on a stool and cried - not out of anger, but despair. Seeing her tears, Denny understood for the first time that there could be an abyss between doing what was right and getting the result you needed. His father had to give up half his salary to find another piece of meat. The punishment was severe, but Denny still did not understand what he had done wrong. Was it bad to feed the hungry?

Not long afterward, what happened with Lilith opened Denny's eyes.

There was a large courtyard nearby where children from the surrounding streets played. A stocky boy named Kurt was always there, too - the butcher's son, fair-haired, with a hooked nose and a belly like a piglet's. A year older than the others, Kurt thought he owned the vacant lot. He took toys from younger children, teased them, and sometimes shoved them into the mud just for the fun of it.

That day he picked on a small, skinny Jewish boy who had recently moved into the neighborhood. The boy stood with his head drawn down between his shoulders while Kurt circled him, chanting: "Yid, Yid, skin and bone - even a pig will leave you alone, afraid of catching what you've got!"

The other children laughed. Denny stood off to one side, feeling something hot begin to boil inside him: a fierce urge to step in.

But someone beat him to it.

Lilith emerged from behind the children. She was small and round-faced, wearing a polka-dot dress that was too big for her. She walked right up to Kurt, looked up at him, baring her teeth, and said so loudly that everyone heard:

“Your father sells rotten meat! And you’re as fat as a pig! Oink, oink!”

The courtyard fell silent. Kurt went crimson, turning his freckles almost white. He raised a fist, but Lilith did not even blink. She simply stood there, looking at him with big green eyes that held no fear - only cool, quiet contempt.

Denny ran to shove Kurt aside, but tripped and, as he fell, struck him in the groin with his head. Kurt yelped and collapsed, clutching himself. The children scattered. The little Jewish boy gazed at Lilith as if she were an angel descended from heaven. Lilith took Denny by the hand and said:

“Come on. It’s boring here.”

Denny walked beside her, watching her. Something clicked inside him. It was not love; he was much too young for that. It was understanding. He suddenly realized that Lilith was not simply “a girl who needed protecting.” She could be the protector, too. She had an inner, intoxicating strength any boy might envy.

From then on, he saw Lilith differently. Not as someone younger, not as a burden, but as an equal - as someone he could go scouting with, knowing she would watch his back.

But the real trials began when Denny was nine and the Germans had firmly established themselves in the city.

William, Denny’s father, did not flee. He stayed. A qualified lawyer, he was forced to take a post under the fascists in order to protect his family. His immediate superior was Captain Erich

Schultz, a man of such impeccable manners that any ordinary person might feel sick at the sight of them.

William's job gave the family a measure of safety: they had food ration cards, patrols gave their house a wide berth, and Denny could continue his schooling. But the same job also made William a target for the underground and, at the same time, a hostage in the occupiers' hands. Denny did not understand the two sides of his father's position. He only knew that his father left for the big gray building by the town hall and came home late, tired and silent.

Here, the boy's "troubles" entered a new phase - from everyday mishaps to inner tests. He became a courier in the forbidden space between the German patrols and the underground. His first "assignment" was not a grenade but simply a piece of bread and two sugar cubes, which he carried to Lilith after she and her mother had moved into a cold barracks on the outskirts. Curfew turned the city into a chessboard of invisible, moving threats. For Denny, it was the perfect training ground.

His kindness found a purpose - and a thrill. Slipping through sleeping courtyards, pressing himself against a cold wall when footsteps rang down an alley, hearing his own heart pound like a drum: none of it felt frightening. It felt important. He did not feel like a boy, but like a person with a mission: deliver the food.

Denny felt no sense of danger. To him, this was what he was meant to do.

Once, on his way to Lilith, Denny tripped over a fat ginger cat dozing near one of the guard posts. The animal yowled. Denny crashed to the ground, scattering the precious sugar cubes across the snow. A local auxiliary policeman burst out of a doorway. Denny did not run. He dropped to his knees and began gathering the damp, sticky pieces, blowing the dirt off them. The sentry shone his flashlight on the boy scrabbling in the snow and burst out laughing.

"Idiot," he said, without malice. "Go home. Now." Then he left.

Denny reached the barracks with only three sweet cubes left. Lilith ate them with the last of the dirt still clinging to them, licking her fingers. She said they were the most delicious sweets she had ever tasted, because he had brought them.

Lilith's father, Yakov, worked at a brickworks and rarely saw his family. One day, noticing Denny's strange, fearless devotion, he took the boy aside. Yakov did not ask; he simply stated what was needed.

"Denny, you can carry small things. Very important things. For our people."

Denny nodded and agreed.

At first, he carried forbidden leaflets hidden against his chest. Then came cartridges, wrapped in cloth and tied to his legs. And finally, a grenade: cold and awkward, hidden in the double bottom of his school satchel.

He did not do it out of political conviction. At his age, ideas like "homeland" and "freedom" were still vague and blurred. Denny took the risks because Lilith's father had asked him, and Lilith was the person closest to him. In his child's view of the world, there was also a clear division: there were "our people" - Lilith, Mom, Dad, Toma - and "they," the ones who made the girl live in a cold barracks and go hungry.

Helping "his own" felt as natural as breathing.

Every such errand carried the risk of death. Denny seemed to wear an invisible shield of naivety. He looked the patrolmen straight in the eye, without a trace of guilt, and his clear, trusting gaze drew only indulgent smiles.

"What are you doing out here, kid? Get home!"

They would shove him away. They were looking for fear; all he gave them was a calm, baffling confidence. His lack of visible guilt or fear saved him again and again - until the world demanded that he do more than take risks, that he make a final, adult choice.

The next assignment came from Lilith's uncle. He appeared not at night but in broad daylight, as casually as if he had dropped by to borrow some salt. Yet a hard calculation lay behind his eyes. He took Denny aside, into the shed behind the house, where it smelled of old wood and dust.

"Denny, listen carefully," he said, resting his rough, scratched hands on the boy's shoulders. "There's a job. A very important one. Many people's lives depend on it. Can you take a large bundle of old things to the oak grove across the river? Someone will meet you there."

Denny nodded without hesitation. The man was almost one of their own, and his tone left no room for questions. If it mattered, then it had to be done.

"Good lad." Anxiety broke through the man's voice, though he tried to hide it. "The load will be heavy. Say it's from Aunt Toma - 'winter clothes.' Remember?"

The next day, on his way home from school, Denny stopped at the half-ruined barracks. Without a word, the man brought out an enormous, shapeless bundle from behind the stove, tightly bound with rope. It was heavy indeed.

"Carry it carefully. Go through the gardens, along the river. Don't talk to anyone."

"I understand."

The journey was long. The ropes bit painfully into his fingers, and his shoulder ached. At the oak grove, beside a broad, spreading stump, a stranger in a worn coat was waiting for him. Overcome with nerves, Denny suddenly called out:

"Winter clothes from Aunt Toma!"

The man silently took the bundle, gave a brief nod, and disappeared into the forest. Rubbing his stiff hands, Denny ran home with a sense of duty fulfilled. He was even a little proud: he had been trusted with an important grown-up task.

The next day, rumors swept through the city: a group of prisoners had escaped from the concentration camp on the outskirts after killing the guards. People said the escapees had firearms. The Germans flew into a rage, and raid followed raid.

Another day passed. At dusk, a covered black car pulled up outside the Goodmans' house. Several Gestapo agents and an officer in a spotless uniform got out. They did not even knock. They kicked the door open and walked in.

"William Goodman?" the officer asked coldly.

"Yes." Denny's father stepped forward, his composure icy.

"Your son was seen yesterday with a suspicious bundle near the oak grove. We have reason to believe it contained weapons used in the escape. As a father, and a man trusted by the Reich, you are responsible."

William went pale, but his voice did not falter.

"My son is a child. Anyone could have asked him to carry something. The boy could not have known - "

"Silence!" the officer snapped. "Helping partisans is punishable by death. Let this be a lesson to anyone who thinks his status gives him the right to cover up treason."

This was no trial. It was a sentence. Everything happened with monstrous, arrogant speed. The Gestapo agents seized William and shoved him into the yard. Sophie cried out and rushed forward, but they threw her aside. An officer held Denny by the scruff of his neck.

His father stood with his back to the wall of the house - the very wall ivy had climbed in summer. He did not beg for mercy. He only looked over the heads of the men toward the second-floor window, where Denny's pale face was reflected. Their eyes met.

One last time, William tried to make his son understand something without words. His gaze seemed to say: "Don't blame yourself. Live."

A short, sharp command rang out in German.

A volley followed. Not one shot, but several - loud, tearing through the evening silence. William jerked and fell flat on the ground where he had just been standing. Denny could not remember running out of the house with his mother, but the next moment they were already on the porch.

There was no scream. Only a ringing in their ears and a freezing emptiness in which the officer said clearly to Sophie:

“You’re lucky. We’ll spare the boy. But remember: he’ll meet the same fate if you don’t teach him who’s in charge.”

After the car drove away and only mother and son remained in the yard, time stood still. Sounds returned in fragments: a dog barking in the distance, someone’s footsteps beyond the fence, fading quickly, as though anyone near this place had been marked for death. Without a sound, Sophie collapsed to her knees beside her husband’s body. Her lips trembled.

Denny did not move. He stood gripping the wooden doorframe, looking not at his father but at the place William’s gaze had fixed on in his final second. The window. His window.

“He saw me. He understood everything.”

Nausea rose in Denny; his stomach clenched. Now he understood: the bundle he had carried with such a sense of importance had become his father’s death sentence. An act meant to help strangers had killed the person closest to him.

Everything pressed down on him; something prickled in his chest. His belief in justice, in the safety of the world, in the idea that good was repaid with good - all of it crumbled to dust, mingling with the dust in the yard and the dark pool of blood spreading across the ground. Denny looked at his father’s hand, twisted unnaturally by the fall. On his wrist was his beloved watch, the one Denny had been allowed to play with.

He saw his mother sway, exhausted. His legs felt like stone, yet they carried him forward on their own. He went to her, knelt beside her, and put his arms around her shoulders.

He did not cry. There were no tears. Only an immense, all-consuming weight - and that strange, warm impulse inside him: he had to hold her. He had to be strong.

“Mom.” His voice sounded hoarse and strangely loud in the silence. “Mom, get up. We have to… we have to…”

Denny helped her to her feet, led her into the house, and sat her down on a chair. Then he went back into the yard alone. Trying not to look at his father’s body, he turned toward Lilith. She stood frozen by the gate, pale, her huge eyes full of terror and tears. She had come looking for Yakov, who had not returned from work, and had come to ask Sophie where he was. At that very moment, a familiar impulse broke through the icy emptiness inside Denny.

Denny went over to Lilith.

“He isn’t coming back,” he said quietly.

Lilith only looked at him, unable to say a word.

“But I’m here.” Those words were not meant to comfort her; they were a vow he was making to himself, the last one he could make. “I’m here. I’ll always be here.”

He took her hand and led her inside, to his mother. There was no childish tenderness or brotherly concern in the gesture - only an act of will. A decision. The need to do good had proved stronger than everything else. It was not a feeling. It was part of the way he was made, a bone that had not broken when everything around him crumbled to dust.

With an emptiness inside him, ringing like a broken bell, and a tiny, unquenchable flame at its deepest point, Denny crossed the threshold. Not into the house, but into a new era of his life. An era in which kindness ceased to be a virtue. It became his fate: inexplicable, fatal. He carried it within him - not like a cross, but like an incurable illness of his own.

His father’s death left them suspended between life and death. Their privileges vanished; their protection evaporated. Their rationed food was gone. Each day could bring a new trial.

That was when Captain Erich Schultz entered their lives. He did not barge in. He came on a formal visit to offer his “condolences to the widow.”

Denny remembered him as a man without a face: neat uniform, impeccable manners, a level voice without emotion. Schultz represented the military command. He had once been his father’s superior; now he was simply a stranger who had come for some reason. He had power over everyone in the city, including their fate, but he wielded it quietly.

A week later, the captain came again. He brought a tin of coffee and a bar of chocolate. He spoke to Sophie in the beautiful French she had once loved. He did not offer to protect her. He simply stayed close, knowing that was enough to give him a semblance of comfort and the softness of a woman’s body.

Denny hated him. He hated Schultz’s quiet confidence, his polished boots, the smell of expensive soap and leather he brought with him. The officer was the living embodiment of the system that had killed Denny’s father - and, at the same time, their only chance of survival. That contradiction tore the boy apart.

One day, while Schultz sat in the living room drinking tea, Denny decided to show how grown-up he was. He had learned a couple of German phrases. He walked into the room and recited, crisp and formal: “Guten Tag. Danke schön.”

Schultz raised an eyebrow. Sophie froze. Encouraged, Denny added: “Mein Vater ist tot.” (*My father is dead.*)

The captain slowly set down his cup. Silence hung in the room, thick as molasses. Then he nodded and said in German, “I know, boy. I know.” Nothing more.

Later that night, Sophie cried into her pillow, understanding her son’s pain but powerless to ease it. Exhausted by grief and fear, she clung to this lifeline. She did not love Schultz. She endured him.

Over the tea and plain crackers he brought, and the conversations about literature he made out of politeness, Denny’s mother was buying safety for her son. He saw that her eyes stayed

empty even when she smiled in response to their guest's courtesies. It was a quiet, daily execution.

One day Schultz arrived without coffee. He carried a small wicker basket, from which long, slightly trembling ears poked out.

"This is for the boy," he said, setting it on the floor. "A rabbit. A lop-eared 'ram' rabbit. They say they're very clever."

Denny looked at the little animal. It met his gaze attentively. Its fur was soft and chocolate-brown; its damp nose kept twitching, and its eyes were dark, bright, and unafraid. It sat in the basket, busily sifting the straw with its front paws.

"His name is Max," Schultz added. "He used to belong to our paymaster, but the man has left."

Denny did not say thank you. He said nothing at all. He simply crouched and held out one finger. The rabbit nudged it with his nose, sneezed, and began to explore Denny's hand - warm, alive, real.

His mother, standing in the doorway, gave a barely perceptible nod.

Denny understood: Max could stay.

Max soon became the center of the boy's little universe. Each morning, as soon as he opened his eyes, Denny checked the basket first: Was Max there? Was he breathing? Were his ears moving?

When Denny carried the rabbit to the barracks to see Lilith, Max would cautiously poke his nose outside, sniffing the frosty air, the smell of smoke and damp firewood - the strange, anxious life beyond home. The boy would cover him with a corner of cloth and whisper, "Don't be afraid. I'm here."

Lilith and Toma's home was a huge building, divided by plywood partitions into cramped little cubicles. It smelled of mold and wet clothes. Children were always jostling in the shared corridor: thin, quick, and able to tell at a glance whether there was anything of yours they could take.

That day they were playing in the yard. At last, the sun broke through the low clouds, and even the cold seemed easier to bear. Denny sat on an overturned crate, with the basket beside him. Lilith knelt and gently stroked Max's back. Eyes closed, he pressed his fur into her fingers.

"He's like a little teddy bear," Lilith said. "Only with ears."

"He's a ram," Denny corrected her solemnly. "A ram rabbit."

"Why is he a ram if he's a rabbit?"

Denny thought about it, then admitted honestly:

"I don't know. That's what Schultz said."

The name hung in the air like a mosquito, buzzing unpleasantly. Lilith said nothing. She only stroked Max quickly, in short, abrupt motions.

Of course, the local boys noticed them. There were about five of them, between eight and twelve, all in rags, their knees smeared with clay. They formed a half-circle around Denny and Lilith. Their leader was lanky, with a split lip that never seemed to heal. He narrowed his eyes at the basket.

"What's that?"

"A rabbit," Denny said without looking up.

"A rabbit? A nice, plump one?" Klaus stepped closer.

"He's a ram," Denny muttered. "A ram rabbit."

And then it began.

"A ram! Hear that? A ram!" someone guffawed. "He's as dumb as his rabbit!"

"Let's eat him!" shouted a red-haired boy with freckles.

"No, let's trade him instead!"

Denny pressed his lips together, afraid. Lilith quietly pulled the basket closer to herself.

"Rabbit is food!" Klaus yelled. "Rabbit tastes good!"

He leaned over and poked Max right on the nose. The little animal flinched and scrambled into a corner.

Denny stood up. Everything inside him was trembling. He did not know how to fight. He was small and skinny, with thin wrists and kind eyes that trusted the world far too much. Klaus was a head taller and half again as broad across the shoulders.

A sharp slap rang through the yard - Denny had struck him. Not with a fist, but with an open hand, as hard as he could, full across the face. The sound was loud and wet, like a soaked rag snapping. Klaus froze, clutching his cheek. His eyes were full of disbelief; this had not happened to him in a long time.

“He’s not food,” Denny said, his voice trembling. “He’s my friend. And you’re not touching him again.”

Then all hell broke loose. Denny did not even try to shield himself. He simply clung to Klaus, gripping his jacket, trying - whether to defend himself or hold his opponent back, he could not have said. They knocked him down and piled on top of him, a knee crushing his chest. Someone punched him in the face; someone else tried to kick him in the ribs. He heard Lilith scream - a thin, desperate sound, almost a shriek.

Suddenly an adult voice roared. The gang scattered, leaving Denny on the frozen ground, staring up at the pale sky. Lilith stood over him, holding the basket close. Max was alive and unharmed, poking his nose out with curiosity.

“Are you all right?” Lilith whispered.

Denny sat up, felt his split lip, then carefully touched his sore cheek. He looked at the rabbit. Max twitched his whiskers and seemed to have no idea he had just started World War III.

“Wow, I really smacked him in the ear,” Denny said with a sudden grin. The smile was crooked, through the scrapes, but real. “Did you hear that slap?”

“The whole yard heard it,” Lilith replied, and they burst out laughing.

Denny came home scratched all over, with a blackened left eye and his jacket torn at the shoulder. His mother rushed toward him, but he pulled away. Sophie looked at the rabbit, then at her son.

“Did you protect him?”

The boy lowered his eyes without answering. She stroked his head and sighed.

“You’re just like your father.”

Denny could not lie.

That night, he lay awake for a long time. His side ached, his lip was swollen, and his cheek burned where the skin had been scraped. But deep inside, beneath his ribs, where a cold, sticky emptiness had taken up residence over the past few months, something small and tender began to glow.

He had protected someone. Not his mother, not his father, not even Lilith. Max. A creature who was only a rabbit, and might die of old age in a couple of years. But now, staring into the darkness and listening to Max rustle softly in the straw, Denny thought: “I didn’t let them hurt him. I did it.”

He fell asleep with a happy smile.

Then Captain Schultz disappeared. Without saying goodbye. He simply stopped coming. Later, word got around that his unit had been transferred to the Eastern Front. The shield they had relied on - so conditional, so repulsive - had fallen away.

Other men began visiting Denny’s mother. Not officers, but the dregs of the rear ranks: bitter, burned-out men in uniform who saw a woman alone in an empty house as nothing more than a way to prove they still mattered and could still wield power over someone.

Denny understood. He sat in his room with his forehead pressed against the cold wall. Through the thin partition came sounds that chilled his blood and made him want to tear out his own ears. It was nothing like what the boy had heard before, when the officer visited.

Back then, there had been silence, broken by the occasional muffled voice. Now there was furniture crashing to the floor, choked sobs cut short by a coarse growl, heavy, wet blows, as if someone were beating a sack of grain.

And laughter. Drunk, shameless, animal laughter. Denny plugged his ears with his fingers, but the sound pushed through the bones of his skull. He could see it all in his mind as clearly as if there were no wall between the rooms. His mother's face stood before him - pale, twisted not so much by pain as by an all-consuming shame and submission that made his own stomach clench.

There were two of them that evening. Something in their voices, in their wild excitement now held back by nothing, told Denny that tonight would be worse. He curled up under the blanket, trying to turn invisible, to disappear.

But the sounds grew louder. Then came a scream - short, desperate, full of such terror that Denny jumped out of bed. A blow landed, then another. The scream cut off, replaced by a quiet, bubbling moan.

The beating went on. Methodical. Heavy.

Denny's body began to move on its own. His legs, numb and unsteady, carried him into the next room, to the hiding place beneath the floor. His hands, cold as ice, found his father's hidden pistol - smooth, heavy, alien.

His heart hammered somewhere in his throat. He gulped air in short breaths. He did not think. There were no thoughts, only a thin, piercing ring in his ears and a white flare of rage before his eyes.

He flung the door open.

The scene burned itself into his memory in a single frame. Disorder. An overturned chair. His mother on the floor beside the bed. Her face... unrecognizable, swollen, covered in blood and bruises. Her clothes were torn. One of the bastards, his trousers

lowered, stood over her, breathing hard. The other grinned as he adjusted his belt.

The roar in Denny's head became deafening. He did not aim. He simply raised the heavy piece of iron and pulled the trigger. The blast tore through the air. The first brute jerked and fell on his side. The grin slipped from the other man's face, replaced first by stupid disbelief, then by panic. He raised his hands and froze, choking on his words:

"No! Stop! Don't! I have children, do you hear? Children! I didn't mean to!"

But Denny heard only one thing, repeating over and over: "children, children, children." The word became a brake. It did not stir pity, but it shifted something in his mind - from "eliminate the threat" to "there is a human being in front of you."

Something short-circuited inside him. His hand, ready to pull the trigger, froze. He could not bring the force of one world - the world of Toma and the commandment "Thou shalt not kill" - to bear on an object from another world, one of chaos and absolute evil. He spared the monster.

The gunshot's echo still hung in the air, mingling with the crash of broken dishes, when a shout and the thud of boots came from the street. A patrol. Their barracks stood across the road; they had heard everything.

Denny's world narrowed to a tunnel. Hot, salty tears filled his eyes, turning the lights beyond the window into blurred yellow spheres. He could not think. His wild, primitive survival instinct surged to the surface, sweeping away shock and horror. He did not even glance at the other man, whimpering against the wall. He just bolted.

He raced through the familiar rooms - to the entryway, to the pantry at the far end, where a black opening beneath the ceiling led to the attic. He scrambled up, scraping his knees on old boxes, his heart pounding as if it might burst from his chest. Below, someone was already battering at the front door; rough voices rang out.

The attic was dark and dusty, smelling of old wood. Moonlight slipped through a crack in the roof, showing the way to a dormer window that opened onto the roof of the neighboring house. Without a second thought, Denny squeezed through. The cold December air seared his lungs.

He ran over the slippery, sloping roof, balancing on the edge of a fall. He felt no fear of the height, no cold - only a burning need to escape, to disappear. After crossing the rooftops, he climbed down a drainpipe into the courtyard he had known since childhood, then raced through dark alleys toward the barracks. He stumbled over potholes and gasped for air. The ringing in his ears had given way to the quiet moan of his mother. He thought he could hear nothing in it but pain.

He burst into the wretched little room without knocking, covered in dust, his face bloodless. Toma did not ask a thing. She cried out, scooped him up, and held him against her warm body, smelling of bread and soap, shielding him from the whole world. Only there, safe in the firm, dependable arms wrapped around his stiff shoulders, did his protection finally fail.

The adrenaline ebbed, and understanding flooded in. It did not come as a thought, but as an image surfacing in his memory with horrifying clarity. Not his mother's face when he burst into the room. Her posture. The unnatural angle of her arm. Her head thrown back. And, above all, the complete, absolute stillness. No breath. No sound. Nothing.

Denny froze in Toma's arms. He heard the whisper of her prayer: "Our Father, who art in heaven..."

In that moment, two realities collided: the one in which he had fired to save someone, and the one he had actually witnessed.

"She wasn't moving..." he breathed, his voice hoarse and unfamiliar. "Aunt Toma... she... she wasn't breathing."

The words burned away his last illusions like acid rain. He had not saved her. He had taken revenge. Or perhaps he had not taken revenge at all - he had simply fired into the void while the real

killers had already done their work. His rage, the gunshot: all of it had been a useless gesture. He was too late.

He had not protected her. He had let them take her life before he had found the courage to go in.

The realization crashed down on him with all its weight. Denny broke down - not with a child's tears, but in deep, wrenching sobs filled with anger at himself, helplessness, and a final, lightless emptiness. Toma only held him tighter, her prayer growing louder, trying to cast a spell over the horror, over this irreparable disaster.

A week in hiding at Toma's felt like life beneath a glass bell. Every creak on the stairs, every knock at the door made Denny flinch and freeze. They waited, and the waiting wore them down more than any punishment could have. Then one morning they were found. No noise, just quiet, assured efficiency. Two men in plain clothes entered the room, looked around briskly, and nodded toward Denny.

"Get your things, lad. You're coming with us to answer some questions."

They did not hit him or shout. They simply led him through the still-dark streets to a massive gray building with columns.

The building had once been the town hall; now it housed the local SS headquarters. Inside, it smelled of tobacco, leather, and paper dust. They shoved Denny into an empty, brightly lit office and told him to wait. He did not wait long.

The door opened. An officer with glasses and an indifferent face came in - and the other man. He was now in a clean, pressed uniform, but dark shadows lay under his eyes and his fingers trembled slightly. When he saw Denny, the German went almost imperceptibly pale and looked away.

The officer sat down at the desk and spread out some papers.

"All right," he began, impassively. "Unteroffizier Krause says he heard shots at the house opposite headquarters and was one of the first to arrive. He found this: his fellow soldier dead, Mrs. Goodman

dead, and no one else in the house. His statement" - the officer glanced at the trembling Krause - "has been recorded. Now it's your turn, boy. Where were you that evening?"

Denny said nothing. Under the officer's oppressive stare, he felt a shiver run down his back. He was afraid.

But something else paralyzed him even more than fear: the injustice of it. This man - Krause - was standing there alive and lying. His mother was dead.

"I... I was at some people's house," Denny said quietly.

"Whose house? Who can confirm that?"

"Toma. The maid. And her daughter."

The officer made a note, then looked up at Krause.

"Unteroffizier, look at the boy again. Are you absolutely certain you did not see him in the Goodmans' house that night?"

Krause forced himself to look at Denny. His eyes lingered on the boy's pale, tightly pressed lips and the bruise beneath his eye - the mark of a blow from a week ago. Two fears struggled inside the soldier: being exposed as a rapist, and panic at the boy - at what he knew, at the memory of Denny standing there with a pistol in his hands, able to kill him, yet sparing him. Perhaps that fear stirred a calculating instinct for self-preservation. Krause was afraid; he was shaking inside, and nausea rose in him.

"Herr Obersturmführer," Krause said, his voice hoarse but firm. "I... I didn't see this boy. And the man who fired... when I ran in, I caught only a glimpse of his back. A tall man. Dark clothes. He jumped out the window and got away."

The lie hung in the air, thick and tangible. The officer studied them both, shifting his gaze from one to the other. At last, he looked at Denny.

"What do you say? Did you see anything?"

Images flashed through Denny's mind: his father against the wall, his mother on the floor, the pistol sight fixed on Krause's back... and the gun lowered. This man was lying to save his own

skin, but now his lie was the boy's only shield. Tell the truth, and Denny would have to admit he had been there. That meant death. No one here acquitted the innocent.

Denny lowered his eyes. Something in his soul finally broke - not his kindness, but his belief in the value of truth itself. The truth would have killed him. A scoundrel's lie gave him a chance.

"I don't know anything," he said in a hollow voice. "I wasn't home. I didn't see anything."

The officer tapped his pencil on the desk. The case was becoming messy and complicated: two bodies, one of them a German soldier; no physical evidence except the weapon; and two witnesses who supposedly had not seen each other. Shoot the boy? They could do it right now. But for what? Time was short, and there were not enough formal grounds. Besides, the boy was the son of a "traitor" who had already been punished. A suspicious element.

"Enough. I'm late," the officer snapped. "The boy goes to the camp. Send the maid and her daughter there too."

The cold statement settled everything. Denny was not shot. He was simply written off as a useless, suspicious appendage - as a possible threat easier to isolate than investigate. His last act of "kindness" - the bullet he had not fired at Krause - sent behind barbed wire the people he most wanted to protect: Toma and Lilith.

The monstrous irony was beyond him. Denny simply bowed his head as the escort came for him.

The three months in the camp became the most terrible trial of all. Dozens of people at a time were led to the gas chambers. Lilith's mother was killed almost at once. As the heartless guards joked, she took up too much space.

Survival here came down to simple arithmetic: how to find one extra crumb of bread, how to take up less room, how to become invisible in a frenzied crowd of people just as doomed as you were. But for Denny there was one more variable: Lilith. Protecting her became his only meaningful task, the anchor that kept him from losing his mind to hunger and terror.

He became her shadow. When the soup was served - a sludge of offal and rotten potatoes, sometimes with strange, fibrous bits floating in it, bits that looked like human skin and were too horrible to examine closely - Denny pushed his way forward. Shoving the weakened aside with his elbows, he tried to get two portions. Once, a tall man, emaciated to the point of looking like a skeleton, tore Lilith's bowl from her hands. Denny hurled himself at him without thinking, sank his teeth into the man's dirty, bony hand, and would not let go until, with a curse, the man flung the bowl away. Together, they ate that soup straight off the floor, trembling with adrenaline and fear.

At night, they slept piled together on the bunks, and Denny arranged himself so that he could shield Lilith with his body. He felt the stares directed at them: empty, hungry, stripped of all humanity. They did not show interest so much as a simple appraisal of flesh. In the dark, the boy hissed like a kitten, baring his teeth and gripping a sharpened stone in his pocket - his only weapon.

The worst thing was not the SS men with their dogs, but the people who had lost their minds - the ones whose eyes already burned with the mad fire of hunger. One day, while Denny had gone to fetch water, one of those shadows crept toward Lilith. He said nothing, only reached for her with thin, trembling fingers, looking at her not as a person but as a piece of meat. Denny returned in time. Seeing the girl in danger, he struck the man on the temple with the stone, using every bit of strength he had left.

Quietly, without a sound. The man simply sank to the floor and went still, bleeding. In this place, death was an everyday occurrence.

Every day began and ended in fear. But fear had become something he had learned to live with, a constant background. Only one thought remained in the foreground: "She has to survive. She's the last thing keeping me myself."

The air raid began without warning. First, sirens wailed somewhere in the distance. Soon the sky filled with a growing,

rumbling roar that made the ground shake. For the prisoners, this was not terror but a chance. The guards, forgetting about the inmates, ran for shelter, shouting and shoving one another.

Amid the chaos, swallowed by the crash of explosions and the howl of falling bombs, Denny grabbed Lilith's hand. They needed no words. They ran.

They made for the place where the fence had been partly destroyed by an earlier bombardment, toward a heap of broken bricks and barbed wire hanging in ragged strips. The Krauts fired at those trying to escape. The children moved in short bursts, now falling, now pressing themselves to the ground as shells howled overhead. Adrenaline kept Denny from feeling pain as he tore his hands bloody, forcing the barrier apart. At last he made an opening. Lilith was stunned by an explosion, but they did not give up. They squeezed through, their torn clothes catching on the rusty barbs, and emerged on the other side into a field pocked with craters.

They ran without looking back, racing beneath the scorching sky. Each flash of a shell seemed like fireworks in celebration of freedom.

For the next few days, they hid in the ruins, trembling at every rustle. Then came silence - not the silence of peace, but of watchful waiting. It gave way to the thunder of a different artillery, not from the sky but from the ground, with close, deafening volleys.

They pressed together in the basement of a burned-out house and waited. Then they heard people speaking in an unfamiliar language, a little harsh, yet somehow so kind. Rescue had come. Soviet soldiers had liberated the city. People wept with joy as they came out to welcome their liberators.

They emerged from their hiding place hand in hand and saw a new world. German "Tigers" no longer rolled through the streets; now there were square green tanks with red stars. From the backs of trucks, weary, stern soldiers in greatcoats handed out hard biscuits from captured supplies. The air smelled of smoke, dust - and, strangely, hope.

They followed the familiar route through the mutilated streets toward Denny's home. At first, he did not recognize it. Or rather, he remembered the place itself: the flower garden where lilacs had grown, the stone bench by the entrance. But the house was gone. In its place gaped a black maw of charred beams, heaps of brick, and roof tiles. Everything left of his childhood, his memories of his father and mother, the carefree life of a little boy with a kind heart - all of it had become a pile of rubble.

Denny stood staring, unable to move. It seemed that his last stronghold, his last connection to the past, had fallen.

Then Lilith silently pointed somewhere.

He followed her finger. In the chaos of the wreckage, a little way off, he saw a dark opening. The cellar. A half-buried staircase led down to it. They descended carefully. Inside, it smelled of damp, smoke, and cold stone. Beams of light squeezed through gaps in the rubble, picking out familiar shapes from the darkness: the stove alcove, part of a wall. Then Denny saw it - a brick ledge running up into the structure above.

Part of the old chimney. The very same flue with its ash pit. He stepped closer and laid his palm against the rough, cold surface. He saw more than a piece of a stove. It was a sign: the last fragment of the past that had not only survived, but offered itself as a foundation for the future and a warm hope.

In the damp, dark pit, among the ashes of everything he had loved, Denny felt something for the first time in a long while - not fear, not despair, but a quiet, unshakable certainty. There was a roof over their heads. Even underground, it was a chance to survive. The cellar and the chimney that had endured were more than shelter. They had become a promise from fate itself: "You have made it through your trials. Now you can warm yourself at your own hearth."

Lilith sat against the wall, hugging her knees, and went still. She had barely spoken for days. Since the shell had exploded nearby and left her concussed, she shook at night and stared at one spot in

silence during the day. She had stopped eating. She drank only water, and even that with difficulty.

Denny paced. He had to do something. His hands had to keep moving, or his head would explode.

He went outside, among the rubble where the few things left of their former life lay scattered. He found a dented tin mug, a plate with a chipped edge that had somehow survived, and a rusty pot without a handle. He carried them down to the cellar and stacked them in a corner. Then he gathered sticks - burnt, damp, but at least there were some - and laid them beside the stove alcove.

He arranged them neatly, like a stack of firewood, the way his father had taught him: “Firewood likes order, son. It burns better when it stands in formation.”

Father.

Denny froze for a moment, pressed his forehead against the cold brick of the chimney, and suddenly remembered.

His mother. A few days before everything had fallen apart, she had taken him down to this very cellar. It had been cleaner and drier then, though it still smelled damp. She moved a box, reached behind the brickwork near the ash pit, and pulled out a small bundle wrapped in oiled cloth.

“If anything happens to me,” she had said quietly, “there’s something here. For a rainy day. Remember this place, Denny. And don’t tell anyone.”

He had not asked what was inside. He was not interested. He had simply remembered.

Now he cleared the ash from the base of the chimney. His fingers found a gap between the bricks, then reached farther, deeper. Something lay in the darkness. He pulled out the bundle. The cloth had rotted at the edges, but inside…

Documents. Two envelopes - letters, probably.

And jewelry.

He tipped it into his palm: gold earrings with green stones - his mother's. He remembered her wearing them on special occasions. A fine, delicate chain with a tiny diamond in the pendant. And most important of all, his father's wedding ring: broad, matte, warm to the touch.

There was his father's beloved watch, too, heavy, with a worn leather strap and a yellowed dial. Denny pressed it to his cheek. The hands had stopped. But the thing itself was real, solid.

He tucked everything inside his shirt. The cold metal seared his skin.

Lilith sat where he had left her, eyes closed, her breathing barely visible.

"I'll be right back," Denny said. "You wait here. Just wait."

She nodded. Or perhaps he only imagined that she did.

He ran out into the street. His legs were weak and buckling from hunger, but he kept going. One name beat in his head: Günter. The accountant, an Austrian who had worked with his father. He had never seemed cruel, only fussy and forever trying to please. Denny remembered him visiting his mother once, when she had traded the family's silverware for food. The Austrian might still be in the city. He might be able to help.

The door did not open at once. The man peered out, recognized Denny, and his face twitched - perhaps with fear, perhaps with disgust.

"What is it, boy? Why have you come?"

"Lilith," Denny gasped. "She's dying. She's ill. She won't eat or speak. Please help. I'll pay."

He pulled the earrings from inside his shirt and pressed them into Günter's hand. The gold glinted even in the gray light of the overcast day. The man swallowed.

"Come in."

The room smelled of sour cabbage and tobacco. Günter sat Denny on a stool, then sat across from him, turning the jewelry over in his fingers. His eyes grew oily and bright.

“Good earrings,” he said. “Real gold. Where did you get them?”

“They were my mother’s.”

“I see… Listen, boy. I know of a place in a neighboring town, an hour away. A children’s home. There’s a nurse, they feed the children, even teach them something. A roof over their heads, warmth. But they don’t take anyone for free. You have to pay.”

“I’ll pay.” Denny clenched what he had left in his pocket. “Will the earrings be enough?”

The accountant narrowed his eyes as he weighed the gold in his palm.

“For a start, yes. But for them to keep her there for long… no. We’ll need more.”

“I’ll bring her,” Denny blurted out, holding out a pendant on a chain. “And you… you’ll look after her? Take her there?”

“Bring her. That’ll be enough now,” Günter said, looking at the jewelry. “If I’m not here, I’ll leave the room key under the doormat. I’ll take care of everything.”

Denny shot out of the house. He raced back, stumbling and gasping, his heart pounding: “I’ll make it. I’ll make it. I’ll make it.”

Lilith was still sitting in the same place. She had not even tried to stand. Denny sat beside her and took her cold hands in his.

“Listen,” he said firmly. “I found someone who’ll help you. There’s a children’s home in the next town - a good, warm place where they feed you. You’ll be taken there. You’ll get better. Do you understand?”

She looked at him for a long, long time. Then she slowly nodded.

Denny lifted her into his arms. She was as light as a bird, almost weightless. All the way to Günter’s, she said nothing. She only rested her cheek against Denny’s shoulder, and he felt her body tremble.

The door was locked. Denny knocked. Silence. He knocked again, louder. No one answered. He took the key from under a floorboard, carried Lilith into the room, laid her on the narrow bed, and covered her with a tattered blanket. Lilith opened her eyes and looked at him.

Denny swallowed. His throat tightened until he could hardly breathe.

“I’ll wait for you,” he said.

She nodded. Her eyes were utterly exhausted, but for her sake he was ready to do anything. Denny bent down and kissed her forehead - quickly, barely touching it - then left.

On the porch, he sank onto a step. Tears streamed down his face. He could not feel them; all he noticed was their salty taste on his lips. He did not want Lilith to see.

She must not see this.

How long had he sat there - a minute, an hour? He did not know. The sound of footsteps brought him back.

“She’s in there,” Denny said without turning around. “Lilith. I brought her.”

Günter froze, then hurried inside. Denny stayed where he was. A minute later, the man came out with a worried, businesslike expression.

“It’s a serious case,” he said, looking somewhere over Denny’s head. “Too far gone. She needs more than a children’s home; she needs a doctor, urgently. And that costs money.”

He fell silent, then turned his gaze to Denny.

“And what about you? Are you still alive?”

Denny shook his head.

“I haven’t eaten in a long time.”

Günter nodded, as if he had heard exactly what he expected.

“There you are,” he sighed. “You’re out of strength, and her life is hanging by a thread. Of course I’ll help, but…” He paused. “What

you gave me will cover a long stay. But the doctor… the doctor will cost more."

Denny understood. Günter was dragging it out, squeezing him for more because he knew the boy would not refuse.

Denny took out his father's ring. It was heavy and warm, the last thing he owned that was truly valuable. He held it out. The man took it, slipped it into his pocket, and nodded once.

"I'll take care of everything."

Denny stood. His knees trembled. He took one step, then another, and wandered away.

He walked without knowing where he was going. His legs carried him back to the cellar, to the chimney, to the pile of sticks he had stacked so carefully. All that remained in his pocket was his father's watch - and nothing else. No food. No warmth. No hope.

He was almost back at the ruins when someone called out:

"Hey, kid!" A voice with a strong accent.

Denny looked up. A group of soldiers in gray greatcoats stood there, red stars on their caps. One of them, young and freckled, stepped away from the others, came over, and crouched down.

"You look green, kid," he asked, half his words in Russian, though Denny understood him. "When did you last get some grub?"

Denny shook his head.

The soldier rummaged in his kit bag, pulled out a can of meat stew, and put it in the boy's hands. Then he took out a large, hard gingerbread cake that smelled of honey.

"Here. Take it. And this…"

He rolled a thick cigarette from a scrap of newspaper and held it out with a grin.

"Shag tobacco. Want a smoke? Warm you up."

Denny looked at the cigarette, then raised his eyes.

"Do you have matches?" he asked. "I've got nothing to light a fire with."

The soldier smiled broadly, almost like a child. He took out a box of matches and tossed it to Denny.

“Here, brother. Live.”

Then he went on, back to his comrades.

Denny went down into the cellar and sat on the cold floor. He laid out the can, the treat, the matches, and his father’s watch in front of him. He stared at them for a long time. Then he took the gingerbread and bit into it. Warm, sweet, so real it made him dizzy. He chewed without taking his eyes off the watch face. The hands had stopped, but he could almost hear them ticking.

He placed the watch on the brick ledge beside the chimney. He struck a match and held it to the dry birch bark he had stacked earlier. The fire caught at once, bright and hungry.

Denny watched the flames. Somewhere, in a strange room, on a strange bed, Lilith was lying. She would have a doctor, a roof over her head, and hope for the future.

And he had only this fire - and a feeling as vast as the sky: he had done everything right. Once again, he had given away the last of what he had. Once again, he was left with nothing.

The fire crackled. His father’s watch lay beside it.

Denny leaned his back against the warm brick, closed his eyes, and for the first time in many days fell into a dreamless sleep.

For three years, this fire kept him warm, and later it warmed others who came to him.

Now, looking into the fire in the hearth, Denny understood the terrible truth: when you do good for others, you should not expect to be repaid in kind. And those you once saved from the cold, gave shelter to, and shared warmth and bread with around a common hearth may decide that you are no longer wanted and throw you back into the darkness.

“Denny.” The voice behind him was hoarse and unfamiliar.

Someone coughed and shifted their weight.

Denny did not turn. He kept looking into the flames.

“I understand,” he breathed quietly.

Silence behind him. Then someone sobbed, but said nothing. The fire flickered.

He did not wait for them to say it aloud. He already knew. All he could do now was step once more into the December haze and leave the cellar that had been his home forever.

Denny gathered his belongings, adjusted the firewood in the hearth so it would burn more evenly, took several boxes of matches, slipped a couple of books into his bag, glanced at his father’s watch, and left in silence.

Chapter 2

December 1948

The bar door opened, releasing a cloud of warm, smoke-filled air and the low murmur of voices.

The man who stepped outside seemed made for the season - solid and sturdy as the frost that day. He looked about forty-five, broad-shouldered, with soft lines in his face that held the memory of all he had lived through.

There was a calm, assured elegance about him: a dark gray Chesterfield coat, the most fashionable style that season, with a velvet collar that darkened softly where it folded. His hat of heavy cloth sat at a slight angle; he had put it on that way. A long, dark scarf hung unevenly, one end almost reaching his waist, the other barely covering his neck. On his feet were heavy black Oxfords, worn in but polished to a shine.

“Ah, winter!” he said to himself.

The weather was magnificent. The temperature was close to thirty degrees below zero, snow crunched underfoot, and the sunset was flaring crimson. The city of N. was going about its evening life.

The man pushed away from the door and set off along the cobblestones. He walked steadily and confidently, though he swayed a little after his visit to the bar. The world around him seemed a little kinder, and his thoughts a little slower. He was in no hurry to get home. He liked walking this way, alone, listening to the crunch of snow beneath his Oxfords and watching the day slowly sink behind the rooftops.

After a couple of streets, he turned toward the waterfront and continued along the old quarter. It was quieter here; the streetlamps were farther apart, and the houses stood closer together, keeping other people’s lives hidden behind their walls.

Ahead, beyond an archway, a half-ruined courtyard stood dark - a reminder of the bombings the city had not yet managed to repair.

Then a girl ran out of the gloom.

She was about fifteen, thin, wearing a shabby little coat. Her red hair was tousled, and tears streamed down her face. She ran up to the man, grabbed his sleeve, and gasped between breaths:

“There! There! My sister! Help her, please!”

His protective instinct moved faster than thought. He was the sort of man who could never walk past someone asking for help. War, the streets, his youth - all of it had forged a habit in him: when someone vulnerable was in trouble, you had to be there.

“Where?” he snapped, already turning.

“There!” The girl pointed toward the archway and ran back the way she had come.

He ran after her.

The alley led to the arch. The old courtyard, choked with broken bricks and charred boards, was a dead end.

The scene before him sent adrenaline surging through his body.

A tall young man of about nineteen, with a long scar running from his lower lip to his chin, was holding another girl. He clamped one hand over her mouth and used the other to tear at her trousers. She struggled, making muffled sounds and scratching at him, but she was thin and weak beside the big brute.

“Hey, you scum!” the man roared, his deep voice making the walls tremble. “Let her go!”

He advanced, something ferocious in his voice. The scarred young man turned, saw the approaching figure, and let the girl go. The sisters darted aside at once and disappeared into the darkness.

The man came within striking distance. The young man did not back away. He stood there, grinning and looking brazenly into the man’s eyes.

“You’re in trouble now, old man.”

Then footsteps sounded behind him. The man turned. A second attacker stood ten paces away, stocky and solid, blocking the exit. He held a bed rail in his hand - heavy iron, bent at the end.

The man was not afraid. He silently assessed the situation. Fear had left him long ago, back in the years he did not like to remember. Something else took its place: cold, calculating, animal. The adrenaline burned the last of the alcohol out of his system. His mind cleared; his fingers curled into fists.

He judged the distance and the angle in an instant. A short step forward - and his knuckles hit their target.

The lanky one had not expected it. He seemed used to his victims being afraid. The punch caught him on the cheekbone, expertly thrown, with the man's whole body behind it. The young man fell onto the cobblestones without a sound, barely catching himself with his hands. He was not knocked out, but his knees buckled and his vision blurred.

The man was already turning toward the second attacker.

The stocky one swung the iron rail at his head. The man threw up his left arm to block it - hard, desperate. Iron met bone. The impact numbed his arm at once, all the way to the shoulder. He could no longer use it to punch effectively.

But his right hand was free. A hook from the side, straight to the jaw, thrown with all his anger and force. The man's eyes filled with something ugly, something inhuman.

"Come on, you little pups!" he growled, and there was a promise of retribution in his voice.

The stocky attacker flew into the wall, dropped the iron, and slid down the bricks. He tried to get up, but his body would not obey; he was badly dazed. The lanky one, however, sprang to his feet, rushed up from behind, and looped an arm around the man's neck, hanging on. The man jerked to throw him off, but he held on with a death grip. Then someone grabbed the man's legs.

A third.

The man had not seen him. He had been standing in the shadows with his back to the wall, waiting for his moment. Slim and wiry, he wore a worn eight-panel cap tilted to one side. Something strange showed in his eyes - not fear, not anger, but a hidden, bitter resolve.

He wrapped both arms around the man's legs and yanked. The man crashed onto the cobblestones. The third attacker would not let go; he clung on tight. The lanky one tried to hit the man from above, but his blows were too weak. The man shielded himself and answered with short, straight punches from below.

The stocky one got up and staggered toward the archway.

The fight was turning against them. The man was like a rock: they hit him, and he barely seemed to feel it. Experience, anger, stamina - he was not going to lose to a few street kids.

The lanky one realized he could not win this way and reached into the pocket of his torn coat.

Steel flashed in the darkness.

A knife. Long, like the kind the Germans bought for themselves.

The man caught the first strike and seized the attacker's wrist, but his fingers slipped and the weapon stayed with his opponent. He did not see the second lunge. The blade flew straight toward his eye - fast, inevitable, deadly.

At the last moment, the raised knife jerked sideways.

The slim one - the same attacker who had been holding the man's legs - suddenly let go with one hand, surged upward, and caught his accomplice's forearm…

The blade only grazed the man's ear. A hot, painful cut, but not a fatal one.

Everyone froze.

The courtyard fell so quiet they could hear snow sliding from the eaves.

The lanky attacker shot his accomplice an angry, bewildered look. The one in the eight-panel cap stared off to the side, still gripping the other man's forearm with a death grip.

He quickly let go of the would-be victim's legs.

The lanky one jerked free, yanked away the knife, and jumped back. From the archway, the stocky one - who had already managed to disappear through it - gave a short, urgent whistle.

"Let's go!" the lanky one shouted.

The three disappeared into the dark passage.

The man was left lying on the cobblestones. He lay with his arms spread, looking at the narrow strip of sky between the brick ruins. He was breathing hard; that kind of "workout" after the bar was catching up with him. His ear burned, and warm blood ran down his neck. The forearm he had used to block the blow was swollen and would not move properly.

But he was smiling.

Foolishly, boyishly, just at the corners of his mouth.

"Just like the old days," he thought.

Suddenly, he remembered something of his own, something distant from the life that had ended many years ago. Courtyards, fights, first enemies and first friends. And the boy who had once...

The thought broke off. He did not try to finish it.

He lay there a little longer, then sat up, felt the wound, and winced. He stood, leaning on the wall with his good arm. He brushed off his coat, picked up his hat, and pulled it down over his head. He balled up his scarf and pressed it to his ear.

Then he walked on.

Behind him lay the dark courtyard, the marks of the struggle in the snow, and the strange boy in the eight-panel cap who had knocked a deadly blow aside at the last moment.

The man walked along the waterfront, thinking. He noted how well the boys had planned it: the girls, the cry for help, the ambush, three against one. Clever. Professional. They had thought of almost everything.

Almost.

They had not counted on the well-dressed man in a five-hundred-mark coat being more than a “victim” - on his having lived through a war, been raised by the streets, and gone through a great deal more than those punks should ever know.

He also wondered about the third boy. The one in the eight-panel cap, with that unusual look in his eyes - no despair, no anger. And the watch with the worn strap, which he had noticed when the boy saved him.

Why had the boy turned against his accomplices? Why?

The man stopped beneath a streetlamp, threw away the bloodied scarf, and used a handkerchief to dab at the wound. He looked at the crimson stains and gave a wry smile.

“Miracles,” he said aloud.

Denny came out of the cellar and stopped. Darkness had gathered around him; only a few streetlamps cast yellow patches on the snow. He knew he had done the right thing. He could not let that man be killed. Not because the man was good or bad - Denny simply did not want to become a murderer.

But that certainty quickly faded in the cold of the December night.

He needed somewhere to sleep. Somewhere permanent, where he would not freeze in his sleep. Denny headed toward the neighboring building. The entrance door stood ajar; its lock was broken.

He went inside.

It smelled of cats and something else, something sour. The stairwell was dim. A faint light came from the landing above, on the second floor. The only residents rarely turned the lamp off before midnight, which meant the entrance would be relatively peaceful. Denny crouched beside the radiator - cold, of course - leaned his back against the wall, and closed his eyes. He needed to think.

The railway station. They always needed porters there. He could earn a little money to start with, and then perhaps he would find a

corner somewhere. Denny opened his eyes, felt for his bag of books and documents in the dark, checked his father's watch on his wrist, and decided: first he would hide his things here, under the stairs; then he would go and scout around.

He tucked his few belongings into the farthest corner, behind a pile of old rags, and left the entrance.

At that very moment, a man stepped in from the street.

Denny moved aside and held the heavy door for the stranger. Lost in his thoughts, he kept looking out at the dark street and simply waited for the man to pass.

But the man stopped.

He saw the eight-panel cap - the same worn one, tilted to one side. And the watch on the hand resting on the door handle. Heavy, with a worn leather strap. The very watch he had seen when the boy saved him from the knife.

"Hello, kid," the man said.

His voice was calm, even kind. Denny raised his head.

A second later, he recognized him: the cut ear, the small scrapes on his face, the confident posture. Denny's insides tightened. He stepped back into the entrance, feverishly calculating how to escape. He found no way out; the man was blocking the door.

The stranger gave a tired, almost warm smile.

"Don't be afraid, son. I won't hurt you. I didn't expect to see you here."

Denny let out a breath. They went out into the street together. Neither of them said a word, but the silence did not feel heavy. The boy sensed that no one was going to beat him. "Strange," he thought, almost aloud.

"Are you hungry?" The question broke the silence. "Come on. I'll get you something to eat."

Denny hesitated. On one hand, it was dangerous. On the other, he had no strength left, and his stomach had been cramping with hunger for a long time.

The stranger held out his hand. It was large and strong, with knotted fingers.

“Viktor Andreevich.”

Denny looked at the hand, then at the man’s face. There was something in his appearance, in his eyes, that Denny suddenly trusted. Maybe it was because he had no other choice. Or maybe his instincts simply did not warn him of danger.

He took the man’s hand.

“Denny,” he said.

Viktor Andreevich nodded and walked ahead. Denny followed.

The little diner was on the next street. Inside, it smelled of fried onions, fresh bread, and something warm and homelike. Denny had not been inside a place like this since he was little. He had often passed by and looked through the windows at people sitting at tables, but he had never actually gone in.

He perched on the edge of a chair, afraid to move. Viktor Andreevich called over a waitress.

The waitress was an older woman in a white apron. Viktor ordered soup, a main course, and fruit soda.

“While we wait,” he said, turning to the boy, “let’s get to know each other a little better.”

Denny tensed.

“Do you live in that building?” Viktor asked.

“No,” Denny said curtly.

Viktor realized the boy was on edge. He did not insist or press him. He simply sat across from him, giving Denny time to get used to him.

The soup arrived. It was hot and rich, with pieces of meat in it. Denny stared at the bowl, hardly believing his eyes.

“Eat,” Viktor said, sliding it toward him.

Denny picked up the spoon. His hand was shaking. The first mouthful burned his tongue, but he barely noticed; hunger

drowned everything else out. He ate quickly and greedily, hardly chewing, and only out of the corner of his eye did he catch Viktor watching him with a sad, understanding smile.

When he had finished the soup, the main course arrived: potatoes and meat under a thick gravy. Denny polished it off in a couple of minutes.

Viktor called the waitress over.

“Bring him a little cake as well. Or a sweet bun, something like that. For the boy.”

Denny froze. A cake from a shop? He had never tried one. When he was little, his mother sometimes spoiled him with homemade shortcakes, but something store-bought… He had stolen little pies at the market and pinched candies from kiosks, but a cake seemed to belong to another world.

When the waitress set down a saucer with a little sponge cake covered in chocolate icing, Denny felt his eyes sting. He blinked quickly to hide the weakness. The tragedies of life no longer moved him, but moments of kindness like this still made him sentimental.

The cake was incredible. It melted in his mouth, leaving a sweet, delicate aftertaste. Denny ate it slowly, savoring every bite, then licked the spoon.

Viktor watched him. Something warm, almost fatherly, flickered in his gaze.

“Are you full?” he asked, tilting his head slightly.

Denny nodded. A pleasant warmth spread through his stomach, and an unfamiliar lightness through his mind.

“Then we can talk.” The man moved his empty plate aside and rested his elbows on the table, fingers interlaced. “Listen, I had some business in that building. What were you doing there?”

Denny hesitated. Should he tell the truth or lie? Viktor looked at him calmly, without the slightest pressure.

“Keeping warm,” Denny admitted at last.

“Do you go there often to warm up?”

"Sometimes."

Viktor kept studying him closely, not looking away.

"Do you know any of the people who live there?"

Denny grew wary. The questions seemed strange, but the fear that had gripped his chest not long ago was fading. Viktor's voice was even and kind; there was nothing in it that made Denny want to curl up into a ball.

"Only the old people on the second floor are still there," Denny said. "They lived there throughout the war."

Viktor brightened and leaned forward.

"Maybe they know who survived from the house next door, the one that was destroyed? Or did you see anything yourself?"

Denny's eyes widened. The destroyed house next door. His house.

"I knew a boy from there," he blurted out, surprising himself with the lie. "We went to school together."

The words came out before he had time to think. Something inside him gave a twitch.

"Where is he now?" Viktor asked. "His parents? His family?"

Denny grew nervous. His palms were sweating; he wiped them discreetly on his trousers.

"People said…" He swallowed. "They said the fascists killed his father. And the boy and his mother were sent to a camp. But it's only rumors. People talk in the street."

Viktor sighed. There was so much weariness in the sound that Denny suddenly wanted to tell him the truth.

But he did not know how. Or whether he should.

"I'm so sorry," the man said, his face darkening. "I hoped they might still be alive."

He fell silent, looking out the window. Behind the glass, a few pedestrians passed; every now and then, a cyclist rode by. Denny sat quietly, holding his breath. Questions tangled together in his

mind: Who was this man? What did he want? Why was he looking for his family?

Viktor paid, leaving several bills on the table. They went outside.

The freezing air stung Denny's face, and he squeezed his eyes shut.

Viktor stepped toward him and held out his hand.

"Thank you, Denny. I owe you."

The boy was embarrassed, but returned the handshake firmly, like a man. Only when their fingers parted did he discover several crumpled bills in his palm. Denny stared at the money in surprise, then looked at Viktor.

"Why are you looking for that family?" he blurted out. "I can help find out."

Viktor began walking slowly down the street. Denny fell into step beside him, listening to the snow crunch under their feet. A woman with a basket passed them and glanced back, but Viktor did not notice.

"I came here on business," Viktor said only after a long pause. "I'm looking for my missing sister and her child. She used to write to me, but I couldn't bring them away. I didn't read the letters until after the war, when they finally reached me. The last ones stop at the end of 1945. Since then, there's been no word."

Viktor spoke vaguely, without naming where he had been or what work he had done. But there was something in his voice that made Denny's heart ache - a familiar, understandable pain.

Denny thought. His mother had no brothers. Or had he simply never known? They never talked about relatives at home.

"What was her name?" he could not help asking.

"Tamara," Viktor replied. "In your language, Toma. She wrote that she worked in that house."

Denny stopped. His ears began to ring.

Toma. Lilith.

Viktor turned around, studying the boy's suddenly pale face with concern.

"What's wrong, kid?"

Denny could not answer. He only stared at Viktor, eyes wide and full of tears. Then the words poured out. He could not stop them or hold them back.

He told Viktor everything: how Toma had read him the Bible in the evenings; how they had lived in the barracks; how she had been killed in the camp; how he and Lilith had escaped together, hidden among the ruins, and trembled at every rustle; how they had found the cellar. How he had taken the girl to Günter, giving away the last of what he had - his mother's jewelry, his father's ring, every last coin. How he had searched for her afterward, but Günter had disappeared and the neighbors only kept saying he had left.

Now Denny did not know whether Lilith was alive, where she was, or whether he would ever find her.

He spoke and cried without shame, without trying to hide it. The words tumbled over one another, tangled and confused, while Viktor listened without interrupting. His expression grew more and more serious, and something flickered in his eyes - as if at last he had found the right path.

When Denny fell silent, Viktor came closer and hugged him. He held him tight, man to man, squeezing so hard it took Denny's breath away.

"Thank you," the man said, a faint rasp catching in his voice. "Thank you, son."

He drew back and looked at Denny, his eyes damp. Snowflakes melted on his stern, stubbled cheeks. Denny sniffed and wiped his tear-streaked face with his sleeve. Meeting Viktor's eyes felt awkward, but he did not want to look away.

"Where are you living now?" Viktor asked, breaking the silence.

"Since yesterday? Nowhere," Denny admitted. "They… threw me out."

The man nodded as if he had expected that. There was not a trace of surprise or judgment in his face. Only understanding.

“Then that’s settled,” he said. “I’m renting an apartment nearby. There’s a room, a couch, a bed. You can stay with me for now. We’ll figure out the rest later.”

Denny stared at him, unable to believe it. After everything that had happened, after his own people had thrown him out, a stranger - almost a complete stranger - was inviting him to share a roof. Just like that. No conditions. No promises.

“Can I?” His voice was uncertain.

“You can,” Viktor said simply.

They walked on together: a tall, sturdy man in an expensive coat and a skinny boy in a battered jacket. In Denny’s pocket, his father’s watch “ticked.” Its hands had long since stopped, but Denny felt they were still counting the time - the time of a new life that had only just begun.

Chapter 3

Viktor's apartment was on the second floor of an old building near the railway station. It had two rooms: a bedroom and a living room with a kitchen area, where the air smelled of tobacco, yesterday's cabbage soup, and the unfamiliar flavor of someone else's life.

Denny froze in the doorway, not knowing what to do with himself. Everything looked too… neat. A table covered with newspaper. A bookcase with its books lined up evenly. A desk lamp with a green shade. And a sofa.

It seemed enormous, with a high back and bolsters at either end. Viktor pointed to it.

"This is your space. The bedding's in the wardrobe; make the bed yourself."

Denny nodded but did not move. He stared at the sofa. Sleep on that? Alone? On something soft? He could not even remember the last time he had slept in a bed. It felt like another life.

Viktor went into the bedroom and closed the door. Denny stood still for another minute, then cautiously approached the sofa on tiptoe. He touched the upholstery. Soft. Warm. It smelled of fabric, a little dust, and tobacco smoke.

He sat down. The springs creaked, but did not give way. He leaned back and closed his eyes.

Then he began to tremble. Not from the cold - from something else. From the fact that he could simply sit on a soft sofa.

He stayed that way for about ten minutes. Then he stood, found a sheet, a pillow, and a blanket in the wardrobe, and made the bed. Carefully, the way Toma had taught him: "Make the corners even, Denny. Order is a way of respecting yourself."

He undressed. He looked at the bed, then at himself, and froze.

His hands were dark, with black rims beneath his fingernails. Dirt was ground into his elbows. His legs were streaked with soot

that seemed to have worked its way into his skin for good. He sniffed himself and grimaced. He smelled of the cellar, smoke, sweat, and stale damp - the smell of someone who hadn't had a proper wash in three years.

Denny looked again at the white sheet and pillow, at the blanket that smelled fresh, perhaps even of starch. He could not bring himself to lie down.

Carefully, he took an old throw from the armchair and spread it on the floor. He put his rolled-up jacket beneath his head and lay down.

It was familiar. Hard, but familiar. He curled into a ball, pulled the throw up to his ears, and closed his eyes.

In the silence, he could hear the clock ticking in the room beyond the wall.

How long he lay there - a minute, an hour? - Denny could not tell.

Then the door creaked. Viktor came out of the bedroom, apparently looking for cigarettes. He glanced at the sofa and took another step… then stopped.

The boy was on the floor, curled up, pretending to be asleep. Viktor's gaze moved from the empty, neatly made bed to the dark shape on the floor, as if he could not understand why the sofa was empty.

"Hey, soldier," he called softly.

Denny froze. His eyelashes fluttered, but he kept his eyes shut.

"I can see you're not asleep," Viktor said with a wry smile. "Come on, tell me. Was it too soft for your lordly back?"

Denny reluctantly sat up and wrapped his arms around his knees.

"It was fine," he muttered, looking away.

"Then why are you on the floor? Habit?"

"No…" He paused, pointing his chin toward the bed. "I… the bedding… It's… too clean. White. And I…"

He could not finish.

Viktor sighed - not angrily, but with a mixture of weariness and warmth.

“All right,” he said. “Get up. We’re going.”

“Where?”

“We’ll get you washed. At this rate, you’ll be lying there until morning, and then I’ll feel guilty for making my guest sleep on the floor.”

Denny jumped up, then hesitated.

“I can do it myself… in the morning…”

“Morning will be busy,” Viktor cut in. “Besides, there’s no need to put it off. Come on.”

He led the boy to the bathroom, a small room with a cast-iron tub and a copper faucet. He flicked on the light, set a large kettle on the stove, and took a basin and a dipper from under the sink.

“The hot water doesn’t always work here,” he explained. “But I’ll heat some now. Get undressed and fill the tub with cold water in the meantime.”

Denny stood frozen in the doorway.

“What are you waiting for?” Viktor turned around.

“I… well…” Denny shifted from one foot to the other.

Viktor took in his hesitation, then suddenly burst out laughing.

“What, are you afraid to wash? Seriously? You made it through a camp, and now you’re scared of water?”

“I’m not scared,” Denny said, offended. “I just… I can’t remember the last time I lay in a bathtub.”

Viktor stopped laughing and grew serious.

“Then tonight you’ll remember. Go on, get undressed. No need to be shy. I’ll have a smoke while you do.”

He stepped out and pulled the door closed behind him. Denny was alone.

He took off his clothes and stood naked in the cramped room, studying himself in the cloudy mirror. Thin, pale, ribs showing; dark streaks on his legs, and healed scrapes on his arms that had left uneven marks. He sniffed his armpit and grimaced. Well…

Viktor knocked.

"The kettle's boiled. Open up!"

Denny slipped his hand through the narrow gap. The man passed him the hot kettle and chuckled.

"Hiding like a proper young lady! Scrub yourself until you squeak, you hear? I'll check. There's a towel on the hook."

Denny closed the door again and diluted the boiling water. He filled the dipper and poured it over his shoulders - and almost began to cry. He poured hot water over himself and watched dirty rivulets run down his body.

"Here, take the soap!" A bar of laundry soap appeared through the half-open door.

Denny soaped himself. The foam stung his eyes and got up his nose, but he scrubbed and scrubbed until his skin began to burn. Then he rinsed himself again.

How much time had passed was impossible to tell. Viktor had already walked by about three times, coughing softly, but had said nothing. At last, he could not wait any longer and knocked.

"You alive in there?"

"Yeah," came the reply from inside.

"Haven't drowned, have you? I'm putting on the third kettle."

"Just a minute," Denny answered apologetically.

He climbed out of the tub, dried himself with an enormous towel, and turned to the mirror. A stranger looked back at him from the cloudy glass: clean, rosy-cheeked, with wet hair and something like happiness shining in his eyes.

Denny smiled at his reflection.

"Hello," he whispered.

When he returned to the living room wrapped in a towel and clutching his dirty trousers in one fist, Viktor was sitting in the kitchen, smoking by the open window. The man whistled.

“Well, look at that - a new person has been born!”

Denny blushed, mumbled something about underwear, and hurried to the sofa. He put on the clothes Viktor had given him: an old undershirt and a pair of knit pants. They were three sizes too big, but clean.

He smoothed the sheet with his hands again. Carefully, he lay down and fell asleep the moment his head touched the pillow. The bed smelled fresh. For the first time in years, his skin did not itch with dirt, and the warmth of a home sent him to sleep at once.

In the middle of the night, an icy chill seized him.

He was running barefoot through the snow, sinking in up to his ankles. Ahead, Lilith’s figure flickered. She turned, waved, called to him, but he could not catch up. His legs dragged through the snow; the white depths grew deeper, turning into sticky, icy slush. Sirens howled around him, shells exploded, but the sound was muffled, as if coming from underwater.

He cried, “Lilith!” - and woke at the sound of his own shout.

Denny sat up in bed, trying to catch his breath. His heart hammered; his shirt clung to his back. He looked around: the table, the lamp with the green shade… He was confused. For a few seconds, he struggled to understand. He was here, in the apartment. Viktor’s apartment.

Everything was all right.

He slid to the floor, rested his sweaty back against the sofa, and sat for a long time staring into the darkness. The door creaked.

Viktor appeared in the doorway, hair tousled, wearing an undershirt and long underwear.

“Nightmares,” he said. It was not a question. He crouched beside Denny and held out a mug of water. “Here.”

Denny took it and drank. His hands were trembling.

“Every night?” Viktor asked.

“I don’t know. I don’t remember my dreams. But this one… this one I remember.”

Viktor nodded, sat quietly for a moment, then heaved himself to his feet.

“It happens. The first few years were like that for me too…” He waved a hand. “Wash your face. You’ll feel better.”

The man went away but left the door ajar. A strip of light came from his room. Denny went to the bathroom, rinsed his face with cold water, then lay down and listened to the quiet. After a while, he slipped into sleep - empty and black this time.

Morning began with Viktor shaking Denny awake before dawn.

“Up, soldier. We’ve got things to do.”

Denny sat up on the sofa, blinking. It was still dark outside. The clock showed half past five.

“Where are we going?” he mumbled, still half asleep.

“I’m going to work. You’ve got an assignment. Listen up.”

Viktor was already dressed and standing in the middle of the room: shirt, suspenders, hair neatly combed. On the table in front of him lay a sheet of paper covered in large, sweeping handwriting.

“First,” Viktor said, “clean out the ash pan, get the stove going, and keep feeding it coal. I want the place warm by evening. Second: wash the floors. The rag’s in the closet; the bucket’s under the sink. Third: wash my shirt and your trousers. The soap’s there too. Fourth: go to the shop and get some bread, milk, and, if they have it, cured pork fat. The money and the list are on the table.”

He paused for breath and gave the boy a stern look.

“Questions?”

Denny blinked.

“Uh… is that all?”

“You want more?” Viktor said with a grin. “You’ve got the whole day. Get it done, and we’ll have a talk tonight. Don’t, and we’ll still have a talk - but it won’t be as pleasant.”

He pulled on his coat, jammed his hat onto his head, and turned back at the door.

“And keep that stove going. Don’t let it die on you.”

The door slammed. Denny was alone.

He sat for a minute, trying to take in the instructions, then jumped up and hurried around the room. Things to do, things to do… He was not used to having them. And there was responsibility now: the stove, the floors, the laundry, the shop…

Denny smiled. Good things to worry about.

He knew how to get the stove going; he had learned in the cellar. He scrubbed the floorboards until they shone. He soaked Viktor’s shirt, rubbed it with soap, rinsed it, and hung it on a line stretched between the wardrobe and the door. Then he ran to the shop.

The place smelled of fresh bread, smoked meat, and sharp spices. Denny stood by the entrance, drawing in the air like a hungry dog, then went up to the counter.

The shopkeeper - a heavyset woman in a grimy apron - looked at him without interest.

“What do you need?”

“I… I need bread, milk, and cured pork fat,” Denny said, reading from the list.

“All right.” She nodded. “How much?”

Denny froze. He had not expected that question. Viktor had told him to buy those things, but had not written down any weights or quantities. Denny looked at the money in his hand, then at the shelves. His eyes darted from one thing to another.

“Bread,” he repeated uncertainly. “A lot.”

“How much is ‘a lot’?” The woman was beginning to sound annoyed.

Then a thought pierced him: What if he was not given any money tomorrow? What if Viktor left or fell ill? He had better stock up. He was used to laying in supplies. In the cellar, you survived by grabbing whatever extra you could; tomorrow, luck might not be on your side.

“Then… give me…” He emptied all the cash onto the counter. “Give me everything this will buy.”

The shopkeeper raised an eyebrow but did not argue. She rattled the weights on the scale, wrapped up about five loaves of bread, cut off a huge slab of cured pork fat, and poured milk into a little churn. She added a few odds and ends as change - Denny could no longer tell what was what. He stood watching the pile of groceries grow, feeling like a rich man.

“It’s heavy,” she warned, handing him the enormous bags.

Denny took them. The shopping was surprisingly heavy. Bent beneath the load, he left the shop and trudged home.

That evening Viktor came home. He took off his coat, hung it over the back of a chair, and walked into the kitchen. He had taken two steps when he stopped.

Loaves of bread were everywhere: on the table, on the windowsill, on a stool. White bread, dark bread, bread with caraway, flour-dusted loaves in paper wrappers and unwrapped ones. Beside them, taking up a good half of the table, was a slab of cured pork fat the size of a small pig. Milk had been poured into three jars lined up in a row, their cloudy glass glinting. From parcels squeezed into the only free corner stuck ring-shaped breads, crisp little rings, and a paper bag that smelled of gingerbread.

Viktor slowly surveyed the plenty, then turned to Denny. The boy stood by the table, his whole face - Viktor noticed at once - glowing with pride and the expectation that he had carried out the assignment brilliantly.

“This…” Viktor faltered, searching for words. “What is all this?”

“Groceries,” Denny said quietly. “You told me to get them. So I did.”

“I told you to buy bread, milk, and pork fat,” Viktor said, spacing out each word as if he were explaining it to a child. “I didn’t tell you to open a branch of the grocery shop in my kitchen.”

“Well…” Denny shifted from one foot to the other. “I spent all the money. So we’d have enough.”

“All the money,” Viktor repeated. He reached into his pocket out of habit, then remembered he had given Denny all the cash that morning, and his hand stopped in midair. He took in the scale of the disaster on the table once more. “Did you buy all the bread in town?”

“Not all of it,” Denny said, sounding offended, though a treacherous smile was already tugging at the corners of his mouth. “They still had some left.”

Viktor watched him in silence. Denny stared at the floor, tense and braced for anything. He was beginning to understand what he had done, and it was getting harder to hold back his laughter.

Viktor stepped toward him. Denny ducked his head and squeezed his eyes shut. But instead of a smack, he felt only a light flick - more symbolic than painful.

“You’re a character,” Viktor said without malice. “Prepared for anything, but not too bright.”

Denny looked up. Viktor studied the bread fortress, the mountain of pork fat, and the little rings. His lips slowly spread into a smile. His shoulders began to shake, and at last he burst out laughing, a deep, hearty laugh.

“Oh, I can’t…” he gasped between laughs. “Five loaves… a slab as big as a log… enough milk for a month… Denny, I can’t decide whether you’re a genius or an idiot!”

Denny felt the tension melt into a warm wave rising in his chest. He smiled - first shyly, then more broadly - and soon he was

laughing too. For the first time in years, he was laughing for no reason beyond a ridiculous, happy moment.

They stood in the middle of the kitchen, surrounded by food, laughing. Viktor held on to the doorframe; Denny gripped the edge of the table. Neither could stop.

“Oh…” Viktor wiped his eyes. “Well, thanks for that. We’ll be eating this for a week. We’ll break our teeth on the stale bread.”

“I didn’t think it through,” Denny admitted, still smiling.

“I can see that.” Viktor glanced at the pork fat and shook his head. “All right, don’t worry. At least we’ll be fed. We can give some to the neighbors. We’ll take a bit to the old ladies on the first floor; they can dry it into rusks.”

He went to the table, cut a thick slice of bread, laid a thin, almost transparent slice of pork fat on top, and crunched into a pickled cucumber from the jar.

“Good,” he said with his mouth full. “You’re a fool, but you know how to pick good pork fat.”

Denny let out a breath. At last, the lightness came back to him. He had not even noticed his shoulders dropping and his fists unclenching.

“I won’t do it again,” he promised.

“You will,” Viktor said with a grin. “But next time, ask me how much to buy.”

“Deal.”

Viktor handed him a generous chunk. Denny took it and bit in. It tasted unbelievably good. The thick layer of fat melted on his tongue; the bread crackled at the crust. It all felt like a luxury he had never dared to dream of.

“That’s how we live,” Viktor concluded, chewing.

Denny nodded, swallowing his bite.

“That really hits the spot,” he said.

That evening they sat by the stove, warming their hands around mugs of tea. Viktor still chuckled now and then as he remembered the sight in the kitchen.

“Five loaves…” he murmured into his mug. “Would you believe it?”

Denny hid a smile and pretended to be absorbed in the view from the window.

“At least they’ll last us a while.”

“That’s for sure,” Viktor agreed. “Unless the mice get to them.”

They laughed again. Outside, snow was falling.

The room was warm, cozy, and simple. As if that were how things were meant to be.

The next day, the lessons began. Viktor stood by the stove in an undershirt and underpants; Denny hovered beside him.

“All right,” Viktor instructed, stirring something in a pot. “Soup is the foundation. The basis of life. Learn to make soup, and you can call yourself a person.”

He spoke with a strong accent, but Denny was used to it by now. Russian words often slipped out of Viktor’s mouth, and Denny had learned a few. *Davai* meant “get started.” *Bystro*, “quickly,” was easy enough to understand. *Khorosho* meant he had done well. *Plokho* meant he had not.

“Watch,” Viktor said, pointing to the potatoes. “Peel them thin, just take off the skin. Don’t chop them up like firewood.”

Denny picked up a knife and a slippery potato. The sharp blade sank easily into the flesh. He ran it along the peel - and cut away a good half of the potato.

“Well…” Viktor drawled. “That’s not peeling; that’s butchering. All right. Try the next one.”

The second potato met the same fate.

“Listen,” Viktor said, taking the knife from him. “Are you peeling that potato or finishing it off? Thinner, thinner!”

“I can’t get it,” Denny muttered, embarrassed.

“People get it done by doing it. Try again, or I’ll give you a slap for not trying.”

By the fifth attempt, Denny had more or less learned to take off only the skin, though he had cut his fingers.

“It’s all right. The first pancake always comes out a mess. You’ll get better.”

“What pancake?” Denny asked, confused.

“It’s a saying. It means you don’t get it right at first, but you learn.” Viktor put an onion in his hand. “Now peel this. And don’t cry.” He gave him an encouraging smile.

Denny got to work. A minute later his eyes were stinging, and tears were streaming down his face.

“It’s all right,” Viktor said, handing him a cloth. “Good for you - it cleanses the soul. Russians say an onion cures seven ailments.”

“Which seven?” Denny sniffed.

“All of them. Keep peeling; don’t get distracted.”

When the onion was chopped - unevenly, in pieces of all different sizes - Viktor showed him how to fry it.

“Oil in the pan, onion goes in. Keep stirring so it doesn’t burn. Got it?”

Denny took the spoon and began. Everything hissed and jumped at once, threatening to leap out of the pan. He stirred so energetically that half the onion ended up on the stove.

“Hey, hold it!” Viktor said, barely managing to pull him back. “Not so fast! Gently, gently!”

“Gently how?” Denny was completely lost.

“Like this.” Viktor showed him slow, smooth movements. “See? It likes a gentle touch.”

The potatoes went into the pot, followed by the fried onion. Viktor let him smell the spices.

“Remember: pepper for heat, bay leaf for fragrance, dill for freshness. Got it?”

Denny nodded, though he had understood only half of it.

When everything was ready, Viktor filled the bowls and handed Denny a spoon.

“Try it.”

Denny tasted the soup. It was scalding hot and a little too salty; the vegetables had gone soft. But it was real soup. His first one. His own.

“It’s good,” he said, surprised.

“Liar,” Viktor said with a grin, tasting it too. “But it’s tolerable for a first try. Keep practicing, and you’ll learn.”

From that day on, cooking became their evening ritual. Denny peeled the vegetables while Viktor called out instructions, sometimes switching into Russian:

“Stir faster! Less salt, you fool! Add water, water!”

Denny picked up new phrases as he went: *bystreye*, “faster”; *menshe*, “less”; *durak*, “fool” - the last one Viktor said without anger, even affectionately. Denny did not take offense.

He also learned *davai*, “come on”; *khorosho*, “good”; *plokho*, “bad”; *yeshchyo*, “more”; *khvatit*, “enough”; *ogon*, “fire”; *voda*, “water” - and, most important of all, *zhrat’*, “get some grub.” When it was time for dinner, Viktor would simply say, “Let’s get some grub.” It sounded so much like home that Denny could not help smiling.

During the day, when Viktor was away, Denny would sit on the sofa, holding his father’s watch and staring at it for a long time. He tried to remember his father’s face, but could not. A clear picture, right down to the wrinkles, would not come. Only a general impression: a stern gaze, gray at the temples, the smell of tobacco and paper. And his mother? Her features blurred even faster.

He would get up and pace the room, angry with himself. How could he have forgotten? He waited for memory to offer him a clue, but it stayed cruelly silent.

After a month, Denny could cook lunch on his own. He could peel vegetables with hardly any waste and had even learned to fry eggs.

"Good job," Viktor said one evening, watching him work at the stove. "There's hope for you."

"Thanks," Denny muttered, stirring the soup.

"And what do you call this?" Viktor asked, pointing to the pot.

"Soup."

"In Russian, *sup*. In German, *Suppe*. In French, *potage*. And in Hungarian?"

"*Leves*," Denny answered.

"*Leves*," Viktor repeated in a terrible accent, and they both laughed.

Denny liked that Viktor taught him more than just how to cook. He told him about different countries and people, and about how important it was to know languages. Sometimes he would slip in a Russian word and make Denny repeat it.

"Come on, say *khleb* - bread."

"*Khleb*," Denny pronounced carefully.

"Good. And *voda* - water?"

"*Vada*."

"Almost. *Voda*. Stress the second syllable."

"*Vodá*," Denny repeated.

Viktor nodded, pleased.

The one thing Denny could not get used to was that there was always food. Whenever he sat down at the table, he braced himself for someone to say, "That's it. Enough. This is the last piece." Again and again, he finished eating and waited for them to take his plate away and throw him out from the table. But that never happened.

Viktor would slide the bread toward him and ask, “Want some more?”

“Why do you freeze up like that?” Viktor asked him one day.

“I don’t know…” Denny hesitated. “I’m used to everything running out so fast. If I don’t eat it right away, there won’t be any left.”

Viktor looked at him for a long moment.

“Listen, kid. Forget that. This isn’t the cellar. I’m here. There’s food, and there will be. Understand?”

“I understand,” Denny nodded.

But he could not break the habit at once. For a long time, he secretly tucked a piece of bread into his pocket when he went outside. Viktor pretended not to notice.

Viktor kept looking for Lilith and the place where his sister had been buried. Denny did not press him with questions. He knew Viktor would tell him if there was any news.

One day, Viktor came home earlier than usual, around three in the afternoon. Denny was just about to leave for some extra work at the bakery. Surprised to see him, he asked:

“What are you doing home so early?”

“Waiting for someone,” Viktor said curtly. “Don’t go out yet.”

Denny sat on the sofa, pretending to read a book while keeping one eye on the door. Viktor paced the room, smoking one cigarette after another and glancing at the clock.

Half an hour later, someone knocked.

A short man in a worn coat came in. Papers stuck out of his briefcase. He took off his hat, greeted them, and went straight to the table.

“I found something,” he said without preamble. “Not everything, but there’s a little.”

Denny tensed. His heart began to beat faster.

The man spread out the papers. Viktor bent over them, frowning.

“Tamara Andreevna,” he read. “All right. She’s on the list. Among the dead.”

Denny froze. The room fell quiet; only the papers rustled in the visitor’s hands.

“Camp N… Second barrack, October. No cause given. It just says she died. The record is there, and it’s authentic. She was buried in a mass grave not far from the barracks, on the outskirts.”

Viktor was silent for a long time. He stared at one spot on the table, then looked toward the window.

“And the girl?” he finally asked. His voice was dull and unfamiliar.

“Nothing on her,” the man said, shaking his head. “There are plenty of children that age on the lists. But there’s no Lilith - or Lily, daughter of Tamara. I haven’t found her yet. Maybe she was entered incorrectly, or… registered under a different surname.”

“Günter?” Viktor looked up.

“I sent inquiries to the neighboring towns, the local offices, and our bureau. Still quiet there, too. If he turns up, we’ll know right away.”

Viktor nodded, took out some money, and paid him. The man gathered his papers and left the apartment.

Denny sat on the sofa, gripping the book so tightly his knuckles went white. He had heard every word.

Viktor came over, sat beside him, and laid a heavy hand on his shoulder.

“Denny…”

“I heard,” Denny interrupted. His voice was hoarse. “She… they haven’t found her?”

“Not yet.”

“And Toma… Aunt Toma…”

“Yes,” Viktor said shortly. “We’ll take her flowers.”

Denny nodded and turned toward the wall. His shoulders tightened, but he said nothing. Viktor sat with him for another minute, then got up and disappeared into his room. Denny stayed on the sofa, staring at the wall without moving. Viktor looked in an hour later; the boy was still frozen in the same position. Two hours later, he was still there.

In the morning, Denny got up and left for work as usual, but he did everything in silence and kept his eyes down. He answered questions with a word or two and did not touch his breakfast.

Viktor did not press him. He knew some things had to be lived through alone. Only that evening, when Denny came back from the bakery, did he say:

“I’m looking. I’ll keep looking. We’ll find her.”

Denny nodded but said nothing. He buried his face in the pillow on his sofa.

For three days he was like a shadow. He walked around and did everything he was told, but inside he seemed locked away. Viktor saw it and did not push. Only once, when the boy had begun to come back to himself a little, did he ask:

“Are you always like this?”

“Like what?” Denny did not understand.

“You shut yourself away.”

Denny took a long time to find the words. Then he let out a breath.

“I can’t talk about her. In my chest… it feels as if everything’s being torn apart. I’d rather keep quiet.”

Viktor nodded. They never brought it up again.

But the search continued.

Sometime near the beginning of September, Viktor announced:

“You’re coming with me tomorrow.”

“Where?” Denny asked warily.

“To school. Evening school. I’ve arranged it.”

The boy was taken aback.

"Why?"

"Because you're seventeen, and you've barely had any schooling. You can read and write, and you can count. What about the rest? You've got a long life ahead of you. You'll need an education."

"I have to work," Denny tried to argue.

"You'll work during the day. You'll study in the evening. I've already decided."

Arguing was pointless. Denny had learned that a long time ago.

The school turned out to be a strange place. The classroom held all sorts: men who had never finished school before the war, women in headscarves, and a few boys older than Denny. Their teacher, an older German woman with an austere face and kind eyes, gave the class a stern look and began the lesson.

Denny sat at a desk, clutching a new notebook and pencil. Beside him, a heavyset man of about thirty snorted softly as he formed his letters, his tongue poking out with concentration.

At first Denny was embarrassed. Grown adults, and there he was sharing a desk with them. But he got used to it. Before long, he even found it interesting. Frau Müller praised him: Denny could do sums quickly in his head, a skill he had picked up back when he attended an ordinary school as a child. Spelling, though, was a struggle.

"That's all right," she told him. "You'll learn. The important thing is that you want to."

In the evenings, Viktor checked his exercise books. He shook his head but never scolded him.

"Your handwriting's chicken scratch," he said with a grin. "But I can make it out. Keep going."

Denny worked during the day.

At first, he worked in a bakery, hauling sacks of flour, washing floors, and cleaning ovens. The pay was low, but fair. Later, through Viktor's acquaintances, he found a job at a small café nearby.

It smelled of fried onions, fresh pastries, and coffee. The owner, an elderly Hungarian man, quickly realized that Denny was a hard worker and trusted him with the dishes. Denny washed plates, cups, and pots in huge tubs of hot water until his skin turned red. He took out the trash, swept the floor, and helped the cooks peel vegetables.

By the end of a shift, his hands cramped and his back ached, but Denny was happy. He clenched his own hard-earned money in his fist, carried it home, and poured it into an old cookie tin. It grew heavier, slowly but steadily.

One evening, when the tin was nearly full, Denny went over to Viktor.

“Here,” he said, emptying a handful of coins and a few crumpled bills onto the table. “This is for the room. And for the food.”

Viktor looked at the money, then at Denny, then back at the table.

“What is this?” he said, sounding neither quite as if he were asking nor quite as if he were telling him off.

“I earned it,” Denny said, swallowing. “You feed me, give me something to drink, and put a roof over my head. I have to pay.”

Viktor was silent for a long time. His eyes held a strange mixture of surprise and pride.

“Listen to me, kid,” he said at last. “You’re no relation of mine. Not by blood. But I didn’t bring you home so you could pay me for the roof over your head. I brought you because you saved my niece. You gave everything you had for her. And now you want to put a few pennies in my hand?”

“But I have to,” Denny insisted.

“You don’t owe me a thing.” Viktor swept all the money into his palm and pushed it back toward the boy. “It’s yours. Save it. For your life. For your future. For Lilith, when we find her. Understand?”

Denny stared at the scattered coins, afraid to look up. His throat tightened. At last, he made himself meet Viktor's eyes.

"I understand," he whispered.

"Good." Viktor clapped him on the shoulder. "If you want to thank me, make some soup. Yours is already better than mine."

Denny smiled and reached for the pot.

Sometimes Viktor went away. For a day, two days, sometimes even three. He came back tired, angry, and silent. He took off his coat, sat at the table, took out a faceted glass, filled it to the brim, and drank it down in one gulp - not grimacing, not eating a thing with it.

Denny sat quietly on those evenings. Only once, when Viktor was finishing his second glass, did he suddenly speak:

"You know who I hate?"

Denny froze.

"Scum. The ones who thought the war was over and they could just hide. They change their papers, change their names, move to other countries. And their hands are covered in blood. The blood of our men, innocent women and children. Blood, do you understand?"

He fell silent and stared into the clear glass.

"I caught one today. His papers are clean: an Austrian refugee. But I remember him. In '43, he was part of a firing squad."

Denny listened, afraid to breathe.

"You..." Viktor looked at him. "Don't tell anyone. Understand?"

"I understand," Denny said.

Viktor nodded, poured himself another half-glass, drank it, and went to bed.

Denny sat in the dark for a long time, watching the fire in the stove. He thought about how the war was still going on for Viktor.

Little by little, life settled into a routine, and they found a new ritual.

Viktor turned out to be a good trainer. Every morning, whatever the weather, he dragged Denny out into the yard and made him exercise: push-ups, squats, running in place, stretching - everything done properly.

“Your body has to be ready,” Viktor said, exercising alongside him. “Anything can happen in life. Sometimes the only things you have are your fists. And your head, of course. But if your head doesn’t help, let your hands do the work.”

Denny exercised, puffing and straining, and kept trying. He liked the feeling of getting stronger. In the cellar he had been a scrawny little runt; now his muscles were slowly filling out, his shoulders straightening.

On Saturdays, Viktor brought out a pair of old boxing gloves he had found at a flea market. They squared off in the yard under the curious eyes of the neighbors.

“Hands up, elbows in,” Viktor ordered. “Move. Don’t stand there like a post. Step in, punch, step back.”

Denny took some punches and sometimes caught one in the body, but he endured it. Viktor held back, but even so, it was enough.

“You have to feel the distance,” he explained. “Your opponent can be closer than you think - and farther away than you expect. Judge it with your eyes, but feel it with your body.”

Denny learned. Slowly, but surely.

Once, after a good training session, he said:

“Thanks, Uncle Vik.”

Viktor looked surprised, then grinned.

“Uncle Vik? I like the sound of that. Better call me Uncle Vitya, though. That feels more natural. Just don’t get lazy - we’re doing push-ups again tomorrow.”

Denny smiled.

Another year passed.

Denny turned eighteen. He got up early, while Viktor was still asleep, took the money he had saved from the box, and ran to the watchmaker.

The old master knew him by then. Denny had come by several times to ask how much the repair would cost and to discuss it. Today he held his father's watch across the counter.

"Here. Fix it."

The watchmaker took it, turned it over, and inspected it through a magnifying glass.

"You've saved enough?"

"Yep."

"Good. Come back in three days."

"I need it today," Denny insisted. "It's my birthday."

The old man looked up and smiled beneath his mustache.

"For the birthday boy, I can do it sooner. Wait an hour."

Denny sat in the workshop without moving, hardly daring to breathe. He watched the fine tools touch the tiny gears, watched the mechanism come back to life. When the minute hand twitched and began to move, his throat tightened.

"Thank you," he breathed, taking the watch. "Thank you so much."

He fastened the strap around his wrist. The watch felt heavy, a little too big for his thin arm, but it was all he had left of his father. And it was ticking.

Tick-tock, tick-tock.

Denny flew home as if on wings.

Viktor was awake, sitting in the kitchen with a mug of tea. He saw Denny beaming, noticed the watch on his wrist, and nodded.

"So its time finally came?"

"It did," Denny breathed. "It's running."

"Well, let me hear it."

Denny held out his arm. Viktor pressed his ear to the watch face, listened, and smiled.

“Good, steady tick. Take care of it.”

“I will,” Denny promised.

That evening, Viktor said:

“Get dressed properly. We’re going somewhere.”

“Where?”

“A bar. It’s time you became a man.”

Denny was taken aback.

“A bar? Why?”

“You’ll see. Come on, don’t dawdle.”

The place was called the Atlantic Cabaret. Inside, the air was thick with smoke. It smelled of perfume, sweat, and something cloyingly sweet. Women in sequins danced the cancan onstage; men sat at worn little tables, drinking and laughing loudly.

Denny felt shy. He had never been anywhere like that. Viktor confidently led him to an empty table in the corner and beckoned to a waitress.

“Two whiskeys,” he ordered. “And something to eat.”

She nodded and disappeared into the crowd. Denny looked around at the women in low-cut dresses, the massive bar, and the lamps whose light sank into the smoke.

“Don’t be nervous,” Viktor said with a grin. “Relax. It’s your day.”

The whiskey arrived in wide glasses with large pieces of ice. Denny tasted his and grimaced. It burned his throat, then a pleasant warmth spread through him.

“Drink slowly,” Viktor advised. “Savor it. This isn’t cellar-brewed moonshine.”

Denny did as he was told. After the second glass, his head felt light and the world seemed kinder. He even began to sway to the music.

Viktor beckoned one of the women who were moving between the tables. A tall blonde in a bright red, low-cut dress came over, leaned on their table, and smiled.

“What can I do for you, boys?”

“This one,” Viktor said, nodding toward Denny. “It’s his birthday. Keep him company for a little while.”

She gave Denny an appraising look. He flushed so deeply that even his ears burned.

“Oh, he’s shy,” she sang, and, without asking, pressed her half-bare chest against him and kissed him on the cheek. “Happy birthday, handsome!”

Denny froze, not knowing what to do with his hands. His heart pounded; the whiskey and the woman’s closeness made his head spin. He felt embarrassed and pleased at the same time. He wanted to disappear into the floor - and for the moment never to end.

But then someone grabbed the woman roughly by the shoulder and pulled her away.

“Hey,” a low, accented voice said. “That lady’s with us.”

A tall man of about forty stood beside them, his face poorly shaved and his eyes cloudy. Two smaller men were with him.

Viktor stood up, slowly, almost lazily.

“What makes you say that?” he asked calmly. “We called her over first.”

“I don’t care,” the stranger said, stepping closer. “Russian, are you? I can hear the accent. Get out while you’re still in one piece. Take the kid and get out.”

Viktor gave him the faintest grin and looked him straight in the eye.

“I wouldn’t, fellas.”

The ringleader shoved the woman aside. She yelped and ran off; he nodded to his friends.

Viktor had just started to raise his hands into a boxing stance when Denny suddenly lunged forward. The street had taught him: if a fight is unavoidable, hit first. Viktor's boxing lessons had taught him how to do it properly.

Denny's short, sharp punch landed squarely on the ringleader's jaw. The big man had not expected the boy to dare; he flew backward into a nearby table, sending dishes crashing to the floor.

The second man immediately swung at Denny. His fist grazed Denny's cheek. Denny staggered but stayed on his feet, shook his head, and focused again. Meanwhile, with two precise moves, Viktor knocked another man out cold. The man slid under a table and went still. At that moment, the third attacker slammed a punch into Viktor's body, then another to his head. Viktor rocked slightly, grabbed the man by the lapels, hauled him up, and hurled him to the floor with all his strength.

The ringleader came around and went for Denny again. But the boy rushed him like a whirlwind. His vision had clouded over. He began pummeling the man, seeing nothing and hearing none of the shouting. His fists landed without aim - first on something soft, then something hard. He kept hitting, pouring out everything that had built up inside him over the years.

"Denny! That's enough!"

Viktor pulled him away, gripping his shoulders. Denny jerked, trying to break free, but Viktor held him fast.

"Cool down, kid. That's enough."

Denny froze, breathing hard. People had gathered around them: some demanded that the police be called; others watched with interest. The three attackers lay sprawled on the floor in different positions.

Viktor quickly sized up the scene, slipped a few bills to the waitress who had hurried over - for the damage - and pulled Denny toward the exit.

"We're leaving. Now."

They spilled out into the street. It was a freezing night. Denny was shaking, from the cold or the adrenaline, he could not tell.

Viktor looked him over: a scrape on his cheek, a split lip, but no serious injuries.

“Well, aren’t you something,” he said without malice. “On your very first night.”

“He… shouldn’t have… done that to her…” Denny gasped.

“I know.” Viktor clapped him on the shoulder. “Good job. You just needed to stop a little sooner. You nearly killed the poor bastard.”

Denny said nothing. His hands were still shaking.

They walked home in silence, with only the snow crunching under their feet. Viktor turned on the kitchen light, sat down, poured himself some vodka from an opened bottle, and poured half a glass for Denny too.

“Come on. To the birthday boy.”

They clinked glasses and drank. Then, all at once, they burst out laughing.

They sat at the table, bruised and scraped, laughing like madmen.

“What a… night…” Viktor gasped, wiping tears from his eyes. “I thought we’d go to a bar and have a civilized evening… Find you a girl…”

“A girl,” Denny repeated, and dissolved into another fit of laughter.

“And instead of that, you punched a guy in the face.”

“They brought it on themselves.”

“They did,” Viktor agreed. “But you fought well. I’m proud of you.”

Denny looked at him and smiled.

“Thank you, Uncle Vitya.”

“You’re welcome.” Viktor raised his glass. “Happy birthday, kid. Now you’re definitely a man.”

They finished their drinks. Snow fell outside. On Denny’s wrist, his father’s watch ticked.

Chapter 4

It all began on an ordinary evening.

Denny sat on the sofa, looking over the papers his mother had hidden with her jewelry. He had carried the packet with him all these years, never understanding why.

Yellowed pages, faded ink, official seals.

Viktor came into the kitchen for tea, saw the papers spread out, and stopped.

“What have you got there?”

“Documents,” Denny said with a shrug. “My mother’s.”

“Let me see.”

Viktor moved the lamp closer, put on his glasses - Denny was surprised; he had never known Viktor wore glasses - and began studying the entries. He turned pages, grunted, and shook his head.

“Do you know what you have here?” he asked at last.

“Well… some papers that prove I’m… me.”

“Papers,” Viktor said with a wry smile. “These aren’t just records, kid. They’re an inheritance. Your birth certificate. The papers for the house and land are your parents’. Bills for the purchase. If we file this properly, you’re the legal owner of the whole property.”

Denny stared at him.

“What?”

“That’s right. The house is yours. By inheritance, the land belongs to you. Legally, we only have to confirm your status. Even if all that’s left of the building is rubble, the land is yours. Every stone on it, too.”

Denny said nothing. He did not believe him. Life had tricked him too many times; too often, hope had turned out to be empty.

“That can’t be,” he said flatly. “It’s just… a pile of old junk.”

“Junk that changes everything.” Viktor stacked the papers neatly. “Let me take them to someone I know. He works at the local administration office and knows how these things work. If anything can be done, he’ll help.”

Denny looked at his father’s watch, then at the papers, then back at Viktor.

“What if it doesn’t work?”

“Then nothing changes,” Viktor answered simply. “But it’s worth trying. Do I have your permission?”

Denny nodded uncertainly.

Two months passed.

Viktor went to different offices, consulted with people, brought home papers, then disappeared again. Denny had nearly stopped hoping when one evening Viktor came into the room with an unusually important air about him. Without taking off his coat, he walked over to Denny.

“We got it done!” he said. “Get dressed. We’re going to the administration office to sign the papers!”

Denny did not understand at first. When he did, his legs turned to water. He managed to steady himself and said, very timidly, in a trembling voice:

“All right, Uncle Vitya…” He could barely hold back his tears.

The official read the papers at length, in a dull voice, pointed to the lines, and made Denny sign. Denny wrote his name without quite understanding what he was doing.

At the end, the official handed him a stamped document.

A certificate of ownership.

For the house. For the land.

They went outside, and Denny stopped, pressing the document to his chest.

“Thank you,” he breathed. His voice broke. “Uncle Vitya…”

He cried with happiness, quietly, like a man.

“You’re welcome.” Viktor clapped him on the shoulder. “You did this yourself. You have the certificate; the house is officially yours. I only helped a little.”

Denny looked at the paper. Something big and warm was growing inside him. Property. Something personal. For the first time in his life, something of his own.

The next day was sunny.

Denny put on his best clothes - the ones he had bought with his own wages: simple trousers, a clean shirt, and the jacket Viktor had given him. His father’s watch was on his wrist. The certificate of ownership was tucked inside his coat, close to his heart.

He was heading toward the city center, to the place where his house had once stood.

His heart pounded. He did not know what to expect. The kids might still be there, or they might have left, or… He pushed the dark thoughts away.

The cellar was still there. The same charred beams, the yard buried in rubble, the dark entrance.

Four of them were warming themselves in the sun at the entrance, sitting on a pile of broken bricks: two girls and two boys. The same ones he had shared warmth and hunger with for three years. The ones who had thrown him out into the bitter December cold.

Filthy, skinny, angry. Just as he remembered them.

Denny stopped about ten paces away.

One of the girls suddenly looked up, squinted at him, and gasped.

“Look! It’s… it’s Denny!”

He recognized her - the little freckled girl, the one he had once shielded from a pack of dogs. She had always looked at him with adoration, but when he was thrown out, she had kept quiet. She was afraid they would throw her out too.

The boys stood up. Their leader was the one who had passed sentence on Denny back then: tall and thin, with a sharp, watchful gaze. The other was stocky, with a baton tucked into his belt.

“What are you doing here?” the older boy grated. “Get out while you’re still in one piece.”

The stocky one sneered.

“Look at him, all dressed up. Steal that new jacket somewhere?”

Denny said nothing. He stood there, looking at them calmly and steadily, his hands in his pockets.

The girl squeaked:

“We thought you were gone… dead…”

“Shut up,” the lanky boy snapped at her. Then he turned back to Denny. “I said get lost. This is our place. You’re an outsider here.”

Denny waited a beat. Then he spoke quietly, but loudly enough for everyone to hear:

“This is my house. I’m not leaving.”

The first boy laughed. The stocky one joined in.

“A house?” the ringleader cackled. “You call these ruins a house? Hear that? Ha! It used to be yours; now it’s ours. We don’t need you, you’re nothing.”

He stepped forward and spat to the side. The stocky boy tensed and pulled out his baton.

“Move it, you little mutt,” the older boy said, advancing on him.

Denny did not move. Everything inside him was boiling, but his head stayed cool. Viktor had taught him: in a fight, what matters is calculation. Distance, speed, the blow.

He knew they would play dirty. One had a knife, the other a baton. If they got the chance, they would hit him from behind.

The lanky boy came closer. Three steps. Two.

Denny snapped up his right hand. A lead knuckle-duster glinted in his fist, clamped between his fingers - crude, homemade, but heavy.

The blow landed squarely on his opponent's jaw.

The sound was like a butcher chopping beef. The leader collapsed, his eyes rolling back. He gasped and jerked.

The stocky boy roared and charged. Denny barely managed to raise his left forearm to block him. The collision sent pain shooting through his arm; his fingers went numb.

The girls screamed.

Suddenly, a loud voice rang out from the neighboring courtyard.

"Hey, you hoodlums! I'm calling the police! What do you think you're doing?"

The attacker stopped and looked around. An old woman was peering from behind the corner.

"Get lost," he muttered through his teeth.

But Denny stayed where he was, staring the stocky boy down.

"I'm not going anywhere," he said. "This is mine."

He pulled a folded sheet from inside his coat, unfolded it, and showed them the seal.

"Certificate of ownership. For the land and buildings. I'm the owner."

The stocky boy stared at the paper, his eyes darting about. He could not read, but he recognized the large official seal.

"You're lying," he breathed, though his voice had lost its certainty.

"I'm not. You can check at the local office."

Meanwhile, the girls had rushed over to the leader and were trying to bring him around. He came to, feeling sick; he sat with his head in his hands, staring at Denny with hatred and fear.

Denny stepped closer. The lead knuckle-duster had bent and dug into his fingers.

He slipped his swelling hand into his pocket, turned to all of them, and said:

"Let's go down to the cellar."

They went down in silence. Denny stood by the exit so he could see everyone and keep his own way out clear. His hand throbbed, but he tried not to show it.

The place smelled of damp and smoke. It was the very smell he remembered from all those years: cold, hunger, and fear. A smell that had become familiar and hateful at the same time.

“Well,” the lanky boy rasped, coming around. “What do you want? To kick us out? It’d be easier to knife you, you stupid bastard.”

He reached inside his coat, where Denny knew he kept a knife.

“Shut up,” Denny cut in. His voice was hard, almost like Viktor’s. “Shut up and listen.”

The older boy froze. His eyes held anger, but also curiosity.

“I’m not afraid of you,” Denny continued. “And I’ve got people waiting around the corner. If I’m not back in ten minutes, the police will be here. You can check, if you want.”

He was lying. No one was waiting for him. But they did not know that.

Silence fell over the cellar. The only sound was water dripping somewhere in the corner.

“I want you to stop your crooked business,” Denny said. “No more robberies, no more muggings. You can keep living here. But you’ll help me. Honest work.”

“What?” the stocky boy asked, not understanding.

“Clear the rubble from the yard. Put the place in order. If you do that, I’ll let you stay. I’ll bring you food. We’ll put up a fence so strangers can’t wander in. I’ll bring new boards to cover the floors and reinforce the roof over the cellar. It’ll be better for you when winter comes.”

He looked around at them. The girls watched with hope; the boys with suspicion.

“It’s your choice,” Denny finished. “I’ll come back tomorrow. I need an answer.”

He turned and headed for the exit.

“Wait!” the lanky boy called after him.

Denny turned back.

“You… you can really get food?” the boy asked.

“If we make a deal, I’ll bring it. More than once.”

And he left.

The sun was shining aboveground. Denny drew a deep breath and smiled. His hand hurt, and he could not get the knuckle-duster off, but inside he felt proud.

He had done it. This was his land.

That evening, he told Viktor everything.

“So you made a deal,” Viktor said, stirring dinner. “Did they agree?”

“I don’t know. We’ll see tomorrow.”

“What if they refuse?”

Denny paused before answering.

“Then I’ll have to handle it another way. But I hope they agree. They’re… they’re people too. Life just dealt them a bad hand.”

Viktor looked at him for a long moment.

“You never change, kid,” he said.

Denny shrugged and touched his swollen knuckles, soaked in laundry soap. That was the only way to get the knuckle-duster off.

“We’ll know tomorrow.”

“And what happened to you?” Viktor nodded at the scrapes.

“It’s nothing.”

“So that was your way of negotiating.”

Viktor examined his hand, felt it, and shook his head.

“Doesn’t seem to be broken, but it’s badly bruised. Put a compress on it. And throw away that homemade thing of yours. Lead… honestly, what were you thinking?” Viktor grinned. “You should ask before you try something like that.”

Denny lowered his eyes.

The next day he went back to the cellar. The yard was empty. Denny stood listening. Then the freckled girl emerged from the darkness.

“Denny,” she whispered. “Come here.”

He went down.

The others were sitting by the hearth. The older boy looked up; a huge bruise spread across his cheek.

“Sit down,” he muttered. “We need to talk.”

Denny sat. He already understood: it had worked. He saw them differently now - not as enemies or friends, but as a workforce he would have to direct.

Everyone knew the lanky boy as Karo. The stocky one, Ferents, answered to the short name Feri. The red-haired, freckled girl was called Piroshka - Prosha to those close to her. The other girl was older, with a sharp gaze and lips that were always pressed together. Her name was Ilona; she had been sleeping with the leader for months and went along with everything he wanted.

“Here’s how it’s going to be,” Denny said. He stood by the hearth, feeling the cold stone at his back. “There’s a lot of work. If you agree, you can stay here. If you don’t, find somewhere else.”

Karo spat to the side but said nothing. The bruise on his cheek would not let him forget the day before.

“First,” Denny said, folding down one finger, “clear the yard. Get rid of all the trash. Second…” He folded down another finger. “Replace the cellar floorboards. We need to get it done while the weather still lets us. Third…” He folded down a third finger. “Clear the rubble by the wall… my father is buried there.”

His voice wavered. He steadied himself and swallowed hard.

“I’ll take care of the grave myself.”

The lanky boy gave a short grunt but stayed quiet. Ilona nudged him with her elbow.

“Will there be food?” Feri asked gloomily.

“There will. I brought some today. And soap, so you can wash. You stink,” Denny said, wrinkling his nose, but without malice. “I’ll bring clean water every day. You work, you get food. Groceries every three days. Make them last.”

He untied his bag and set several loaves, a slab of cured pork fat, onions, rusks, and a jar of pickles from Viktor’s supplies on a crate. Their eyes lit up. Piroshka looked at the pork fat as if it were a miracle.

Denny caught her eye and gave a slight smile. She was small and slight, but her eyes were alive. He remembered how she had looked at him when he protected her. Now she looked at him differently - with hope and shame.

“Eat up. Don’t be shy. Then get to work,” he said.

First, Denny went to the gap in the burned fence where the gate used to be. He pulled a brand-new mailbox from his bag. It was made of tin, painted dark green with enamel. White lettering on its side read: “GOODMAN D. U.”

He set it into the ground beside the crooked post. He tamped the earth down with his foot, straightened the box, then stepped back to admire it.

The bright spot stood among the ruins like a challenge. A sign: people lived here. The owner was here.

“What’s that?” Feri asked, emerging from the cellar with a piece of bread.

“A mailbox,” Denny answered. “For letters.”

“Who’d write to you?” Feri said with a grin.

Denny did not explain. To him, it was proof: he had a home. He had a right to this land.

The money disappeared quickly. Almost all his savings went on boards, tools, and nails. Through old friends, Viktor helped him find good planks.

“It’s all right,” Denny whispered to himself. “I’ll earn more.”

His job at the café had become permanent. The owner, an elderly Hungarian man, appreciated Denny's hard work and promoted him from dishwasher to waiter. Denny learned to carry a tray, smile at customers, and remember their orders. In the evenings, after his shift, he hurried to his ruins to check on the work and bring the others fresh water.

They worked hard - to Denny's surprise, very hard. Karo kept scowling, but carried the boards diligently. Feri used a crowbar to clear the rubble. Ilona helped take out the trash, often pressing against the lanky boy and whispering in his ear.

And Piroshka... Piroshka was everywhere. Small and nimble, she slipped through the narrowest gaps, pulled out little stones, swept, and collected nails in a tin. She often caught Denny watching her.

One day, when the others had gone down to the cellar to warm themselves, Denny slipped a couple of coins into her palm.

"This is for you," he said quietly. "Don't tell anyone."

Piroshka looked at the money, then at him.

"Why?" she whispered.

"Take it," he said sharply.

She closed her fist around the coins and nodded. They never spoke of it again.

A week later, Viktor looked in on the yard. He stood for a long time, taking in the cleared rubble, the neatly stacked bricks, and the open entrance to the cellar. Denny was planing a board.

"Well, look at you," Viktor said in amazement. "It's a whole construction site."

"Yeah." Denny wiped the sweat from his forehead. "We've almost finished replacing the floor. Tomorrow we'll reinforce the ceiling."

Viktor walked around the property, looked into the cellar, and nodded to the others. They tensed when they saw the visitor; they recognized the same man from the bar. Karo even took a step back.

“That’s my uncle,” Denny called when he saw their reaction. “He saved me that winter. He won’t hurt you unless you give him a reason.”

Viktor grinned.

“Keep at it, champions. I’m just looking around.”

He took Denny aside and asked quietly:

“Any trouble?”

“It’s all right. The food and a roof are keeping them here.”

“And the tall one?” Viktor nodded toward Karo. “Is he causing trouble?”

“He scowls,” Denny answered honestly. “But as long as I’m useful, he puts up with me. And after that… we’ll see.”

Viktor clapped him on the shoulder and left.

That evening, when Denny got back from his shift, he found the others sitting by the entrance, looking at him differently. Not quite with respect - more with wary curiosity.

“What?” he asked.

“That man,” Feri said. “Who is he to you?”

“I told you. My uncle.”

“But… he…” Feri stumbled over the words. “He didn’t turn us in back then?”

“No. And he won’t touch you if you do your work.”

On the tenth day, Denny came back from the café to find the yard quiet. The teenagers had settled on the ruins, but no one was working. Karo and Feri were smoking; Ilona was pressed against the older boy. Piroshka was playing with a neighbor’s dog.

“Why are you sitting around?” Denny asked.

“We…” Karo hesitated. “We cleared the rubble you told us to.”

Denny froze.

“Where?”

“By the wall.”

Denny slowly walked deeper into the yard. Where a heap of broken bricks had stood, there was now an empty patch of ground. Beyond it lay a small mound covered with earth.

A cross, roughly nailed together and charred, lay to one side. A name had once been visible on it.

Denny stepped closer and sank to his knees.

He did not cry. He only looked at the cross and the earth beneath it. His father, William Goodman, lay there. A man who had died because of him - because of that kindness within him that could not live alongside a cruel reality.

“Dad,” Denny whispered. “I’m sorry. I couldn’t do anything else!”

He pressed his forehead against the cross and wrapped his arms around it.

“It was my fault. I carried that bundle. I didn’t know, but… if I’d asked… if I’d only asked… if…”

He fell silent for a moment.

“I couldn’t save Mom. I’m sorry. I couldn’t protect Aunt Toma either.” His voice trembled, and tears ran down his face in thin tracks. “I couldn’t keep anyone safe. It was my fault.”

The wind stirred his hair. The others murmured quietly somewhere behind him, but Denny did not hear them.

“I’m just like this… I couldn’t have done it any other way, Dad.” He lifted his head and looked at his watch. “I swear, I couldn’t! Why am I like this?”

He was quiet for a moment, then added almost soundlessly:

“And I’ll find her. I promise. I believe she’s alive.”

Denny never spoke Lilith’s name aloud. It hurt too much. It was too frightening to admit that she might already be gone. He kept his hope inside him, like the fragile flame of a candle.

Denny took off his watch and held it close to the little mound.

“Can you hear it? It’s ticking. Your watch is ticking. I had it fixed. And I’ll fix the house too - our house.”

He heard a muffled sob and turned around.

Piroshka stood a few steps away, her hands pressed to her chest, looking at him with tear-filled eyes. She did not move or say a word. She just stood there and cried.

Denny nodded to her, wiped his face with his sleeve, and got up. He straightened the fallen cross.

“We need to put up a new one,” he said hoarsely. “A stronger one. And a little fence.”

He turned and went back to the others. They were silent. Even Karo had lowered his head.

“Why are you standing around?” Denny asked in his ordinary voice. “There’s work to do. Feri, bring the boards; we’ll finish the cellar floor. Pirosha, go get water. Ilona, find me some good boards. I need to make a new cross.”

Everyone stirred. Work started up again.

As Denny hammered in nails, he kept glancing at the mound by the wall and listening to his father’s watch steadily mark the time.

Chapter 5

Denny came into the apartment late, his legs unsteady and his eyelids heavy. Without even changing, he dropped onto the sofa and closed his eyes. His emotions had drained him completely: the encounter with the past, his father's grave, the talk with the kids, his shift at the café. It had all fused into one heavy knot.

Viktor came out of his room and looked him over.

"Still alive?"

"Just about," Denny breathed.

"Pack. We leave in the morning."

Denny pushed himself up on one elbow, confused.

"Where are we going?"

"My people tracked Günter down through their channels. He's in Budapest. I have the address. I've got the tickets."

Denny sat up. His heart skipped, then began hammering wildly.

"Günter?" he asked.

"Yes. He changed his surname, but it's definitely him."

Denny jumped to his feet and began pacing. His hands were shaking. He didn't know what to do first. His things… He had to pack. But what? What should he take? What for?

"Denny." Viktor came over and took him by the shoulders. "Sit down. Breathe."

Denny obeyed, but his breathing would not settle. Viktor poured half a glass of vodka and put it in his hand.

"Drink. It'll help. Otherwise, you won't sleep."

Denny drained it in one go. It burned; he coughed. Warmth spread through his body, and the shaking eased a little.

"Lie down," Viktor ordered. "We have an early start."

Denny lay down, but sleep would not come. Images kept circling through his mind: Günter, his oily eyes, his hands taking the ring.

Was she alive? No?

He turned the thought over like a stuck record until he finally drifted off. The vodka had done its work.

They were up at first light.

They dressed without speaking and stepped outside. Viktor stopped at a flower stall and bought a modest bouquet of asters - an even number, the last flowers of the year.

“We’ll stop by Tamara’s,” he said.

The mass grave was at the edge of the cemetery. Neat rows, plain headstones, names and dates. Denny knew the place; they came every month.

Viktor laid down the flowers and stood in silence. Denny bowed his head.

“I’m sorry, Aunt Toma,” he whispered. “We’ll find her. We will.”

Viktor put a hand on his shoulder, and they headed for the station.

The train crawled along, stopping at every station. Denny sat by the window, watching fields and villages slide past without really seeing them. Inside, everything trembled. His thoughts went round and round: alive? yes? alive? no?

Viktor tried to hand him a sandwich. Denny shook his head. He could not swallow. His throat was tight; his stomach felt like stone.

“Eat something,” Viktor urged. “It’s a long trip.”

“I can’t.”

Viktor did not insist.

The hours dragged on. Denny counted the minutes, but the hands on the clock seemed frozen. He drifted into a daze, then surfaced from it, soaked in sweat. One moment he was burning; the next, freezing.

“We’ll be there soon,” Viktor said as the train began to slow. “Pull yourself together.”

Denny nodded. It did not help.

Budapest greeted them with the clatter of trams and the smell of coal and fresh bread. The city was wounded, but alive, recovering from the war. Here and there, new signs gleamed.

Denny had always dreamed of seeing the Chain Bridge. He had heard so much about it, read about it in books. And there it was - beautiful, newly restored. But Denny stared into the distance. His eyes moved over the stone, the water, the faces of passersby, taking nothing in.

He almost ran. His legs carried him faster than he could think. Viktor could barely keep up.

“Slow down,” he said.

Denny did, but a minute later he was hurrying again.

The closer they came, the harder he shook.

Viktor turned into a narrow street and checked the note in his hand.

“Here.”

Red brick, a tiled roof, three stories. An ordinary building. The door they needed was on the second floor.

They climbed the stairs. The wooden steps creaked under their feet. Denny felt every beat of his heart pounding in his temples.

Viktor knocked.

“Who is it?” came a voice from inside.

Denny flinched. That voice. The same insinuating tone, slick and ingratiating. Günter.

Denny nodded: it was him.

“Open up,” Viktor ordered. “We have questions.”

The door opened a crack, held by a chain. An eye appeared in the gap.

"What do you want? I'm not working today. Come back tomorrow if you want to sell me something."

Viktor held his identification card to the opening.

"Ministry of State Security of the USSR," he said in a voice Denny had never heard from him before.

Günter froze.

"Open the door!" Viktor barked. His voice had changed - hard, metallic. Denny had never heard him like that. Only then did he notice what Viktor was wearing: a long leather coat and a cap, every movement tightly controlled.

So that was why Viktor never opened up. Why he left and came back angry, drinking glass after glass. State security. This was no joke.

The man obeyed and raised his hands in fright.

"Put them down," Viktor ordered. "Go sit."

Günter backed into the kitchen and dropped onto a stool. Viktor took the chair opposite him. Denny stayed behind Viktor's shoulder, looking around while Viktor questioned Günter.

An old-fashioned child's dress hung on the door. On the shelf stood a porcelain doll with bright red lips, just like one Denny had seen in the window of an expensive shop. Günter caught him looking.

"That… that's a present for my niece. She lives in the country."

Günter studied the young man and recognized him. His eyes widened.

"You…" he whispered.

Denny could not force out a word. His lips would not move; his tongue felt stuck to the roof of his mouth. His ears rang, and everything blurred. His hands shook so badly that he had to shove them into his pockets.

“The girl, Lilith,” Viktor began, his voice clipped and formal. “The one this young man brought to you in 1945. Where is she? Tell me everything, in order.”

Günter began to tremble.

“The… the girl… You don’t understand. This is a mistake…”

“Pull yourself together and answer the question,” Viktor cut in. “I won’t ask twice.”

“I… I don’t… He came then, begging me to take the girl. She was concussed. He was shaking all over; I could barely understand half of what he said.”

“Go on.”

“I told him where the key was, said he could bring her to my place, and I would help.”

“Not for free,” Viktor said sharply.

Günter squeezed his eyes shut and nodded nervously.

“Yes, yes. For a fee. When I came back, the boy was sitting by the entrance. He was beside himself. I asked if he was all right. He said the girl was in the room. He refused to go inside.”

Günter stammered, his words tangling together.

“I promised I’d take a look and come back out. I went into the room… There wasn’t a soul there.”

“What?” Viktor leaned forward.

“Empty!” Günter cried. “I went into the kitchen. No one there, either! There was no one!”

“What do you mean? Don’t lie to me.” Viktor did not raise his voice, which only made him more frightening.

“That’s what happened! I swear! Don’t take me away. I’ll give it all back. Everything I have!”

Viktor slowly turned toward Denny.

Denny was white as chalk. His lips had turned blue. He swayed and tried to grab the doorframe, but his fingers slipped. He vomited onto Günter’s old rug.

"Water!" Viktor shouted.

Günter jumped up and brought a mug. Denny took it, but his hands would not hold steady. The liquid spilled; the glass fell and rolled across the floor. Denny stared at one spot, unblinking, barely breathing.

"That's how he was then, too," Günter babbled. "There was no girl!"

"Shut up." Viktor crouched in front of Denny. "Denny. Denny, can you hear me?"

Denny did not answer.

"Where's the alcohol? Whiskey?" Viktor turned to Günter.

Günter rushed to the sideboard and pulled out a bottle of spirits.

Viktor filled a glass and forced the drink into Denny's mouth. Denny swallowed and coughed. His eyes rolled back, and he collapsed unconscious onto the floor.

"Don't take your eyes off him," Viktor ordered.

He went into the hall and used the telephone. He gave someone the address, then came back. Günter sat beside Denny, trembling with fear. He thought they were coming for him.

Twenty minutes later, a doctor arrived with a small medical case. He examined Denny, took one sniff, and reached for the smelling salts.

Denny coughed and waved his arms as he came to. He looked around, dazed and confused. Viktor told the doctor what had happened. The doctor listened closely and asked about Denny's past. Viktor recounted everything he knew.

"Tell me, Doctor. What's wrong with him?"

The doctor looked at Denny, then at Viktor.

"He has a psychiatric disorder. It appears to be the result of severe stress."

"I've lived with him for two years," Viktor said, unconvinced. "I would have noticed."

“Not necessarily,” the doctor said calmly, tiredly. “After trauma like this - his mother’s death, the camp, everything he went through - the mind can give way. The brain may block some memories. Or reconstruct reality. It happens. Rarely, but it does.”

He nodded toward Denny.

“Something has given way now. Reality came back, and his body couldn’t cope. He blacked out.”

The doctor took a bottle of pills from his case and handed it to Viktor.

“Three times a day. Keep an eye on him. No stress. If he faints again, get him to a psychiatrist at once. There are psychiatrists at the clinic on Hatvan Street.”

Viktor took the medicine and nodded. He saw the doctor to the door, then came back. Denny was sitting on the floor, leaning against the wall and staring at one spot. Viktor gave him a pill. Denny swallowed it without even wincing.

Viktor turned back to Günter.

“You bastard,” he said quietly. “You saw the boy in that state and didn’t take him to a hospital. And then you took the last thing he had.”

Günter trembled and mumbled something incoherent.

“What did you take?” Viktor pulled out his pistol. He did not aim it; he simply held it in his hand. “Bring out the rest. Now.”

Günter scrambled to the sideboard, took out a small box, and emptied its contents onto the table: gold, some coins, a bundle of banknotes.

Viktor swept everything into his coat pocket.

“This is for him. And this is…”

He struck Günter with the pistol butt, swinging with all his strength.

Günter’s nose crunched and was knocked sideways. He fell. Blood filled his mouth and dripped onto the floor. He groaned.

“For giving him false hope,” Viktor said, each word clipped. “Be grateful you’re still alive. You’re on file now, scum. Step out of line, and they’ll come for you.”

Günter lay in a dark red pool, shaking his head. His groans said it all: he understood. He had heard. Never again.

Denny sat staring as if through the walls, unresponsive. Viktor helped him up. Denny got to his feet and began walking on his own, slowly, as if in a fog, unable to make out the way.

They went outside. Denny said nothing, staring straight ahead.

The hotel was nearby - old and shabby, but the rooms were clean. Viktor settled Denny on the bed, then sank into an armchair. All they could do now was wait.

Denny passed out. The medicine had done its work.

He woke a few hours later and sat up. He looked at Viktor. His gaze had changed: clear, but empty.

“I’m remembering… in pieces… vaguely, but I’m remembering,” he said almost inaudibly. His voice was flat, unfamiliar, strangely slow.

Viktor did not interrupt. He waited.

“Explosions, gunfire… We run, fall, duck down.” Denny stared at the wall. “Wire. I tried to move it out of the way, but I couldn’t. And she… she grew heavy. So heavy. I couldn’t drag her. Couldn’t lift her. She wasn’t moving.”

He fell silent.

“What happened next?”

“Then the cellar. The ruins. I was talking… talking to empty space. For a long time. Begging her to wake up. But she wasn’t there. She was already gone.”

He went quiet again. Viktor sat motionless.

“Then… I imagined carrying her to Günter’s. I made it up. I was sure I was carrying her. I kept whispering things, saying goodbye.”

Viktor could not bear it. He turned toward the window. His shoulders shook. Denny stayed silent for a long time, then added softly:

“I didn’t know, Uncle Vitya. I really didn’t know. I thought she was alive. I did everything for her. But she’s gone. She stayed there.”

He closed his eyes. Tears ran down his cheeks, and he did not wipe them away.

Viktor sat with his fists clenched, looking at Denny. Then he slowly slid out of the chair and onto the floor, leaned his back against the wall, and began to cry.

For the first time in many years.

For himself, for his sister, for the girl he had never seen but had already come to love. For Denny, who had carried that lie inside him for so long. For the hope that had turned out to be a mirage.

The two men sat in opposite corners of the room, crying in silence. Each for his own reasons. And for the same one.

Chapter 6

Morning at the hotel was gray. Denny sat on the bed, staring at the wall. Viktor had left early for the clinic to see the doctor who had come the day before. Denny was alone.

The pills the doctor had given him were beginning to take effect. Or perhaps he only imagined it. His thoughts moved slowly. He wanted to sleep, but he had to wait - Viktor had told him so.

So he waited.

When someone knocked, Denny did not understand the sound at first. He got up and opened the door. Viktor stood there, with a short man in glasses beside him, carrying a neat briefcase.

“Come in, Doctor,” Viktor said, stepping aside.

The visitor looked around the room, then at Denny. He sat down and gestured for Denny to take the chair opposite him.

“My name is Dr. Nemet,” he introduced himself. “I’m a psychiatrist. Your friend asked me to see you.”

Denny gave the smallest nod. The words reached him slowly, but he understood.

“Tell me,” the doctor said. “Whatever you remember. Whatever you feel. Take your time.”

Denny stayed quiet for a long while. Then he began his story.

At first, the words came in fragments. Then they grew clearer. He told the doctor about his father, his mother, the camp, the escape. About the confusion: carrying Lilith, speaking deliriously to empty space, and the story that he had supposedly given her to Günter.

Nemet listened without interrupting, nodding now and then. Viktor stood by the window, looking out at the street.

“All right,” the psychiatrist said when Denny had finished. “I understand. Now tell me: are you ready for treatment?”

Denny looked at Viktor. Viktor confirmed his decision with a brief, silent glance.

“I’m ready,” Denny said.

The doctor opened his briefcase and took out medicine bottles, papers, and a pen.

“Treatment will take time. You must take the pills on a strict schedule. No alcohol. No mental strain. But psychotherapy is just as important as medication.”

“How long will it take?” Viktor asked.

“At least a month. It could be six months. It could be a year. It depends on him” - Nemet pointed to Denny - “and on how hard he tries and whether he follows the schedule.”

Viktor nodded.

“Understood. Just not at the clinic. Treat him here. I’ll pay.”

The doctor looked at him and shrugged.

“That can be done. I’ll bring in a colleague, but you’ll be responsible.”

“Fine.”

Viktor counted out some banknotes and handed them to the doctor. Nemet put them in his briefcase, left the medicine and a schedule, and went out.

Denny watched him leave, then turned to Viktor.

“Forgive me, Uncle. I didn’t know.”

Viktor came closer, put a hand on Denny’s head, and ruffled his hair.

“You’re not to blame, kid. Nobody is. War spares no one.”

“Look after the house,” Denny asked. “The others…”

“I will. You focus on getting better.”

Viktor left a bundle of money on the table - the money he had taken from Günter - and a slip of paper with a phone number.

“If anything goes wrong, call me. I’ll come.”

“You’re not staying?”

“I can’t.” Viktor sighed. “Duty. Hang in there, kid.”

He hugged Denny goodbye and left.

Denny was alone. The first few days were the hardest.

The pills knocked him out. He slept twelve hours, woke exhausted, and could barely make himself eat. His thoughts were tangled. Memories came in waves: faces, sounds, smells. Sometimes he could not tell what was real and what was delirium.

He tried to put the events in order, but his mind would not cooperate. Only fragments: an explosion, wire, the weight in his arms. Lilith’s face, drenched in blood.

The headaches became constant. Denny endured them, took the medicine on schedule, and tried to eat a little, though food would not go down. He decided that if he was going to be treated, he would do everything they told him. Anything to make the mess in his head stop.

A week later, Dr. Nemet brought a woman with him.

“This is Katrin,” he said. “She’ll talk with you. Don’t be afraid - she doesn’t bite.”

Katrin was tall and round-faced, with large glasses on a kind face. She smiled at Denny, sat down across from him, and asked:

“How are you feeling?”

Denny shrugged.

“Bad?”

“Fine.”

“What does ‘fine’ mean?”

Denny thought about it. He was rarely asked questions like that.

“I take my pills. I eat. I sleep.”

“And inside? How do you feel?”

“I don’t know. Empty.”

Katrin nodded and made a note in her notebook.

“Empty is an answer, too. We’ll fill that emptiness. Slowly. All right?”

Denny agreed.

They talked for hours. Katrin asked questions; he answered. Sometimes he fell silent, sometimes he withdrew into himself, but she waited patiently. Denny felt he could trust her.

A month passed, then another.

Katrin came three times a week. Dr. Nemet came every three days to check Denny’s blood pressure and pupils and adjust the dosage. Denny grew used to them. He looked forward to seeing Katrin.

She listened to his stories about the cellar, Toma, and Max the rabbit. She laughed when he described slapping Klaus. She grew sad whenever he spoke about his father. She never interrupted.

“You’re special, Denny,” she told him once. “You went through hell, but you kept your ability to love. That’s rare.”

Denny did not know what to say.

By the end of the second month, he was going outside. He walked around Budapest and looked at the restored Chain Bridge he had heard so much about. It was beautiful, but it brought him no joy. Inside, everything was still empty and gray.

He called Viktor once a week, as Viktor had told him to.

“How are things, kid?”

“Fine, Uncle Vitya. I’m getting treatment.”

“Good. Hang in there. The guys are clearing out your house, but it’s harder without you. Most of the rubble is gone.”

“Do you miss my cabbage soup?” Denny tried to joke.

“I do,” Viktor answered seriously. “Come home already.”

“I’ll come when they get my head straight.”

At the three-month mark, the phone rang while Viktor was at work.

“Viktor Andreevich?” A woman’s voice on the line sounded worried. “This is Katrin, Denny’s psychologist. I… I’m not supposed to do this, but the boy is special. I have to tell you.”

Viktor set his papers aside.

“I’m listening.”

“He’s physically well. He exercises, eats, sleeps, goes for walks. But inside… he’s fading.”

“What do you mean?”

“You understand,” Katrin said quickly, worried that she was breaking professional confidentiality. “His disorder began with the killing. When he shot that soldier. He wasn’t made for violence; his mind broke. Since then, his brain has put up a defense: saving Lilith became the meaning of his existence. He lived on that hope. Now she’s gone, and he doesn’t know why he should wake up tomorrow. I’m afraid that without a purpose, a person might take their own life.”

Viktor said nothing.

“The pills Dr. Nemet gives him numb everything,” Katrin continued. “The pain, the joy, even his thoughts. They’re almost like a narcotic. If he takes them for years, he’ll become a vegetable. He’ll end up in a clinic. I’ve seen people like that.”

“What should we do?” Viktor asked, his voice low.

“He needs a new purpose. Or… to work through the old one. He’s attached to you, to the house. He talks about it often. Take him off the pills, bring him home, give him something to do. And… I’m sorry; this is only my personal opinion… he needs to say goodbye to Lilith. Go to her grave, accept that she’s dead, lay her to rest in his heart. Otherwise, he’ll stay suspended between worlds.”

Viktor let out a breath.

“I understand. Thank you.”

“I only want what’s best for him,” Katrin said quietly. “He’s a good boy.”

“I know. Thank you.”

He hung up and sat thinking for a long time.

Viktor called the archive. He reached the same man who had found the information about Tamara.

“Listen,” Viktor said sharply into the phone. “Did you find anything on Lilith?”

“No,” came the reply. “She isn’t on the lists. If the surname was wrong, or the name, we’ll have to search through the index cards and photographs. There are thousands.”

“I don’t have a photograph. Only the kid knows what she looks like.”

“Then bring him. We’ll look.”

Viktor hung up.

The hotel. A knock at the door.

Denny opened it. Viktor stood on the threshold, tired, with a travel bag, but smiling.

“Uncle Vitya?” Denny’s face brightened. His emotions were still muted, but something stirred inside him.

Viktor stepped into the room and hugged him tightly.

“You’ve filled out!”

“I’ve been exercising.”

Viktor looked around. Everything was clean and tidy; dumbbells lay on the floor. Denny was in an undershirt, his hair tousled.

“Well, get packed. We’re going home.”

“For good? Can I?” Denny could hardly believe his ears.

“For good. Enough lounging around here. I’m skin and bones without your soups.”

Denny smiled, a little more broadly than usual.

“All right. I’ll be ready in a second.”

He hurried about the room, packing his things into an army bag. Viktor sat down and watched him.

“I stopped by your cellar the other day,” he said. “Hardly anyone’s been there for a week. Just the freckled one - Proshka, I think - sitting by the entrance. She said the others had gone. Asked me to give you this.”

He handed Denny a bundle of cloth. Denny unwrapped it, and his hands went still. In his palm lay a gleaming, patterned strip of metal, slightly bent but intact.

“This…” His voice trembled. “This was Mom’s. Her favorite bookmark. She never went anywhere without it.”

He held it close to his eyes and ran a finger over the engraving.

“Where did it come from? How did they find it?”

“I don’t know.” Viktor shrugged. “She said she dug it out of the rubble. Decided you should have it.”

Denny carefully slipped the bookmark into his breast pocket and pressed his palm against it.

“I’m ready.” He slung the bag over his shoulder.

“Hold on, lad. Let me catch my breath.”

But Denny could not sit still. He paced the room, looked out of the window, and started pacing again.

“Uncle Vitya, how’s the house? Were they working? Did you take them food? Why did they leave? Where exactly did they find the bookmark? And - ”

“Slow down.” Viktor raised a hand. “I’ll tell you everything. Be patient.”

Denny nodded, but impatience still surged inside him. For the first time in a long while, he felt something besides emptiness.

They stayed at the hotel until evening. Denny told Viktor about the therapy, about Katrin, about how he could now do ninety-five push-ups in one set.

“Are you taking the pills?” Viktor asked.

“Yes. But my head still feels… full of cotton wool…”

Viktor was quiet for a moment.

“Listen. While we’re still here, with the doctors close by… I need to talk to you. About Lilith.”

Denny tensed and sat straighter.

“I don’t remember much,” he said quietly. “Only the weight. Carrying her, the barbed wire digging in… and the emptiness.”

“I don’t mean the memories,” Viktor interrupted. “Something else. You have to say goodbye to her. Properly.”

Denny said nothing.

“I’ve arranged things with the archive,” Viktor went on. “They’ll give you a pass. They have the prisoners’ record cards there, with photographs - everyone who went through the camp. If her name was written down wrong, you’ll recognize her face. Then we’ll find out where she’s buried. We’ll do right by her.”

Denny looked at him.

“You don’t have to go there right away,” Viktor added. “When you’re ready. When you can. But it has to be done, kid. For her and for you.”

Denny was silent for a long time. Then he stood, went over to Viktor, and hugged him.

“Thank you, Uncle Vitya. For everything. I don’t know how I would have…”

“All right.” Viktor clapped him on the back. “Enough sentiment. Let’s get something to eat, or we’ll starve at the station.”

Denny threw the pills away. Viktor noticed but said nothing. He only nodded.

It was a long journey. Denny watched the fields, villages, and little stations pass the window. He felt shaky inside, whether from stopping the medicine or from nerves. He thought of the house. Of the others. He turned the bookmark over in his fingers. The thought of searching for Lilith, saying goodbye, burying her frightened him. He still did not understand how to go on living.

Beside him, Viktor read a newspaper and glanced at him from time to time.

“All right?” he asked.

“All right,” Denny said.

And for the first time in a long while, it was true.

The train slowly drew into the platform. Denny pressed his face to the glass, trying to make out the familiar streets. Three months. Ninety days in a strange city, in a strange room, with strangers and medicine that numbed everything.

“Here we are.” Viktor stood and reached for their things.

Denny jumped up and grabbed his army bag. But in the vestibule, he suddenly stopped and turned to Viktor.

“Uncle Vitya, could I… go to the cellar? I won’t be long.”

Viktor looked at him and took the bag.

“Off you go, then. Just don’t disappear for too long. I’ll make dinner.”

Denny ran. His feet carried him through the familiar streets. The city greeted him with the smells of coal, fresh bread, and autumn leaves. The nearer he came to the house, the slower he walked.

There was the familiar turn. The dismantled fence. The mailbox. He stopped to catch his breath and looked around. The yard had changed. Most of the rubble was gone: the heaps of broken brick had been sorted, the trash gathered into tidy piles.

He went into the yard and over to the grave. A mound rose there now, edged with stones, with a new, sturdy cross and a neatly carved plaque:

WILLIAM GOODMAN, 1900-1944

Denny knelt. The earth was damp, the air smelled of decaying leaves. He ran a hand over the cross.

“Hello, Dad. I’ve got… this…”

He took his mother’s bookmark from his breast pocket. A gleaming piece of patterned metal - the only thing he had left of her. He laid it on the grave and weighted it with a stone so the wind would not carry it away.

“Now you’re together,” he said softly. “You and her. I don’t know where they buried Mom… Let this stay with you.”

He stayed another minute, then crossed himself, awkwardly, as Toma had once taught him, and went to the cellar.

A sheet of plywood covered the entrance. He moved it aside and stepped in. The cellar was dim. The floor structure had been partly repaired, but gaps still exposed the damp earth. In a corner by the hearth, where the coals barely glowed, lay Piroshka. She was curled on a heap of rags, her knees drawn to her stomach. At the sound of his steps, she flinched and raised her head.

“Prosha…” Denny breathed.

She stared at him with wide eyes full of disbelief, hope, and fear. She was thin and pale, with shadows beneath her eyes and cracked lips.

“You…” she whispered. “You came back?”

Denny went over and crouched beside her. Piroshka tried to sit up, but swayed and propped herself on an elbow.

“What are you doing here?” He tried to keep his voice calm. “Where is everyone?”

“They left.” Her voice was faint and hoarse. “They all left.”

Denny looked around. The fire was almost out, and there was no wood left. The floorboards - the ones they had managed to replace - were already beginning to rot in the damp. Water pooled in the corners.

“Have you eaten?” he asked, already knowing the answer.

Piroshka looked away and shook her head.

Denny sprang up and ran outside. Ten minutes later, he came back out of breath, carrying a tin can, with a spoon sticking out of his pocket.

“Here.”

He opened the can. Inside was hot soup he had fetched from Viktor. He handed her the spoon.

Piroshka stared at the food, scarcely believing her eyes. Then she took the can in a trembling hand and began eating ravenously. She almost choked - it was hot - but kept swallowing without stopping.

“Easy. Easy.” Denny steadied her by the shoulder. “Slow down.”

He put a few pieces of kindling he had found in a corner onto the hearth. They were damp, but better than nothing. He blew on the coals, and the fire hissed.

Piroshka began to eat more slowly, savoring it. Color came back to her face, and her eyes shone. Denny crouched beside her, watching, and only now saw how much she had changed.

She was so thin she seemed almost translucent, but her features were fine and regular. Aristocratic. The ginger freckles across her cheeks and nose made her look like a small woodland creature.

“Thank you,” she said, finishing the last spoonful. “I’d started to think… I don’t know what I thought.”

“Tell me,” Denny said. “What happened?”

Piroshka sighed, set the empty can aside, and wrapped the rags more tightly around herself.

“At first, after you left, things were all right. Viktor Andreevich brought food. We worked. Karo and Feri even made an effort. I suppose they were afraid you’d come back and ask what they’d done. Then…”

She fell silent, looking into the fire.

“Then they found a box. In the rubble, behind the wall. Silver, with patterns on it.”

Denny flinched. His mother’s box. The one she had kept her trinkets in.

“It was empty,” Piroshka said quickly. “Completely empty. Nothing inside. But they sold it to a dealer for good money. I told them, ‘Don’t. It belongs to Denny.’ But they…” She waved a hand.

“Go on.”

“They had money. They bought food and drink. Drank for three days. Then Karo and Ilona brought back some nasty stuff. A powder. I don’t know. Opium or heroin. I can’t tell the difference.”

Denny listened without speaking.

“They went wild. Either they were out cold or running around somewhere, looking for more. The money soon ran out. They sold the materials that were left: boards, tools. They even pulled the nails out. Then they started robbing people again. I wouldn’t go.”

“What did they do?”

“They came here when Viktor Andreevich brought the groceries. Pretended to work, took the food, and left. They didn’t leave me anything. I lay here, warming myself by the fire whenever I could find wood. They found an attic somewhere and moved in. There’s nothing left to cover the roof with - they sold everything. It got cold in here. Look at the puddles.”

“And you?”

“I stayed.” Piroshka looked at him. “I waited for you. I believed you’d come back. And I hid that piece of metal. I thought it might matter.”

Denny let out a breath.

“It does. It was Mom’s. Thank you.”

He hugged her carefully. Piroshka went still, then pressed herself against him.

“Let’s get out of here,” Denny said. “It’s too cold.”

“I’ve nowhere to go,” she whispered.

“Come on. Don’t worry.”

He helped her up. Piroshka could barely stand, but she held on. Denny took her arm, and they headed for the entrance.

He led Prosha through the familiar streets to the place where the stove was burning and a hot dinner waited.

Denny knocked three times, quickly - their signal.

The door opened almost at once. Viktor stood there in an undershirt and sweatpants, a newspaper in his hand. He looked at Denny, then at Piroshka, hunched, wet, and shivering.

“Oh, we have a guest,” he said, winking to ease the tension. “You should have warned me. I’d have lit some candles.”

Denny brought her into the hall. She stood clutching his arm, afraid to look up.

“Uncle Vitya, it’s bad over there.” Denny spoke quickly, stumbling over his words. “The cellar floor’s been torn up. They sold everything. Those two - Karo and Feri… The boards, the tools. They even pulled out the nails. It’s cold and damp. She’ll freeze.”

Viktor looked at the girl. She drew her head down between her shoulders.

“Take her to the bathroom,” he said. “I’ll put the kettle on.”

Denny nodded and led Prosha away. The bathroom was clean, with a large towel hanging on the wall. He switched on the light and turned on the faucet.

“I’ll bring some hot water,” he said. “Stay here. Get warm.”

Prosha stood motionless in the little room. Frail and defenseless, she looked around as though she could not believe it was real. A minute later, Denny came back with a kettle and set it on the edge of the tub.

“Mix the water until it’s warm. Here’s the towel. I’ll bring you some clothes.”

He went out and pulled the door nearly shut. Prosha could hear running water and the clatter of pots in the kitchen. Slowly, she undressed, looking at herself in the mirror. Skinny, pale, dirty. She turned away and climbed into the bath.

She washed for a long time, almost an hour. As the water cooled, she added boiling water from the kettle and scrubbed her skin with a washcloth. Now and then, she stopped to listen to the voices on the other side of the wall, then went on washing.

Meanwhile, Denny searched through the things Viktor had once brought for him. He found sweatpants, a warm long-sleeved top, and woolen socks, and pushed them through the partly open bathroom door.

“Prosha, here. Put these on.”

“Thank you,” came the answer from behind the door.

In the kitchen, Viktor had laid out dinner: potatoes, sauerkraut, meat, bread, and fruit preserve. He put on the kettle and brought out the cookies.

“Is it really that bad?” he asked when Denny sat down.

“As bad as it could be. The floor’s been torn up, the boards sold. The tools are gone. They stripped the place, Uncle Vitya. While I was getting treatment, they…”

“I understand,” Viktor cut in. “I thought they were working. So that’s how it was.”

Denny said nothing, twisting the edge of the tablecloth between his fingers.

“Can she stay?” he asked quietly. “I’ll sleep on the floor. Let her get warm. Tomorrow we’ll think of something.”

Viktor looked at him for a long moment, then nodded.

“All right. I don’t mind. We’ll sort it out tomorrow. She can stay tonight.”

The bathroom door creaked. Prosha came out and stopped in the kitchen doorway. Denny and Viktor fell silent, looking at her.

This was not the bedraggled creature from the cellar. Before them stood a girl - thin, alarmingly fragile, but with fine, noble features, thick dark-red hair falling past her shoulders, and a scattering of freckles. The sweater hung on her like a sack. She had to hold up the trousers with one hand. Yet there was something touching, even beautiful, about her.

She looked at Denny. He could see gratitude in her eyes, and a hidden fear. He could not look away.

Under the table, Viktor gave him a discreet kick.

"What?" Denny came to himself and jumped up, nearly knocking over the furniture. "Come in. Sit down. Let's have dinner. Here, sit here."

He pulled out a stool for her, almost sweeping the bread bin off the table.

Prosha sat, still holding up her trousers, and lowered her eyes.

"Thank you so much. I feel awful… I don't deserve this. I've nothing to give you in return."

"Go on, eat," Viktor said, cutting her off, but without anger. Almost warmly. "Don't be shy."

Prosha looked at the table, and something inside her seemed to break. Her hands reached for the food of their own accord. She fell on it, fast and hungry, mixing potatoes with sauerkraut, bread with preserve, meat with cookies. She chewed, swallowed, reached for more, as though afraid it would be taken away.

Denny watched her and saw himself: the boy who had sat in this same kitchen a few years before, eating just as fiercely, unable to believe the food would last. Viktor said nothing, only glancing at them both from time to time.

Viktor finished first. He stood, picked up his cigarettes, and poured tea into a mug.

"I'm going to my room," he said. "Keep it down. I have an early start."

His door closed.

"Prosha," Denny said quietly, "don't eat everything at once. After going hungry, it'll make you ill. Let's have some tea and cookies instead."

Obediently, she pushed her plate away and took a cup. Denny made fresh tea, set a dish of sweets in front of her, and sat beside her on the sofa.

They sat without speaking. Prosha warmed her hands around her mug and looked out of the window. Rain tapped against the glass,

the last yellow leaves drifted from the trees, and on Denny's wrist his father's watch ticked.

Steady. Peaceful. Comforting.

Chapter 7

The morning was gray but quiet. The rain had stopped, and fog hung outside the window.

Denny woke first. The floor felt rather hard; he was no longer used to it. Propping himself on an elbow, he looked at the sofa. Prosha was asleep, curled up with the blanket pulled to her nose.

He got up quietly, put on his trousers, and went to the bathroom.

He opened the door and stopped in surprise.

His clothes hung neatly from the line stretched beneath the ceiling: the very shirt he had left in a corner for washing the day before, his socks, even Viktor's undershirt. Beside them hung Prosha's old rags, washed and carefully smoothed out. Everything hung straight, without a crease.

Denny touched the shirt. Almost dry already. Had she washed them in the night? Early that morning? He remembered how long she had stayed in the bathroom the evening before and realized that his guest had done more than warm herself under the shower. She had washed everything she could find in the laundry basket. Neatly, with a woman's touch.

He stood a moment longer, looking at the clean washing, and suddenly felt warmth spread through his chest. A rare feeling these past few months.

He washed his face, put on clean clothes, and went to the kitchen to make breakfast. Eggs sizzled in the pan. Denny fried a whole heap - plenty to spare, Viktor's way. He cut thick slices of bread, brought out the butter, and made tea.

Viktor came out of his room, stretching as he walked, and sniffed.

"Oh. Smells like life in here."

"Sit down. It's nearly ready." Denny set the pan on the table.

Viktor sat and looked him up and down.

“How was your night? A good one?” He gave a sly wink.

“The floor’s a bit hard. I’m not used to it anymore,” Denny replied, letting the joke pass.

“Let her sleep. Get her strength back.” Viktor pulled his plate closer and helped himself to eggs. “Well, welcome back, kid. It’s good to have you home.”

They ate without speaking, and the silence was kind and peaceful. Then Viktor reached into the inside pocket of the jacket hanging over his chair and pulled out a thick bundle.

“This is yours,” he said, handing it to Denny.

Denny unwrapped it and stared. Gold. A few coins, a chain, earrings, and a bundle of banknotes.

“Is this from Günter?” he asked without looking up.

“From our dear friend himself. For what he took from you. Plus a little interest for the time he’s had it, you might say.”

Denny shook his head.

“No, Uncle Vitya. Please. I can’t…”

“You can,” Viktor cut in. “It’s yours by right. He should be glad he’s still alive.”

Denny looked at the gold, then at Viktor. He reached across and shook his hand, firmly, man to man.

“Thank you, Uncle Vitya.”

“Don’t mention it.” Viktor nodded toward the table. “And there’s something else.”

He handed Denny a thick envelope bearing a seal. Denny opened it. Inside was a pass to the archive, with his name, dates, and a signature.

“Whenever you’re ready,” Viktor added. “They’re expecting you. Tell them I sent you.”

Denny studied the paper for a long time. Then he folded it carefully and put it in his pocket.

“I understand. I’ll try.”

“Go on, eat. It’ll get cold.”

There was a rustling in the next room. Prosha had woken and slipped into the bathroom; they could hear the water running. Soon she appeared, her face washed and her hair smoothed down. She still wore the enormous sweater, but the trousers fit a little better now, tied with a piece of cord.

“Good morning,” she said quietly, sitting at the table.

“Morning!” they answered together.

Prosha ate slowly and carefully, trying not to hurry, though it was plain how much she wanted to fall on the food. She took small bites and chewed them thoroughly. Denny watched her, smiling despite himself.

After breakfast, Viktor went out on business, and Denny took Prosha to the market.

The square hummed. Women called from their stalls, cows lowed in pens, and the air smelled of hay, manure, fried onions, and fresh bread. Prosha turned her head from side to side, studying the clothes on display.

“Choose something,” Denny told her. “Trousers, a jacket, boots. As long as they’re warm.”

She moved among the stalls with brisk, practical purpose. She felt the fabric, tugged at the edges, held things up to the light, even sniffed them.

“What are you smelling them for?” Denny asked, puzzled.

“To see if they smell damp,” Prosha said seriously. “I learned that in the cellar. If something’s musty, you have to dry it, and there’s nowhere to do that. So you either wear it straightaway or let it rot.”

Denny fell respectfully silent.

She chose the trousers quickly: dark blue, made of thick fabric, with reinforced knees.

“These. They’ll be good for crawling.”

“Are you planning to crawl?” Denny asked in surprise.

“Did you think I’d be lying on a sofa in the cellar?” Prosha snorted. “There’s work to do. Look after the house, mend everything. If I’m there on my own, I have to think of everything.”

Denny wanted to tell her she was no longer alone, but said nothing.

Her choice of jacket was practical, too: dark-green canvas, with deep pockets.

“I can put tools in here,” she explained. “And food, if I need to.”

“You’re going to carry food in your pockets?”

“Did you think I’d be going to a restaurant every day?” Prosha asked, surprised. “No. I need to have some in reserve. It’s always cold there. The food won’t spoil.”

Watching her, Denny realized that this girl knew more about survival than he did.

The boots were harder. Prosha tried on five pairs, putting them on, walking, squatting, even trying to jump.

“What are you hopping about for?” the seller asked with a chuckle. He was an elderly Hungarian with a gray mustache.

“To see if they pinch,” Prosha answered seriously. “If they’re too tight, I’ll rub my feet raw and won’t be able to walk.”

The man looked at her, then at Denny, grunted, and reached beneath the counter.

“Here. These aren’t broken in, but they’re sturdy. I’ll let you have them cheap.”

Prosha tried them on, walked in a circle, and gave a brisk nod.

“We’ll take them.”

Denny paid. Prosha was about to leave, but stopped by the next stall, where old clothes lay in heaps. Among the worn things was something large, checked, and woolen. She went closer and unfolded it.

It was a blanket. Thick and warm, with fringed edges. Worn, singed in one place, but otherwise quite sound.

“How much?” Prosha asked.

The seller, a thin Romani woman wearing earrings, looked her over.

“Twenty forints. English-made. Pure wool.”

“Too much,” Prosha said at once.

“A good thing’s always worth money.”

Without a word, Prosha took off her new scarf - the very first thing Denny had bought her - and laid it on the counter.

“I’ll swap.”

The woman narrowed her eyes and felt the scarf.

“This is junk.”

“It’s good,” Prosha said firmly. “And new. I’ve only worn it for an hour.”

Denny opened his mouth to intervene, to pay the difference, but Prosha gave him such a sharp look that he stayed quiet.

The seller considered, shook her head, but took the scarf all the same. Prosha immediately picked up the blanket, hugged it to her chest, and strode away.

“What do you want that old thing for?” Denny finally asked.

“It isn’t an old thing.” She stroked the wool. “It’s warmth. You need something to sleep on in the cellar. You’ll buy boards, we’ll mend the floor, and then what? Lie on the ground? This is wool. Real wool. It’ll keep us warm. I’ll air it, and it’ll be as good as new.”

Denny fell silent. He suddenly understood that she was not thinking of herself. She was thinking of the cellar. How to make it a home.

“Why did you give away the scarf?” he asked softly. “I bought it to keep you warm.”

“I’ve got a jacket now.” Prosha nodded at the new canvas coat. “The scarf… it’s pretty, but not much use. The blanket’s different.”

She smiled.

“You’ve thought of everything, Proshka,” he breathed.

“I know.” She nodded. “Come on. We still need socks. Woolen ones.”

An hour later, they were on their way back from the market. Prosha carried the blanket; Denny, a bundle of new clothes. They were in good spirits. Denny was beginning to come back to life.

“Denny,” Prosha said suddenly. “Can I help rebuild the house, too?”

“You’re already looking after everything there. On your own…”

“No, I mean something else. I want…” She faltered. “I want a place of my own. A real one. Even if it’s only a cellar, it’s a home. But it’s your home. I want to know I won’t be thrown out tomorrow.”

Denny looked at her: red-haired, freckled, swallowed by the enormous jacket, with the blanket under her arm. And so… alive.

“It’s a deal,” he said. “I promise. The cellar’s yours.”

They quickened their step toward the ruined, damp, cold patch of ground that was, for all that, their own.

They reached the house close to lunchtime. It was the day Viktor usually brought food for the others, but Denny had decided to handle things his own way.

Karo and Feri were already sitting in the yard. Ilona was poking through the ruins by the wall, searching among the broken pieces. At the sight of Denny, the two tensed but stayed where they were.

“Well, look who it is,” Feri drawled, squinting. “The house pet’s back.”

“Where’s the food?” Karo demanded. His eyes were sunken; his hands shook faintly. “And you’ve brought her? Still not dead, then?”

Prosha stepped behind Denny.

“No one’s feeding you anymore,” he said calmly. “And you won’t be staying here, either. We’ll settle this once and for all.”

Karo gave a grunt.

“What are you talking about?”

"You're leaving. I'll let you off for the tools, the boards, everything you sold. The box, too… I'll forgive that. But I don't ever want to see you here again. Ever."

Feri spat at his feet.

"And if we don't leave?"

"Then we'll have a different sort of talk."

Karo glanced at his accomplice, then at Prosha.

"Oh, I see. The gutter bitch told you everything. Traitor."

"Leave," Denny repeated. "That's all."

"Give us some money, and we'll go," Karo said suddenly. "We know you've got it. Give us traveling money, and we'll disappear."

Denny looked at them: shameless, degraded, shaking. He felt disgust, but took a banknote from his pocket and thrust it at Karo.

"Here. And don't let me see you again."

Karo snatched the money and tucked it inside his clothes. He and Feri stood, picked up their bags, and made ready to leave. Ilona trailed after them.

Denny turned and walked farther into the yard. Prosha followed.

The first thing he looked at was his father's grave. The stone that had held down the keepsake lay off to one side.

"Stop!" Denny shouted.

They froze by the exit.

"Give me back the bookmark."

"What bookmark?" Karo turned. "Been drinking too much?"

"The one on the grave. The patterned piece of metal. Give it back."

Feri sneered.

"Never seen anything like that. Go and sleep it off."

"The bookmark. I said."

Denny stepped forward. Something was boiling inside him. It was his second day without the pills; his mind was still unsettled,

and his head did not always do as he wanted. But right now, all he felt was anger.

Then he saw it. Ilona stood behind them, a little to one side. In her fist, the familiar piece of metal gleamed.

She showed it to Karo. He smirked.

“Oh, you mean this?”

Denny turned to her.

“Give it here. Nicely.”

Ilona brazenly shook the bookmark.

“Buy it.”

“Give it back!” Denny stepped toward her.

Ilona tossed it to Feri. He caught it and roared with laughter.

Denny spun and drove his fist into Karo’s stomach with all his strength. Karo doubled over and sank to the ground, gasping for air.

“Give it here.” Denny held out his hand to Feri. “Or I’ll cripple the lot of you.”

Feri threw it back to Ilona and pulled a club from his waistband. His eyes were clouded and vicious.

“Take that, you little cur!”

He swung. The club whistled through the air. Feri aimed straight at Denny’s face, but Denny managed to jerk back, shielding himself with his arm. At that moment, his opponent rushed him with his fists.

The blows rained down. Denny covered up, but several heavy punches got through to his body. Feri was furious and strong, despite looking high on drugs.

Suddenly, there was a dull thud. Feri staggered and clutched the back of his head.

Denny looked up. Prosha stood beside them, gripping the same club that had flown aside during the fight. Her eyes were wide and frightened, but her hands held it firmly.

Feri swayed and sank onto the bricks.

Denny stepped toward him. At that instant, a sharp pain tore through his side. He cried out, dropped to his knees, and instinctively clutched his stomach. His fingers found something cold and hard sticking out beneath his ribs.

Ilona had rushed up behind him and driven the piece of metal into his side with all her strength.

“Run!” she screamed.

The two recovered, scrambled to their feet, and fled. Ilona followed. A minute later, they were gone.

Prosha dropped the club and rushed to Denny.

“Hold on! Hold on! Don’t die, do you hear me? Just a moment… just…”

She darted about, not knowing what to do. Then she ran to the neighbors and hammered on the door.

“Help! Fire! A doctor!”

A woman came out, threw up her hands, and rushed back inside.

Prosha returned to Denny. He lay on his side, pale, his eyes rolling back. Sticking out of his side was the bookmark. His mother’s favorite. The one he had fought so desperately to get back.

“Hold on,” Prosha whispered, gripping his hand. “Help’s coming. Just a moment…”

Denny did not answer. But suddenly, inside his head, everything grew calm. For the first time in months, the noise that had followed him all this time died away.

Only silence remained.

Quiet at last, he thought, slipping into the dark.

Chapter 8

Flashes of light… Shouts, noise - everything blurred, like watercolor underwater. Silence.

His mother and Tamara, the watch, his father, Lilith - all mingled, turning in a slow, heavy dream, then suddenly stopped. Grew still.

Sharp pain. A cry - his own or someone else's, impossible to tell. Doctors, blood, white coats, stains. Silence again…

"Everything will be all right. I'm here." A voice out of the dark, warm and familiar.

Then shivering. Heat. Fire. Fear - for what had happened, for everyone around him. Fear of failing to help, of being too late, of not loving enough. Silence…

Remorse. Anxiety. And the shot. That shot. Cold in his hand, the smell of gunpowder, the recoil flaring deep inside him.

A blow to the back.

His eyes opened a little. Hands were lifting him from the floor.

"You clumsy fool." A voice beside him, muffled and indifferent. "I said on three."

Pain. Fierce, cutting, like a knife. Weightlessness - they had laid him on something. The bed was cold and hard. Silence.

Peace…

"Forgive me… forgive me… I didn't mean to… I was trying to save… I didn't want to shoot…"

Tears. Silence.

"Lilith… my darling… I'll come back…"

Silence.

Gunshots, noise, screams, blood.

"Get up! Get up! I'll carry you! Ahhh… no-o-o!.."

Silence.

The smell of bread and cured pork fat.

Mmm…

His eyelids trembled and opened a little. Everything around him was white. The lamp beneath the ceiling hurt his eyes, though its light was dim. Denny squinted and moved his head. No one beside him.

With difficulty, he turned his neck.

One bed beyond his own sat a man. Fat, his head bandaged, he was chewing loudly, eating cured pork fat with bread. The smell was heavenly. The sight, though… Crumbs in his mustache, greasy fingers, pieces falling back onto the newspaper. His neighbor picked them up and put them in his mouth again. Ugh.

Denny closed his eyes. He did not even have the strength to grimace.

Silence.

Pain woke him this time: cutting, throbbing, somewhere deep in his stomach. His hand reached down of its own accord and found thick, firm bandages. Another stab of pain made him grunt. He groaned through clenched teeth.

“He’s awake! He’s awake!”

A clear woman’s voice. His head began to throb.

A white coat, a headscarf - a nurse. She rushed into the corridor. Footsteps came at once. Heavy, assured, measured. Too loud. Every footfall pounded in his temples.

“Uncle Vitya…” Denny whispered through dry, bloodless lips.

But the man who entered was not Viktor.

A uniform, a cap tucked under one arm, a tired face.

“Police lieutenant,” he introduced himself, coming closer. “Hey, lad. Can you hear me? Can you talk? I’m short on time. This is the second day I’ve come to see you…”

The nurse fluttered behind him.

“Lieutenant, you can’t! He’s just had surgery. They gave him an anesthetic. He…”

“I need to question him,” the policeman cut in. “Give him something to bring him round.”

“He’s on morphine already! What are you thinking? He needs rest!”

“Water…” Denny breathed, barely audibly.

The nurse hurried to the bedside table, brought a mug, moistened his lips, and wiped his face with a wet cloth. His forehead was hot.

“His fever hasn’t gone down,” she told the lieutenant. “He’s in no state to talk.”

“I’ll be quick.” The officer sat on the edge of the bed, making Denny wince with pain. “Listen, lad. A girl brought you in. Red hair. She said people you knew attacked you. Who were they? Do you know them? Where can we find them?”

Denny looked at him through a haze. Speaking was hard; every word sent pain through him. He did not want to waste his strength on this man. He stayed silent.

The policeman waited. Denny tried to prop himself on an elbow, but a sudden flash before his eyes cut everything off.

He blacked out.

“Hey, kid! What are you doing? Who’s going to make the borscht? You pack it in!”

The familiar bass voice, dear to him, seemed to come from the depths of memory.

Without opening his eyes, Denny smiled. As much as he could. His lips would not move properly, stuck together with a dry crust, but their corners stirred.

The cool cloth passed over his forehead and cheeks again. He gathered his strength and opened his eyes.

Viktor. His figure was blurred and indistinct. The lamplight shone straight into Denny's face, making it hard to focus. Sounds were too loud, painful to his ears; the image swam. But it was him. Denny let out a breath and finally relaxed.

"Don't move, kid." Viktor leaned closer, and his features grew a little clearer. "Easy. Save your strength. You're alive. That's something."

He looked Denny over and shook his head in dismay.

"So thin… Your eyes have sunk right in. What's this? Trying to lose weight? Enough of that. You need to eat. I brought food. Soup, bread with onions and cured pork fat, your favorite meat patties. It's all here. Have something. Just take it slowly."

Denny tried to focus, gathering every bit of concentration to answer. It took him a while.

"Thank you," he whispered, scarcely audibly. "What happened to me?"

"'What happened to me?'" Viktor chuckled, but warmly this time, with none of his usual sarcasm. "You like getting yourself into trouble, that's what. Lucky the bookmark was silver, at least, rather than rusty. You didn't get an infection. That's something."

He straightened the blanket and moved the bedside table closer.

"They cut you open pretty thoroughly, of course. Not that girl." Viktor nodded vaguely to one side. "The doctors. Said they had to take your guts out and clean everything. At least, they say, you won't have any trouble on the toilet now." He gave a short chuckle. "What matters is you're alive."

Denny looked at him, gathering the last of his will. The stubborn spark Viktor had known for two years appeared in his eyes.

"I'm ready," Denny said, quietly but firmly.

"Ready for what?" Viktor asked, puzzled.

"The archive. I'll go. I remember everything."

Viktor looked at him for a long time, then sighed.

“Stay where you are. Listen to him - he’ll go! Get your strength back first. The doctors said the operation went well. Now the important thing is that you don’t get an abscess. Or whatever they call it… Let’s hope for the best. The rest can wait.”

“I remember everything,” Denny repeated. “I’ll show you.”

“Enough, kid.” Viktor put his heavy hand on Denny’s shoulder. “Settle down. Eat, get stronger, and then you can show everyone everything. Your archive isn’t going anywhere.”

He paused, then added:

“Your friend’s been begging to see you. Hasn’t left me alone since they brought you in.”

Prosha came into the ward. She wore a hospital-issued gown over her clothes. Red-haired, exhausted, her eyelids red and dark circles beneath her eyes from lack of sleep. She came to the bed and stopped, not daring to sit.

“I was so frightened.” Her voice trembled. “Forgive me, Denny. Forgive me… I wasn’t quick enough. I didn’t stop…”

“It’s all right.” Denny found the strength to smile. “It was my own fault.”

“Hold on.” Prosha perched on the edge of a chair and took his hand. “I’m here. I’ll be right here. In the corridor. Just call…”

“Oh, yes,” Viktor said with a wry smile. “This is her third day on duty. On a bench in the passage. They can’t get rid of her. She’s guarding you.”

Prosha lowered her head, embarrassed, but did not let go of his hand.

“Go to our place,” Denny said, looking at Viktor. “That’s all right, isn’t it?”

“Of course.” Viktor nodded. “I offered as soon as she came running and told me about you. She won’t. ‘I won’t go without him,’ she says.”

He stood and straightened his jacket.

“All right. Time I was back on duty. Food’s on the table. Glad you pulled through. I’ll look in this evening. Take care.”

He left.

Denny looked at the table. The smell… Soup, bread, cured pork fat. Hunger gripped his stomach.

“Food… I’m hungry,” he breathed.

Prosha stirred, opened a little jar, and made a sandwich: dark bread, a slice of cured pork fat, onion on top. She scooped up a spoonful of soup.

“Carefully. A little at a time.” She brought the spoon to his lips. “Swallow. Now have a bite.”

“Stop!”

The nurse - the one in the headscarf - burst into the ward, her eyes blazing.

“What are you doing?” she demanded of Prosha. “He can’t have that! They’ve only just stitched his intestines together, and you’re giving him bread, pork fat, and cabbage soup! A fine pair of clowns!”

Prosha froze, the sandwich in her hand.

“Broth only!” the nurse said sharply. “Nothing else! In a couple of days, we may allow rusks. He’ll get hospital food. Don’t worry - he won’t starve. Put that away at once!”

Obediently, Prosha covered the little saucepan and put away the sandwich. The nurse gave them another stern look and left.

“Eat it yourself,” Denny said. “Take the food.”

She shook her head, but he kept looking at her. Prosha sighed, took a little bite of bread and pork fat, and chewed slowly. Then she took his hand again.

“Alive,” she whispered, smiling through her tears. “You’re alive.”

“Go to Viktor’s,” Denny repeated. “He’s a good man.”

“No.” Prosha shook her head firmly. “I won’t go and live with a man without you. I’m frightened. I… I can’t.”

“I understand,” Denny breathed.

Suddenly, Prosha reached inside her clothes and took out a small bundle: the gold and money Viktor had given Denny the day before.

“This… this is yours,” she began quickly. “When they were taking you to the hospital, it fell out of your pocket. I picked it up. I was afraid someone would steal it. It’s all here. I didn’t take anything.”

She laid the bundle on his chest. Denny looked at it, then at her.

“Take it,” he said quietly but clearly. “For food. And rent a room. Just make sure there aren’t any rats. Buy some groceries.”

Prosha stared at him.

“I will,” she said at last, nodding. “All right. As you say. I’ll keep it safe.”

Denny closed his eyes. His strength was gone. But he could still feel her hand: warm, alive, dependable.

She stayed like that until, two hours later, the nurse sent her away.

“That’s enough. Time to go! Visiting hours ended ages ago. He needs his injection.”

Prosha stood, touched her lips to his hand, wiped his forehead with the damp cloth, and straightened his blanket.

“See you tomorrow,” she whispered, and left.

After the injection, Denny sank into sleep again.

…He was about seven, perhaps. Lilith was six. Summer, hot weather. They had run off to the waste ground behind the barracks. There, among the burdock and nettles, they had their secret headquarters: a pit covered by an old roofing sheet. Inside were pieces of cardboard, a couple of empty food cans, and their precious treasure box, filled with colored glass, buttons, and feathers.

That day, Denny had brought two lemons. Small, slightly shriveled, but real. He had stolen them from the pantry, though he knew he would be in trouble. But he would do anything for Lilith.

“Wow!” Lilith clapped her hands. “Where did you get them?”

"Over there." Denny jerked his head vaguely.

"Did you steal them?" She looked at him with interest.

"No… well…" He hesitated.

"Oh, all right." Lilith waved a hand. "Let's try them."

She took a lemon and bit straight through the peel. She chewed, squeezing her eyes shut.

"It's good," she said with her mouth full.

Denny watched her and smiled. He had not even touched his own lemon.

"Why aren't you eating?" Lilith frowned.

"I don't want any."

"You're lying." She poked him with a finger. "Go on. Eat."

"Later."

"No. Now." Lilith snatched the lemon from him and all but forced it between his teeth. "Bite it, or I'll be upset."

Denny sighed and obeyed. The sour juice made his jaw tighten, but he chewed and went on smiling.

"You're a fool, Denny," Lilith said suddenly.

"Why?"

"Because you give everything to other people. And you…"

"What's wrong with that?"

"If you disappear from hunger, I'll be left all alone." Lilith sniffed. "You're the only one I have. The very best. Don't you dare leave me."

Denny did not know what to say. Her eyes were wet, whether from the sourness or her thoughts. He had never seen Lilith cry before.

"I won't die," he said. "I promise."

"Promise, promise?"

"Promise, promise, promise."

She looked at him, wiped her eyes with her dirty palm, and smiled.

“All right. I believe you.”

She moved closer and leaned against his shoulder. They sat without speaking, chewing their sour lemons and pretending they liked them.

“Denny,” she said suddenly.

“What?”

“When I grow up, I’m going to marry you.”

Denny choked and coughed. Lilith laughed, bright as a little bell.

“What are you scared of?” she asked through her laughter.

“Nothing.” He went red.

“Fool,” Lilith said, and gave him a quick kiss on the cheek, like a sparrow pecking. Then she moved away at once.

“Come on. Let’s go. We’ll get told off.”

They climbed out of the pit, brushed themselves down, and raced home. The wind whistled in their ears. The sun was setting behind the barracks roofs…

Piroshka came out of the hospital and stopped beneath the entrance canopy. A fine, miserable drizzle was falling. She lifted her face to the drops and closed her eyes.

He had woken up. He was alive. He had spoken to her.

Tears came again, but they were different now: not the bitter tears of the past three days, spent on the hard bench in the corridor, listening to the nurses’ footsteps. This was relief, happiness, hope.

She wiped her face with her sleeve, took a deep breath, and set off down the street.

In one hand she carried a bag of food and the blanket; in the other, a half-eaten pork-fat sandwich. Piroshka chewed as she walked, never stopping. One thought beat in her head: a room. Denny had given her a task.

Find somewhere to rent.

She had no idea how it was done. Where should she look? Who should she ask? What did it cost? She had never rented anything. She had lived in the cellar, and before that, a barracks. Childhood had almost faded from her memory. Only scraps remained: a warm, comfortable house, the smell of pancakes, a lawn… then, all at once, the war. But Denny had said to rent a room, so she would.

She walked with purpose, though she was trembling inside.

Rain soaked her red hair. Drops ran down her freckled cheeks and fell from her chin onto her jacket. She did not notice.

Piroshka reached Station Street and turned along the canal. It was quieter here. The houses were old and shabby, their windows dark hollows. Some still bristled with bullet holes and shrapnel scars.

Then a sign caught her eye. On a peeling wall, just above an archway, were the words:

ROOM TO LET

The arch was built of red German brick. In the dark passage, it smelled of mold and cats. She stopped for a moment, crossed herself just in case, and stepped inside.

Beyond the arch was a small yard cluttered with old crates. To the left stood a door with flaking paint. Piroshka knocked. No answer. She knocked again, louder.

The door opened a crack. An appraising eye gleamed in the narrow gap.

“What do you want?”

“I… To rent a room.”

The door opened wider. Before Piroshka stood a small, spare old woman with a wrinkled face and gray hair gathered into a meager bun. She wore dark clothes and looked as though she were calculating how much she could get out of this girl.

“Got money?” she asked without preamble.

“Yes,” Piroshka said firmly.

“Show me.”

Piroshka took out the bundle Denny had told her to take and showed the corner of a banknote. At once, the old woman’s face softened. She stepped aside.

“Come in.”

The corridor was long, cluttered with junk and full of cats. The landlady shuffled ahead in her slippers.

“It’s a good room. Bright,” she began as they walked. “Not many neighbors. Quiet. Rent in advance. Thirty forints a month. And a deposit - another twenty.”

Piroshka almost choked.

“Fifty?” she asked. “For what?”

“For everything.” The old woman turned and gave her a sharp look. “A roof over your head. Heat. Water. If you don’t want it, keep looking.”

Piroshka bit her lip. Denny had trusted her with the money. But it was his money. She could not simply throw it away.

She looked around the corridor. A dirty floor, cobwebs in the corners, dust a finger thick on the windowsill.

“Who’s going to clean this place?” she asked suddenly.

The landlady blinked in surprise.

“I clean. Once a week.”

“Not very well,” Piroshka said bluntly. “Look at all that dust.”

The old woman pursed her lips but said nothing.

“I can clean,” Piroshka went on. “Every day. Wash the floors, dust, scrub the toilet. You give me a discount.”

“What?” The old woman stopped.

“A discount. I work, you charge less. Agreed?”

They faced each other in the dim corridor: the small, spare, tenacious old woman and the red-haired girl, soaked through and no less tenacious. Their eyes met. There was no fear in Piroshka’s, only determination.

“Twenty forints,” the landlady said at last. “And you clean the whole house. Stairs, corridors, toilet. I want everything shining.”

“Fifteen,” Piroshka insisted. “And I’ll wash the dishes in the shared kitchen, too, if you need me to.”

The old woman studied her for a long time. Then, unexpectedly, her lips twisted into something like a smile.

“You haggle like a Gypsy. All right. Fifteen. But mind you: if I see dirt even once, you’re out. No arguments.”

“Agreed,” Piroshka breathed.

The room was on the second floor, at the very end of the corridor. Small, with one window overlooking the canal. Against the wall stood an iron bed with a wire-mesh base and a thin mattress. Opposite it was a small cabinet with a drawer. On the floor lay a ragged rug with a faded pattern that must once have been red. Another hung on the wall, worn and patchy, with deer on it.

The old woman - she had introduced herself as Nina - stood in the doorway while Piroshka looked around.

“Toilet and shower at the end of the corridor. Shared. Kitchen’s there, too. Any questions?”

“No,” Piroshka said.

The landlady left. Piroshka was alone.

She went to the radiator and touched it. Warm. She smiled. She ran a finger over the windowsill; it came away gray with dust. A piece of the sill was missing, apparently knocked out by something heavy. The bed’s wire base sagged almost to the floor.

Piroshka sat on the edge of the mattress. The room was growing dim. A branch tapped steadily against the window. Somewhere in the distance, a dog barked.

At first, she simply sat, staring ahead. Then her shoulders began to shake, and the tears came of their own accord. Not bitter tears, but tears of relief, clear and light. She cried and smiled at the same time.

He was alive. She had a room. A real room, warm, with a radiator.

Piroshka jumped up and hurried from corner to corner. She had to clean. Wash everything, scrub it, make it comfortable.

She found a rag in the corridor, persuaded the old woman to lend her a bucket, filled it with water, and set to work. She scrubbed the floor, cleaned the windowsill, shook the rug out through the window, remade the bed, and spread out the blanket. For now, she left the rug on the wall. Let it hang. The deer were company of a sort.

Then she remembered their agreement and went out to wash the corridor. After that came the stairs, the shared kitchen, then the toilet and shower. She scrubbed so hard that three hours later everything shone. The old woman came out several times to look but said nothing.

Toward evening, when the work was finished, Piroshka returned to her room. She stood in the doorway, unable to believe it: this was her place. Rented, yes. Temporary, yes. But tonight she would sleep neither in a cellar nor on a hospital bench. She would sleep in a real bed, in a room with a window and heating.

She went to the radiator, crouched, and pressed her cheek against the warm metal. She closed her eyes.

She remembered Denny first coming into her life in that hard year, 1946. She had been only a girl, about fourteen. Two dogs had attacked her. She had wandered over to a shop and was searching the trash for food, but the dogs had not welcomed the intruder. Denny, though he looked thin and weak himself, had gone down on all fours between her and the pack and growled with all his might. His stare had been enough to make them back off.

He had always been like that. Foolishly kind, other people said. But to her, that kind boy had become the most dependable person in the world.

Then came the long years in the cellar. He shared his food with her when the others turned away. Stroked her hair when she cried

at night. Never once hit her or called her names, even when she made a mess of things.

Now he lay wounded in the hospital and still went on helping her. Gave her money for a room, bought her clothes… He was still the only person she could talk to from the heart. Piroshka promised herself she would never let him down.

She opened her eyes, stood, and went to the window. Outside, the canal was darkening. On the far bank, she could see half-ruined barracks and the road to the cellar that had sheltered her all those years.

But now she was here. Warm. With hope. And Denny in her heart.

Nina quietly opened the door and came in.

"Here. These are for you." She set a plate on the cabinet, laid down a fork, and tossed an old pillow onto the bed. "You've cleaned up. Now do the same every other day. Don't forget."

The old woman went out. Piroshka spent a long time studying the pattern on the plate: plain white earthenware with a narrow blue rim. Then she picked up the bent fork, straightened it against the edge of the table, and laid it beside the plate.

Everything was different.

She sat on the bed with her legs tucked beneath her and looked out of the window again. The rain had stopped. The clouds were parting, revealing a pale evening sky.

She thought about Denny. About waiting for him all that time in the cellar, after the others had gone. About the way her heart had beaten when she saw him again.

She liked him. Very much. Not as a brother or a friend. Differently. She did not have a name for the feeling, but everything inside her grew warm at the thought of him.

"Get well, Denny," she whispered into the dark, crossing herself. "I'm waiting for you."

A few streetlights came on outside. Soft twilight filled the room. Prosha yawned, curled up on the bed on top of the blanket, and fell asleep without noticing.

For the first time in many days, she slept peacefully, without fear, a smile on her lips.

Chapter 9

Two weeks in the hospital stretched into an endless succession of gray days. White walls, the smell of medicine. Doctors came, felt Denny's stomach, changed the dressings, shook their heads, and went away again. He grew used to being unable to laugh, move suddenly, enjoy his food, or get to the toilet on his own.

"Well, hero," his doctor said at last, an elderly bearded man with perpetually tired eyes. "We're discharging you tomorrow. But there are conditions."

Denny pushed himself up on his elbows, hissed with pain, and lay back down.

"What conditions?"

"These." The doctor unfolded a sheet of paper and began counting on his fingers. "Strict diet. Nothing fatty, nothing fried, no cured pork fat or coarse bread. Broth and porridge made with water. For two months, don't lift anything heavier than a mug. Less laughing, less worrying. And we're leaving the stitches in for now. Come back in a week for a checkup."

Denny listened and nodded. Home. That was what mattered.

"Please tell Viktor all of that," he asked.

"I've already told everyone. I'm repeating it for you." The doctor smiled. "He and the girl ask me every day: 'When can he come home? What can he do? What can't he do? What should we feed him?' You've got good people behind you, lad."

Denny smiled. He really did have good people behind him.

Viktor arrived the next morning with a large bag. Inside were soft clothes for home, slippers, and fresh socks.

"Get dressed, kid," he ordered. "We're going home."

Denny dressed slowly. Every movement sent a sharp pain through his stomach. Viktor waited patiently, helping now and then.

When they stepped onto the hospital porch, Denny took a deep breath.

"How good this feels," he breathed.

"It does," Viktor agreed. "Come on. The car's waiting."

That same morning, Piroshka woke in the little room she had cleaned for the two of them. She sprang out of bed, quickly washed her face, combed her hair, and put on her ironed clothes. Denny was coming out of the hospital today! She had imagined the day a hundred times: meeting him at the exit, taking his hand, walking back to her place.

She would show him the room, clean and comfortable, with the rug on the wall and the view over the canal. He would sit on the bed, and she would feed him the soup she had made specially for him the day before.

Her heart pounded with happiness.

She reached the hospital half an hour before his discharge time, climbed to the second floor, and went to the nurses' station.

"Daniel Goodman, Room Five. He's being discharged today," she blurted out, breathless. "I've come for him."

The nurse looked up at her with tired eyes.

"He's already gone. About twenty minutes ago. His uncle took him, I think."

Piroshka went still.

"Gone? Where?"

"Home, I suppose." The nurse shrugged and returned to her papers.

Piroshka stood in the middle of the corridor, not knowing what to do. He had left. Not with her. With Viktor.

She slowly went down the stairs, stepped outside, and sat on a bench. Tears ran down her face; she did not wipe them away. People passed. Some glanced back, some hurried on, while she simply sat and cried. Everything she had imagined, everything she had dreamed of these past days, had collapsed in a minute.

"Why?" she whispered. "Why didn't he come to me? I tried so hard for him…"

She did not understand that Denny had never thought there was a choice to make. Viktor had simply arrived, spoken to the doctors, and taken him home. To Denny, it was natural. Over the past two years, Viktor's home had become his home, too.

But Piroshka…

Piroshka did not know that. The bitterest thoughts took shape in her head.

He doesn't need me. He only feels sorry for me. I'm ugly, skinny, horrible. Of course he chose Viktor. Viktor's dependable, a grown man, with an apartment of his own. And what am I? A beggar from a cellar.

After sitting there for half an hour or so, she stood and trudged to work. A few days earlier, she had found a job washing dishes. She wanted to live on her own money, to be a burden to no one.

Meanwhile, Denny and Viktor entered the apartment.

The familiar smell: tobacco, cabbage soup, old books. Denny stopped on the threshold and closed his eyes.

"What are you standing there for?" Viktor gave him a gentle nudge. "Come in. Make yourself comfortable. Let's get you settled."

He led Denny to the sofa and carefully helped him sit. Denny leaned back with a blissful sigh.

"How good this feels…"

"Just wait. It'll be even better in a minute." Viktor began bustling about the kitchen. "The doctors said to make you broth, using fresh water after the first boil. We'll have it ready in no time. Lie down and rest."

Denny watched him working at the stove and felt awkward. The man who had always been so strong and independent was now bringing him water, cooking, helping him stand.

“Uncle Vitya,” he called. “Maybe I could manage somehow? You’re doing so much for me…”

“Stay put!” Viktor barked from the kitchen, but without anger. “You haven’t healed yet. The doctors said no strain for two months. Once that’s up, you can do it yourself. Until then, put up with it.”

Denny sighed and smiled.

That evening, after Viktor came back from work, they sat in the kitchen. Denny drank broth; Viktor had tea with crisp little bread rings.

“Uncle Vitya,” Denny said, “I remember everything. Everything that happened… in the camp.”

Viktor looked up.

“Well?”

“I didn’t carry her to Günter’s. I didn’t carry her anywhere. She stayed there… I’ll show you.”

Viktor said nothing.

“I want to find her soon,” Denny went on. “Go to the archive. Look through the photographs. I let you down then, with my head, with that disorder. But I remember now. I’ll find her. I’ll do everything. I promise.”

Viktor set his mug aside and looked at him for a long time.

“Don’t rush, kid. Get back on your feet first. Lilith…” He faltered and paused. “Lilith can wait. We’ll all be there someday.”

Denny nodded, but determination burned in his eyes.

“All right,” Viktor said. “Change of subject. Let’s get some grub before it goes cold.”

Denny smiled. Grub. One of Viktor’s trademark words.

“Uncle Vitya,” he began when they had finished. “I wanted to talk.”

“Again?” Viktor chuckled. “You’re in a confiding mood. Go on, then.”

“I think I might move in with Piroshka.”

Viktor raised his eyebrows in surprise.

“What for?”

“Well… You have work, things to do. And I’m lying here, with you looking after me like a child. I feel bad. You can’t even go to the bar.” He smiled. “It’s all me, me, me.”

Viktor grinned.

“Don’t even think about it. I don’t mind. When I’m old, you can wipe my ass. Then we’ll be square.”

Denny laughed and immediately clutched his stomach.

“Oh, don’t make me laugh… It hurts.”

“That’s more like it.” Viktor leaned back in his chair, pleased. “Stay where you are.”

“But I mean it,” Denny insisted. “Will you take me to her?”

Viktor was about to answer when someone knocked. He tensed at once. The knock was odd. Who could come at this hour?

“Who is it?” he asked in his deep voice.

“It’s me…” came the answer. “Open up…”

Viktor glanced at Denny, who merely shrugged.

The lock clicked. Piroshka stood in the doorway.

“Stood” was generous. She could barely hold on to the frame. Her eyes were red, her hair disheveled, and the smell of alcohol hung unmistakably in the air.

“Well, well.” Viktor whistled. “Come in, mademoiselle.”

Piroshka stepped into the hall, saw Denny on the sofa, and burst out:

“I thought we… And you… You bastard!”

Denny’s eyes widened.

“I waited!” Her voice rose. “Cleaned the room, made soup! And you’re here! With Viktor! You don’t need me, do you? I’m ugly? Pathetic?”

“Prosha, what’s wrong?” Denny tried to stand, but a sharp pain pinned him where he was.

“What’s wrong?” She was shouting now, her words slurred. “I thought we’d be together! And you… you… It’s all pity! I tried for you. Gave you the money. Got a job so I wouldn’t live off you! And you?”

Viktor stood to one side, arms folded, watching with interest.

“Prosha,” Denny tried to say, but she was not listening.

“Since we were children, I’ve… Why did you save me from those dogs, then? What the hell for? And I… I thought…”

She sobbed and fell silent, her throat closing, the words gone.

“All right.” Viktor stepped forward. “Enough. Come along.”

He took her arm and, ignoring her feeble resistance, led her to the bathroom. She was still mumbling, but he had already turned on the cold water and put her head under the faucet.

“Ow!” she shrieked.

“Bear it,” Viktor said sharply. “Time to sober up.”

A minute later, he brought her out, wet but noticeably sobered, sat her in the kitchen, and put a mug of strong coffee before her.

“Drink. And keep quiet. You can go on when you’ve recovered.”

Piroshka obediently took the mug, swallowed, and grimaced. Viktor turned to Denny.

“All right. I’ll leave you to it. Sort it out without an audience. Just don’t kill each other.”

He chuckled and went to his room, pulling the door nearly shut.

“What a performance,” came his voice from behind it.

Silence fell. Piroshka carefully stood, slowly approached the sofa, and dropped beside Denny.

“Prosha,” he said at last, “what’s wrong?”

She looked up. Wet hair clung to her face, making the freckles on her nose stand out.

"I thought… you'd be with me…" she whispered.

"Just this evening, I asked Viktor to take me to you. We were talking about it when you knocked."

Piroshka went still.

"Really?"

"Really."

She looked at him. Slowly, understanding dawned in her eyes: what a fool she had made of herself.

"And I… the things I said…" she mumbled. "Forgive me…"

"You're a fool, Proshka," he said softly. "But I understand."

"Really?" she asked, scarcely audibly.

"Really. I'd probably have been hurt, too."

Suddenly, she leaned forward and kissed him.

Denny froze. He had not expected it, had never thought of it, never even imagined it. But her lips were soft and warm, and she smelled of coffee and cognac.

She drew back, looking frightened.

"What was that?" he breathed.

"I don't know," she said honestly. "I just wanted to."

Denny smiled and put his arms around her, carefully, so as not to pull at the stitches. Prosha pressed against him, burying her nose in his shoulder.

"I'm sorry I got drunk," she mumbled. "Auntie Nina gave me a drink to calm me down. Look what happened."

"Who gave you a drink?"

"My landlady. She's kind."

"All right." Denny stroked her wet hair. "Let's sleep. Things will be clearer in the morning."

She nodded and settled beside him, on top of the blanket. Denny covered her with the throw that always hung over the back of the sofa. She was still mumbling something, but already drifting off.

The room grew quiet. Only the watch broke the silence - his father's watch. On the windowsill, in the light of a streetlamp, his mother's bookmark gleamed.

Denny closed his eyes.

"All right," he whispered into the dark. "Everything's all right."

Chapter 10

Morning came to Denny with the smell of frying bacon and eggs. He opened his eyes and smiled at once. Viktor was clattering pans in the kitchen, humming to himself. It smelled so good that Denny's mouth began to water.

Prosha stirred beside him. She opened one eye, immediately squeezed it shut again, felt her tangled hair, and rubbed her face with her palms. Denny watched her with an affectionate smile. Red hair stuck out in every direction; a fold in the pillow had left a mark on her cheek. She was ridiculously sweet.

"Up you get, you two!" Viktor called from the kitchen. "Breakfast's ready!"

Prosha froze. Slowly, she turned her head toward the kitchen, then looked at Denny.

"This is so embarrassing," she whispered, drawing the words out, and instantly disappeared beneath the throw.

Denny wanted to laugh, but pain caught him in the stomach. He had to hold it in.

"Get up," he said, lifting the edge of the throw. "Everything's all right."

Prosha emerged and gave him a frightened, guilty look. Then she sprang up and, barefoot, on tiptoe, dashed past the kitchen to the bathroom, trying not to look at anyone. Her hair flew, her face was puffy, and the sweater flapped around her. Quite a sight.

Denny watched her go, smiling. She was a good girl. Odd, funny, but sweet.

"Stop!" Viktor suddenly barked.

Prosha froze in the doorway. Viktor approached with a faceted glass. Cloudy liquid sloshed inside it, with bits of herbs floating on top.

“Here.” He held it out. “Your potion.”

Prosha took it automatically and stared at the contents.

“What is it?”

“Drink. You’ll feel better.”

She took a sip. Then she closed her eyes and swallowed the lot. Wiping her mouth with her hand, she gave back the glass and vanished into the bathroom, slamming the door.

“Pickle brine always helps.” Viktor nodded and went back to the table.

Denny hobbled after him, holding his stomach. Everything was ready in the kitchen. Bacon and eggs sizzled beside a heap of toasted bread.

“It’s been ages since I had your specialty,” Denny said, swallowing.

“True enough.” Viktor waggled his eyebrows with satisfaction. “The bacon’s turned out beautifully today. Sit down.”

He put a plate before Denny, whose eyes widened. On it were boiled potatoes, carrots, and grated beet.

“Damn,” Denny breathed.

“Oh, yes.” Viktor grinned, sitting opposite him with his own eggs. “A diet’s a diet, kid. You can enjoy the smell for now. Your friend can tell you afterward what it tasted like.”

Prosha came out of the bathroom, her face washed, her hair combed - as far as that mass of hair allowed - but still crimson with embarrassment. She stopped in the doorway, afraid to enter.

“I’m sorry,” she faltered. “Yesterday, I had too much…”

“Sit down.” Viktor cut her off, nodding toward a stool. “Go on. Eat.”

“I’d never had a drink before,” Prosha explained as she sat. “Auntie Nina offered it to calm me down. I didn’t think…”

“It happens.” Viktor chuckled. “When I quarreled with my wife, I used to drink so much she’d spend three days searching the village for me.”

Denny looked up with interest.

“You never told me. A wife?”

Viktor went still. For several seconds, he stared at one spot. Then he slowly put down his cup of tea and gripped his fork until his knuckles whitened.

“No,” he said dully. “She’s gone. No one’s left. Those Bandera bastards…”

He fell silent, staring at his plate. A thick, heavy silence settled over the room. Ten seconds passed.

“All right.” Viktor shook his head and pulled himself together. “What am I doing, first thing in the morning? Sit down. Don’t be shy.” He nodded to Prosha. “Did the brine do the trick?”

“Yes. Thank you,” she said quietly, settling on the stool.

She ate with her head lowered, but kept glancing sideways at Denny. He chewed his vegetables and gave her encouraging smiles.

“Now listen, Red.” Viktor raised a finger. “Boiled and mashed food only. Porridge, vegetables, broth. Nothing fried. If he begs, don’t give in. Understood?”

“I know all that,” Prosha interrupted. “The doctor told me. I’ve borrowed a saucepan and a grater already. Made soup, too.”

“You’re a resourceful one.” Viktor gave an approving grunt and looked at Denny. “You won’t come to grief with her around.”

Denny merely smiled.

After breakfast, they began to pack. Prosha bustled about, helping Denny dress and handing him his things. Viktor brought out the army bag, and together they packed his few possessions. Denny hobbled around the room, keeping a hand on the wall. Whenever he stopped, Prosha took his elbow.

“Got everything?” Viktor asked.

"I think so."

"Then I'll wait downstairs."

He went out, pulling the door nearly shut.

Denny looked around. The sofa that had been his bed for so many months. The dining table. The kitchen where Viktor had taught him to cook. It was hard to leave.

He went to the sofa and reached beneath the pillow. Half of the valuables from Günter's bundle had been hidden there since that morning: gold and coins. He wrapped them in the cloth again and pushed them farther under.

"Prosha," he called. "There's a pen and paper on the cabinet by the door. Bring them, please."

She brought them. Denny stood at the windowsill, smoothed the paper, and wrote in large letters:

To my dear Uncle Vitya. Thank you for everything.

He folded the note and tucked it beneath the pillow, too.

"He'll find it when he cleans," he explained.

She nodded without speaking. Something warm shone in her eyes. She understood the gesture: farewell, gratitude, respect.

Viktor was already waiting in the car downstairs. Prosha took Denny's arm, and slowly, step by step, they made their way out. On the threshold, Denny turned back.

The apartment that had become home saw him off in silence, with its familiar smell of tobacco.

The car stopped outside an old red-brick house. Viktor helped Denny out; Prosha supported him on the other side. Carefully, with an arm under each of his, they brought him to the entrance and up the steps.

As soon as they reached the hall, Nina came hurrying out. Her eyes went straight to Denny.

"Is this him?" she asked Prosha.

Piroshka nodded, hiding a smile. The old woman looked Denny up and down.

“Well, young man,” she said sternly. “Treating the girl like that. Mind yourself. If you do it again, I’ll take a frying pan to you. Don’t think I won’t.”

Denny stared, his mouth open, unable to think of an answer. Prosha laughed behind her hand.

“All right. Off you go.” The landlady waved them on. “Just keep the noise down, and don’t waste water. Do you hear?”

“Yes, Auntie Nina,” Prosha answered obediently.

She took Denny’s arm and led him on. The room was small but surprisingly comfortable. The floor was clean. New curtains hung at the window - Prosha had plainly made an effort - and a little picture of a river hung on the wall. The bed was neatly made with the blanket she had bartered for at the market. A stack of books and a kerosene lamp stood on the bedside cabinet.

“This is nice.” Denny smiled as he lowered himself onto a chair.

Prosha stood beside him. He leaned his head against her waist, put his arms around her, and closed his eyes. She stroked his hair. Both felt warm and peaceful inside.

Outside, crows cawed and rain drummed against the window. Here, in this little room, was their new refuge.

“I’ve… got everything ready,” Prosha said, plainly eager to please. “I’ll show you.”

Denny let go of her and looked up with interest. Prosha stepped away, reached beneath the bed, and brought out…

Denny blushed. He did not know how to react. He understood that she had tried hard, did not want to hurt her, but the situation was unbearably awkward.

In her hands was a white enamel bedpan.

“This is for you,” she said proudly. “The toilet’s down the corridor. It’s a long way. At night, if you need to, you can use this. It’ll be easier.”

Denny looked at the bedpan, not knowing where to put his eyes.

"I… I hadn't thought of that, of course, but…" He took it, turned it in his hands, and carefully set it aside. "Please put it back."

Prosha wilted at once.

"I'm sorry. I only wanted to help… make things easier for you…"

"Thank you. I appreciate it." Denny took her hand. "I really do. But let's have no more surprises like that for now."

She looked downcast and turned toward the window. Denny drew her back.

"Come here."

She came, and he put his arms around her waist again, resting his cheek against her. At last, they both let out a breath and relaxed.

That evening, another problem emerged.

The bed was narrow, and its wire base sagged in an arc. Denny's stitches were still fresh. They could not lie in it together without the slightest movement making him groan.

"I'm sleeping on the floor," Prosha announced firmly.

"You don't have to," Denny tried to protest.

"Yes, I do. You can't risk it. I move around in my sleep. I'm bound to knock you. No arguments."

She spread the market blanket on the floor, threw a sheet over it, and set down a pillow. Denny felt awkward, but understood there was no other way.

"Good night, Denny," she whispered.

"Good night, Prosha."

The days settled into a rhythm.

In the mornings, Prosha went to work washing dishes at a canteen. Denny stayed alone, moving slowly around the room, getting used to his new home. At lunchtime, Prosha hurried back to feed him grated vegetables and broth, keeping him strictly to his diet.

In the evenings, Denny taught her to read and write.

“This is ‘А,’” he said, pointing in the primer. “This is ‘Б.’ Remember them.”

Prosha carefully formed the letters in a notebook they had bought at the market. Her tongue was sharp, but reading and writing were a struggle. In the cellar, there had been no time to learn.

“What’s this one?” she asked, pointing to “ы.”

“‘Ы,’” Denny explained patiently. “A difficult letter. Hungarian doesn’t have it. Only Russian.”

“Why do I need it, then?”

“Viktor says it’ll come in useful.”

Prosha sighed and bent over her notebook again.

A few days later, Denny asked her:

“Go and look at the house. See how things are. We haven’t been there for a while.”

She went and came back with news. The yard was clean, the cellar partly flooded, and no strangers had appeared since that day.

“We need to find some workers,” Denny decided. “Buy boards and canvas to cover the floor. I’ll give you money. See if you can find someone.”

Prosha nodded and set about it. She knew how to negotiate; she had the temperament for it. Within a week, the cellar floor had been covered over, with canvas stretched above it to keep out the damp.

Denny called Viktor almost every day. Nina let him use the telephone. He reported on the repairs, the healing of his stitches, and Prosha’s Russian letters.

“Good for you,” Viktor’s voice boomed down the line. “Keep in touch. Come by if you need anything.”

After a few weeks, Denny could move confidently again. The stitches were out, the pain almost gone. Only a tightness remained across his stomach. He began going outside, first as far as the corner, then farther.

One day, he reached the little café where he and Viktor had once sat together. He bought buns for Prosha to have with her tea, and scraps from the butcher for the landlady's cats. When he came back, Prosha was cleaning. The room shone. A new lamp stood on the table, bought at the flea market with money she had saved on food.

"Have you been going hungry?" Denny frowned.

"No. I'm just careful with money." She waved away his concern. "Look how nice it is!"

That evening, they sat shoulder to shoulder on the bed, wrapped in a throw. Denny showed her pictures in a book from the market. Prosha carefully read the captions, following the lines with her finger.

"It says 'ko-rabl,'" she sounded out: the Russian word for ship.

"Clever girl."

"And here… 'pu-te-shest-viye.'" Journey.

"Very good."

She put the book aside and rested her head on his shoulder.

"Do you remember the evenings in the cellar?" she asked softly. "You told me all those tall tales, made up stories. I believed every word."

Denny smiled, looking at the little flame in the lamp.

"Of course I remember."

"I liked you even then," she admitted, staring at the wall. "From the first day, I knew you were my destiny."

Author's clarification: Piroshka is over eighteen at the time of this scene.

He put his arm around her and drew her closer. She moved back a little, looked into his eyes, and kissed him.

Since that evening at Viktor's, neither had dared to do it again. Something awkward remained between them, unexplained and unspoken. But now, in the little room, with the rain outside, everything fell into place.

Denny held her close and returned the kiss, timidly at first, then more boldly. She pulled off his sweater and ran her hand over his chest and the scars that had not yet fully healed. He kissed her cheeks, her lips, her neck, stroking her hair.

“Prosha…” he whispered, breathing unevenly.

“Don’t stop,” she answered.

He took off her slip. She covered herself, shyly, but did not pull away. Denny gently moved her hand aside and pressed his lips to her nipple. She drew a deep breath, almost a moan. He caressed her body. His hand moved down her back and closed around her buttock. Prosha arched toward him.

Awkwardly, with trembling hands, he pulled off his trousers. She sat astride him, looking straight into his eyes. She touched his penis - and suddenly felt it pulse, something warm running over her fingers.

Denny went still. He looked at her, frightened and ashamed.

“I… I didn’t mean it to happen like that…” he began nervously.

She smiled, but made no move to get up. Looking him in the eye, Prosha said:

“I hope you weren’t planning to get rid of me after just once.”

Denny let out a breath and smiled back.

She slipped to the floor. Kneeling, she pressed her lips to his stomach, kissing the scars, moving lower and lower. Denny lay back against the pillow, lost in pleasure. At that moment, he belonged entirely to her, and Prosha liked that undivided possession.

Then she came back to bed and pressed her back against his chest. Denny put his arms around her, slid a hand along her thigh, and, caressing and guiding her, entered her. Her soft moan filled the room.

They made love for hours. Sometimes they lay still, catching their breath; then they reached for each other hungrily again. They dissolved into one another, lost track of time, became one.

“Stop… wait!” Denny suddenly gasped.

Prosha was astride him, moving in rhythm.

“A little longer,” she breathed, without slowing.

The bed shook, the old wire base springing beneath her hips.

“Stop!” he cried more loudly, breaking through her euphoria.

She froze, looking at him in alarm.

“What? What’s wrong? Did I do something wrong?”

Denny looked at her - and suddenly smiled.

“Prosha… please move the bedpan.”

She went still, then looked down. The rim of the enamel bedpan protruded from beneath the bed. All this time, it had been digging into his back.

Their eyes met, and they burst out laughing. Helplessly, breathlessly, until they cried. Prosha slipped out of bed, pulled out the bedpan, and put it in the far corner.

“There,” she said through her laughter. “It won’t get in the way again.”

“I hope not,” Denny answered, still laughing.

She came back, put her arms around him, and rested her cheek against his chest.

“Fool,” she whispered.

“You’re one, too.”

He kissed the crown of her head and held her tighter. Outside, the rain was easing. Somewhere far off, a dog barked. The watch on his wrist ticked steadily and peacefully. The bookmark lay in a book on the table, given a second life.

They fell asleep.

A few hours later, a dull ache in his stomach woke Denny.

Overexertion was putting it mildly. His hormones had won, and he did not regret it. Carefully, he raised himself, sat on the bed, and felt his stomach. He could not bend far enough to look at the wound. A sharp pain forced him to straighten and breathe deeply.

Prosha slept, curled up, her face peaceful, almost childlike. Denny smiled and stepped onto the rug. Barefoot, trying not to make the floorboards creak, he went to the window.

The moon hung over the canal, nearly full and cold. Its light made a silver path across the water. A streetlamp burned somewhere at the end of the road. It was so quiet that he could clearly hear his father's watch ticking on his wrist. Denny sat on a stool and rested his forehead against the cold glass. His breath misted the window at once, blurring the moon into a pale smudge.

His thoughts flowed slowly, like the water in the canal. The camp. Barbed wire. The cry he had heard then. Talking to empty space. Lilith's eyes. Budapest. Günter.

He looked at the watch. The hands moved steadily. Tick-tock. Tick-tock.

"I'm ready," he whispered into the dark. "Tomorrow. The archive. The photographs."

He sat a little longer, looking at the moon. Then he stood and, so as not to wake Piroshka, carefully lay on the floor with the throw beneath him. He settled on his side, knees drawn up, cradling his aching stitches. A strip of moonlight slowly crossed the room.

"Tomorrow," he repeated, already sinking into sleep.

It was a good morning. Piroshka, in excellent spirits, brought tea and gave him a light nudge with her foot.

"Get up, Denny! What are you doing down there? If you want to sleep on the floor, go to the cellar!" She laughed.

He sat and rubbed his eyes. She gave him a quick, playful kiss on the lips.

"I'm off to work. I'm late!"

She threw on her jacket and rushed out.

Denny sat for a minute, taking stock of how he felt. His stomach ached, but bearably. He got up, showered, and made himself presentable. In the corridor, he met Nina. She gave him a sidelong look but said nothing, only grunting to herself.

Back in the room, Denny took his archive pass from the drawer. He looked at it, sighed, and put it in the inside pocket of his jacket.

“It’s time,” he told himself, and went out.

The archive occupied an old library building, gray and shabby, with tall barred windows. Denny pushed open the heavy door and stepped inside. It smelled of dust, old paper, and something sour.

An attendant sat in the entrance hall. Denny showed his pass, went on, and saw him: the same man who had come to them with news of Tamara. Short, bespectacled, carrying a briefcase.

“Good afternoon,” Denny said uncertainly. “I’m… Denny. Here’s my pass.”

The man looked up and recognized him.

“Ah, the lad! Hello. You took your time. I’m Mikosh. I’ve been expecting you.”

He offered his hand. Denny shook it.

“Come along. I’ll explain. First, and most important: if anyone asks, you’re my trainee. An intern. Understood?”

Denny nodded.

“Second. Those shelves over there.” Mikosh waved toward the far corner. “The boxes from the concentration camp you’re looking for. Don’t touch anything else. Only what I show you. Take nothing away. Food, tea, water - outside only. Don’t bring any of it in here. Clear?”

“Clear.”

They walked between seemingly endless rows, boxes piled upon boxes. Dust hung in the air. Light barely penetrated the dirty windows.

“There’s your place.” Mikosh nodded toward a windowsill in the corner. “Make yourself comfortable.”

“Could I have a chair?” Denny asked, holding his stomach without thinking.

“A chair?” Mikosh smiled dryly. “That would be a bit much. Be glad we let you in at all.”

He turned and walked away, leaving Denny alone.

Denny went to the shelves and found the right section. The boxes were heavy and dusty. He pulled at the first. It would not move. He had to brace himself and tighten his stomach muscles. Pain shot through him at once. He hissed, but did not let go. Carefully, he dragged the box across the parquet to the windowsill.

He sat on the floor and opened it.

Inside were hundreds of yellowed cards, the ink faded, a photograph pasted into the corner of each. Denny took the first. German lettering: surname, given name, date of birth. The photograph was small and black-and-white, a number on the person’s chest. At the bottom right, a stamp:

TOT

Dead.

Denny swayed, whether from the stale air or his emotion. He knew what it meant. These people - all of them - had been where he had been. In the same hell. Only they had stayed there forever, and he had survived.

His palms grew clammy. Sweat appeared on his forehead. He caught his breath, went to the window, and drew cold air through a gap. Forced himself to calm down.

“I have to,” he repeated. “For her.”

He returned to the box and went on.

Card after card. Denny studied the faces, read the surnames, set aside those that were not hers. Some he recognized: people from his barracks, his bunkmates, those who had shared his suffering. Many had died before his eyes.

Each familiar face hurt. Denny went still over a photograph, remembering how that person had coughed at night, asked for water, fallen silent forever. Then he took a breath and reached for the next card.

Hours passed. The sun shifted, changing the angle of the light. Denny had lost all sense of time.

He drew out another form and froze. His heart beat faster. He stared at the card, and time stopped.

He remembered everything. That day. That moment. The soundless scream caught in his throat. His fingers shook. The card fell to the floor. He did not pick it up. He sank onto the cold parquet and held his head in his hands.

“Forgive me,” he whispered. “Forgive me.”

Tears ran down his face; he did not wipe them away. His shoulders shook with silent sobs.

“I didn’t mean to… I had to… she died anyway…” he whispered, choking on the words. “Forgive me. Forgive me. Forgive me…”

He could not stop. He was alive. Why him?

He sat there so long that the sun disappeared and darkness fell outside. The form still lay on the floor. The box stood open.

Mikosh came over. At the sight of Denny on the floor, he stopped beside him.

“What are you doing here?” he asked. “I thought you’d gone. I was about to have words with you for leaving without telling me.”

Denny looked up. His face was wet, red, and swollen from crying.

“Ah, young man.” Mikosh sighed and shook his head. “I understand. Digging up the past is harder than it looks.”

“I found something,” Denny answered dully. “Not what I was looking for. What I tried to forget.”

Mikosh was quiet, then patted his shoulder.

“Hold on, lad. The echo of war… It’s loud. Very loud.”

He waited a little, but Denny did not move. Mikosh sighed again and headed for the exit.

“Put everything back before you leave,” he called from the doorway.

Denny was alone. Another ten minutes passed before he forced himself to stand. He picked up the card, looked at it once more, and put it in the box. Closed the lid. With difficulty, he dragged the heavy box to the shelves and somehow pushed it back into place.

Outside, it was dark and cold, drizzling. He sat on a bench by the entrance for a long time, feeling neither the cold nor the rain. He simply sat, staring at one spot.

His thoughts fluttered like battered birds. He had protected her as best he could.

"I'm no better than they are," he whispered.

He remembered everyone he had failed to save.

"Forgive me," escaped his lips again.

The rain grew heavier. He was soaked through, but did not move. At last, he stood and trudged toward home, slowly, like an old man, dragging his feet, his head bowed.

At the corner, beside a little church, he stopped.

He crossed himself and stood looking at the dark windows and the cross barely visible against the night sky.

"Forgive me," he said aloud, and went on.

Prosha was waiting at home. She had begun to worry and kept looking into the corridor. When he entered, wet and pale, his eyes swollen, she gasped.

"Denny! What happened? Where were you? You're soaked! Take off your jacket. I'll get a towel!"

She hurried around him, pulling off the clothes heavy with water and wrapping him in a throw. He said nothing. He only looked at her with such grief that her heart tightened.

"Prosha," he said at last. "I killed a man. In the camp. Smashed his head with a stone."

She went still, her eyes fixed on him.

"You were protecting someone," she said softly. "You told me. You had no other choice."

“Protecting…” He shook his head. “But today I saw his face. On a card. And I understood… He was a person, too. What does that make me?”

She came and sat beside him, putting her arms tightly around him.

“You’re good, Denny. It was the war. The war’s to blame, not you.”

He leaned into her, buried his face in her shoulder, and wept again, quietly, exhausted. Prosha stroked his head, her fingers moving through the damp strands, whispering:

“It’ll be all right. You’ll get through it. We’ll get through it. I’m here.”

Wind sounded outside, but the room was warm and quiet. They sat together on the narrow bed, holding each other, while time moved slowly but surely on.

Denny woke late the next day. Prosha had already hurried off to work. A plate of grated carrot and boiled potato waited on the cabinet beside a note in crooked letters:

Eat it all. See you this evenning.

He smiled, but sadly.

The day before would not leave him. The face in the photograph stayed before his eyes.

He made himself eat, dressed, and went out. His feet carried him toward the house. He walked slowly, stopping every five minutes to sit on a bench or lean against a wall. His stomach still ached, and his strength returned grudgingly. But he had to get there. To his father. To the grave.

He turned into the narrow street, passed the red-brick arch, and came close to the mailbox.

Its flag was up.

Denny stopped, scarcely believing his eyes. He stepped closer and ran his fingers over the tin side, where the name was written:

GOODMAN D. U.

His hands shook as he unlocked it. Inside lay a thick envelope stamped with a coat of arms. It was addressed to "D. U. Goodman." Beneath that:

ADMINISTRATIVE. OFFICE OF THE CITY COUNCIL.

He opened the envelope, unfolded the sheet, and read. His shoulders sank.

"Dear Mr. Goodman,

"We hereby notify you of outstanding land-tax arrears. Please pay the sum of… by the end of the current month. Report to the department…"

Denny lowered his hands. The paper fluttered in the wind.

Tax. Land. Money almost gone on boards, repairs, doctors, and Prosha. Very little left. But there was the gold. He had not touched that yet.

He put the letter in his pocket and went to his father's grave. Sitting on the ground, he leaned against the sturdy new cross they had recently put up, clasped his knees, and stared into the gray sky.

"Dad," he said quietly. "I don't know whether you can hear me. Talk to me."

A crow cawed somewhere, sprang from a branch, and flew away.

"I killed a man. In the camp. He was alive, and I… with a stone…"

His voice shook. He fell silent and swallowed the lump in his throat.

"And I didn't save Mom. Or Toma. Or…" He sobbed. "I didn't save anyone, Dad. And you… you're here because of me. If I'd asked… just talked to you… I didn't think… Forgive me…"

Tears fell onto his sleeve and his watch. He wiped them away.

"I don't know why. Why? You're gone. Why is everything like this? What comes next?" He raised his head to the sky as though waiting for an answer. "Give me a sign. Answer me. Something. I have to know. What should I do?"

He waited. Silence. Only the wind rustled the burned boards.

“Forgive me,” he whispered, resting his forehead against the cross. “Forgive me for being like this. I can’t be any different. I remember what you taught me: ‘If you promise, do it. If you’re not sure, keep quiet.’”

He sat a little longer, wiped his face with his sleeve, and stood. His knees shook. He ought to check the cellar. He had not been down there for a while.

He went down the steps, moved the plywood aside, and entered. It was dark, with a sour, sickening smell. He narrowed his eyes, adjusting to the dimness, and heard a sound.

Someone was grunting and wheezing in a corner.

Denny tensed and took a step forward. A figure hunched against the wall emerged from the darkness. He went closer - and recoiled.

Ilona.

She lay on the floor, covered in vomit, filthy and pitiful. A fine tremor shook her body. Her eyes rolled back, showing the whites; her lips were blue. A syringe lay beside her.

“Ilona!” Denny dropped to his knees and shook her shoulder. “Ilona, can you hear me?”

She did not respond, only wheezed and shuddered. Denny turned her onto her side so she would not choke. She was frighteningly light, almost weightless.

Breathing. Barely, but breathing.

“Just a moment. Hold on,” he said anxiously.

The pain in his stomach, the weakness in his legs - everything fell away. He jumped up and ran outside, to the same neighbors he had once asked for help. He hammered on the door.

“Help! Someone’s dying! Call an ambulance! Quickly!”

A woman opened the door. Recognizing him, she gasped and rushed to the telephone. Denny stood panting, a hand against the wall.

The ambulance arrived about forty minutes later. All that time, Denny sat by the cellar entrance, afraid Ilona would die before it came. When the orderlies carried her into the light, he saw her face: bluish, gaunt, deep shadows beneath her eyes.

A young, tired nurse quickly examined her and rolled up a sleeve. Needle marks covered the veins; some places had become inflamed.

"Looks as though she's taken too much," she said, looking at Denny. "We'll flush her out for now. After that… You understand."

"Take her to the hospital," Denny asked.

The nurse shook her head.

"The hospitals are full. There isn't room even without people like her. Patients are lying in the corridors. We'll help her here, put her on saline. After that, it's down to luck."

Denny looked at the nurse, then at Ilona. He remembered her laughing, taunting him the last time they met, and driving that piece of metal into his side. But he reached into his pocket and felt the crumpled banknotes. He drew the nurse aside and discreetly pressed them into her hand.

"Here. Take it. It's all I have. Please help her."

The nurse looked at the money, pursed her lips, and hesitated for a second.

"Well… all right. We'll try. I can't promise. We'll see what we can do."

She nodded to the orderlies. They put Ilona in the ambulance and drove away.

Denny was alone. Slowly, he went back into the yard and sat on the boards by the entrance, looking at his father's grave. Sunlight broke through the clouds and lit the cross.

"A strange sign," he whispered. "I don't understand, Dad. I don't understand at all."

He sat a little longer, took out the letter, and read it again.

Taxes are serious business. You don't play games with them.

He thought that was what his father had said. Denny had understood none of it then.

He set off for the administration offices. He had to sort out the taxes, find out what it all meant. He was worried; he knew nothing about such things. He trudged over the old cobblestones. The administration building was close by. The Goodman property lay right in the center of this small town, the town that was home to him.

Denny knocked.

"Yes. Come in."

The office was enormous, with high, molded ceilings and heavy curtains. Behind a large, polished wooden desk sat a small, fat man with a thin mustache and spectacles on a chain. He did not even look up as Denny entered.

"What is it?" he asked in a creaking voice.

"I'm Goodman. I've had this letter."

"Goodman? Means nothing to me."

"Here." Denny held out the letter.

The official took it, scanned it, and grunted.

"You have debts, Mr. Goodman. Taxes don't like to wait." At last, he raised his eyes and gave Denny an ironic look.

"Tell me how much, please. And when do I pay?"

"Is this the ruined house in the center, opposite the old office building?" the man asked with sudden interest.

"Yes. That's right."

"Sit down, young man."

Denny sat opposite him. The official looked him over: battered jacket, pale face, bags beneath the eyes. His little piglike eyes darted from side to side, assessing, weighing.

"My name is Janos," he said. "I'm in charge of taxes and levies here. Just a moment. Let me find… Somewhere here… Ah. There."

He took a fat folder from the desk, leafed through it, and drew out several sheets.

"Well, my boy. You're very much in arrears. You inherited more than a year ago, and no payments have been made since 1943. It's mounted up. Quite a sum."

Denny swallowed.

"How much?"

"Here. Look for yourself."

Janos handed him the paper. Denny read the figure and lost his breath. It was a large sum. Very large. He gripped the leather armrest of the chair.

"And it must be paid by the thirtieth," the official added, enjoying his reaction. "Otherwise, it goes to court. The land may be confiscated. And there'll be an investigation. How is it, young man, that you've ignored your taxes all this time?"

Denny said nothing, thinking desperately. Would the gold he had left be enough? If he sold everything he could… Would it cover it?

"Could I pay in installments?" he asked. "It's a great deal of money."

Janos smiled. An oily smile, like a cat eyeing a bowl of cream.

"Look, my boy," he said soothingly. "I'd be glad to help, but these debts go back too far. They won't approve an extension. Those are the rules."

Denny sighed heavily.

"But…" The official rose, approached, and put a plump hand on his shoulder. "I can make you an offer."

"What offer?" Denny grew alert, hoping for an extension, or perhaps that the man wanted a bribe.

"I could buy the property. With all the junk that's left on it."

Denny flinched as though struck.

“Don’t worry.” Janos patted his shoulder. “I’ll pay everything for you, and there’ll be something left over for you, too. There’s nothing there anyway. Just a cellar.”

“My father’s there,” Denny blurted out. “I mean… buried there. It’s the Goodman family home.”

“Home?” The official smiled dryly and returned to his chair. “It’s a ruin, boy. Open your eyes. It’s a very good offer, and your debt is enormous. If you’re late, they’ll take it anyway. This way, at least you’ll get some money. We’ll bury your father properly, too. In the cemetery. It’s the best solution. I want to help you.”

Denny stood. For a few seconds, he looked at the man, at the piglike eyes and the false smile.

“No,” he said firmly. “Thank you. I’ll find the money.”

“Be quick about it. If you change your mind, come back,” Janos called after him.

Outside, Denny caught his breath. His hands shook.

I’ll find it. It’s my home. Ours alone. Our family’s.

The old craftsman was working on a mechanism when Denny entered. Seeing him, he set aside his magnifying glass and smiled.

“Ah, it’s you! Been a while. How’s the watch?”

“Fine.” Denny held out his wrist. “Running like new.”

“I told you!” The watchmaker nodded with satisfaction. “What can I do for you? Another watch?”

“No.” Denny glanced around, took the bundle from inside his clothes, laid it on the counter, and opened one corner. “This. Will you take it all?”

The watchmaker looked at the gold. His face grew serious. He stood, went to the door, and slid the bolt.

“Stolen?” he asked quietly but sternly.

“No! Of course not.” Denny was frightened. “My parents left it.”

A lie. He was no good at lying, but he had to. The watchmaker looked at him for a long moment, then nodded.

"Come through, then."

He led Denny into the back room, which smelled of metal and oil. Tools covered the walls. Three rows of narrow shelves held jars for tiny parts. The man brought out a small set of scales. He spent a long time weighing, examining through his glass, setting one piece aside, scrutinizing another. Finally, he named a sum.

Denny had no idea whether it was a fair valuation. But he had no choice. This was his only chance. The money almost covered the tax.

"I agree," he breathed.

They shook hands.

"Thank you." Denny hesitated, looking at the bundle the watchmaker was putting into a safe. "Excuse me… Could you add just a little more?"

The man turned and raised an eyebrow in surprise. Then he smiled.

"A big purchase coming up, is it? All right. Come back in two days. I'll get the money together. I'll add a little."

Denny left the shop with a light heart. It would work. It would all work.

Prosha was waiting at home. As usual, she bustled about, clattering pots, dusting, humming to herself. At the sight of Denny, she jumped up and kissed his cheek.

While she set the table, he decided to call Viktor.

"How are you, Uncle Vitya?"

"Fine." Viktor sounded cheerful. "Where have you been hiding? When are you coming to see me?"

"In three days. It's the last Sunday of the month. The grave."

"Oh, of course!" From the sound, Viktor had slapped his forehead. "Work's swallowed me up."

Viktor went on, “Why don’t we come back to our place after the cemetery? Stay a day, at least. We’ll remember her properly. Keep me company.”

Denny smiled.

“All right,” he said. “I’ll tell Prosha I’m staying the night. I’ll get the flowers myself.”

“Agreed. I’ll pick you up.”

He hung up and went back to the room.

They sat down to dinner. Prosha could hardly leave him alone: kissing him, slipping an arm around him, stroking his hand. She was happy. She shone so brightly that the room seemed lighter.

“What are you so happy about, Prosha?” Denny asked, chewing his boiled potato.

“Me? Look. Can’t you see?” She jumped up and turned before him.

Denny watched, baffled.

“What? I don’t see.”

“The dress, silly! The dress!” She laughed. “Someone I know made it. Cheap. Look!”

He looked more closely. An ordinary cotton dress with a tiny flower pattern and frills. Prosha spun, catching his eye, radiant with delight.

“Well…” Denny said slowly. “I don’t know…”

She stopped and pouted.

“What do you mean, you don’t know? Don’t you like it?”

Denny smiled and pushed his plate aside.

“Come here.”

She came. He put his arms around her waist and drew her closer.

“I like you much better without it,” he whispered in her ear. “Take it off. Quickly.”

Piroshka laughed playfully, let the dress fall to the floor, and nothing else mattered.

The morning was gray but dry. Denny woke before Prosha. For a long time, he lay looking at the ceiling, then dressed quietly and went out.

The archive greeted him with its familiar smell of dust and old paper. At the entrance, a potbellied guard with a newspaper gave him a leisurely nod.

“Here you are,” he said without interest. “Go through.”

Inside, it was warm, even stuffy. The windows seemed never to be opened. Years of dirt had formed a film on the inside of the glass. Denny went to his boxes, still where he had left them. The two remaining ones. He paused, remembering the archivist’s advice:

Keep your distance, lad. Treat it as work. Otherwise, it’ll eat you alive.

He took a deep breath and opened the first box.

Card after card. Faces, faces, faces. Denny studied every photograph. Men, women, children. Some looked straight at the camera. Others averted their eyes. Others already seemed half dead. He sorted them carefully, putting them in order, even returning the mixed-up cards to their proper places. The work calmed and distracted him.

After about three hours, he felt hungry. He put a card aside, stood, and stretched his stiff back. Outside, he bought a cabbage pastry from an old woman and sat on the bench in front of the archive.

His thoughts drifted far away. Childhood. Mom. Dad… Their walks along the embankment. The things his father had taught him… He could almost feel the touch of his father’s warm hand.

“Denny!”

Someone really had touched his shoulder. He started and turned. The archivist stood beside him: short, gray-haired, with thick spectacles. He sat on the bench and took out a cigarette.

“Lost in thought? I see you’re finding your feet.”

“Oh, just…” Denny gave an apologetic smile.

“It happens. When I first started, I looked at every card as though it were a living person, too. Then I got used to it. You have to. Otherwise, you’d go mad.”

He drew on the cigarette and released a cloud of thick smoke.

“You’re doing well, by the way. Keeping everything in order.”

“I wanted to ask. What university sends people here for practical training?”

“Oh. An admirable interest. It’s an institution in Budapest. Very prestigious. If you want a life among papers, that’s the place.”

“I hadn’t thought of it. But my parents were well educated.”

“If you like, I could put in a word for you at the dean’s office.”

Denny looked surprised.

“Do you think I could do it?”

“Why not? The main thing is to try. You did well at school. Viktor told me.”

They were silent for a while. Then Denny asked:

“How did you meet Viktor?”

Mikosh gave a short grunt, took off his glasses, and wiped them with the edge of his jacket.

“Viktor… That’s a story of its own. In 1944, they nearly shot me. Suspected I had links with the partisans. Took me into the woods and stood me by a pit. I’d started saying goodbye to life. Then, out of nowhere, he appeared. German uniform, papers, Gestapo. He tore into those Krauts, shouted that they were idiots, that I was an important witness and they weren’t to touch me. Took me away, brought me to a house, locked me in. At night, he came back, gave me money and some papers, and told me what to do to stay alive. Later, I found out he’d been working among the Germans, getting our people out. Risked his life every day. I’m alive because of him.”

Denny listened, holding his breath. So that was the kind of man Uncle Viktor was.

“All right.” Mikosh stood. “We’ve sat here long enough. If you need anything, ask.”

They returned to the archive. Denny sat down before the boxes again. But now his thoughts had changed. University. Education… Perhaps he should try. His father would have been proud. His mother…

He took another card.

And the world stopped.

In the yellowed photograph was a face he knew and loved. Thin, exhausted, but the eyes were bright and alive even in the picture. Denny would have known them among a thousand.

His hands began to shake. The card slipped; he caught it and gripped it. Then he slowly lowered himself onto the floor and leaned against the warm radiator.

Everything around him lost its edges and blurred.

The barracks. Cold. She is beside him, shivering. He covers her with his own body. The drone of aircraft. Explosions. Screams. They run, fall, get up. Wire. He tears at it with his bare hands, feeling no pain. She runs behind him, stumbling. He turns and reaches out - and sees her flung aside. She falls. He rushes to her, lifts her, drags her. Her body grows heavy, impossibly heavy, filling with lead.

Then silence.

Denny sat on the floor, gripping the card, unaware of the tears running down his cheeks. Time stopped, giving way to the past he had so badly wanted to forget.

“Denny!” Mikosh’s voice came from far away. “Planning to stay the night? Time to close. Come on!”

Denny came back to himself. He wiped his face with his sleeve and looked at the photograph again. Carefully, he folded the card and put it in his inside pocket. He stood, silently gathered the boxes, and put them back. Mikosh watched with understanding.

“Bring it back when you feel able,” he said as they parted. “It isn’t only your history.”

Denny went outside and walked away quickly. Houses, people, cars, trees - everything blurred before his eyes. He noticed none of it, pressing the card to his chest as though it were the essential proof of his life.

Prosha met him at home. She had come back from work, set the table, and waited.

“Denny! Where were you? I was worried! Sit down. I’ve fried potatoes with onions. Just how you like them…”

He walked past without a word, sat on the bed, and stared at one spot.

“Denny?” Prosha came over and touched his shoulder. “What happened? What’s wrong?”

“Leave it. It’s private,” he said dully. “Not now.”

“But…”

“Prosha, please. Don’t.”

She went still, her lips pressed together in hurt. After a moment, she turned abruptly and went to the kitchen. He could hear her sobbing there.

Denny did not move. He heard her walking, clattering dishes, crying, but could not make himself go to her and explain. The words stuck in his throat.

After a while, Prosha came out.

“I’m going to Auntie Nina’s,” she said coldly. “I’ll sit there. You… do whatever you want.”

The door slammed. Denny was alone.

He sat for a long time, looking at the card and his mother’s bookmark. Then he closed his eyes and cried. Quietly, without a sound, as only those whose childhood was shattered by the echo of war know how to cry.

Chapter 11

Morning brought a gray sky and a heavy heart.

He lay on the bed, staring at the ceiling, listening to Nina grumble in the corridor and the first barges sound their horns somewhere on the canal. Prosha had already gone to work, after making love to him - silently, but with great passion.

He got up, dressed, and checked that the card was still inside his clothes. Today, he and Viktor were going to Tamara's grave. Every month, on the last Sunday.

A car horn sounded outside. Denny picked up the tulips, an even number, in the Russian custom Viktor had taught him. He went downstairs, opened the door, and jumped into the passenger seat.

Viktor sat looking straight ahead, serious. He gave a brief nod.

"Let's go."

They said nothing on the way. Each lived through this day in his own way. Denny watched houses, trees, and people pass the window. They all went about their lives, knowing nothing of the heart breaking inside him or the admission he could barely keep from spilling out. Viktor glanced at him now and then, but said nothing.

Sometimes silence was better than any words.

It was not far to the cemetery. Old crosses, leaning headstones, a few fresh flowers on the graves. The communal burial place where Tamara lay was modest: a granite slab carved with names, hers among them. Every time, Viktor stood before it for a long while.

They approached. Denny laid down the flowers and crossed himself. Viktor whispered a prayer in Russian, quickly, almost inaudibly. Denny knelt and touched the cold stone.

"Aunt Toma," he whispered. "Forgive me. I didn't understand anything then. But now... now I know."

He stopped, a lump rising in his throat. Viktor finished his prayer, sighed heavily, and sat on the edge of the monument. Denny stayed on his knees, unable to rise.

“Uncle Vitya,” he said quietly, turning. “I found her. As I promised.”

Viktor turned his head and looked at him questioningly.

Denny reached inside his clothes, took out the carefully folded card, and handed it to him. Viktor unfolded it and brought it closer.

A girl looked out from the photograph. Thin, exhausted, her hair cropped short, her frightened eyes enormous.

Viktor said nothing for a long time. Then, slowly and very gently, he ran a finger over the photograph. Tenderly, like a father. Suddenly, a tear rolled down his cheek, over the coarse gray stubble. He did not wipe it away, letting it fall onto his chest.

“My dear niece,” he said dully. “We’ve found you, too.”

Denny swallowed, gathered his courage, and spoke.

“Elizaveta Koshtina.”

Viktor nodded without looking away from the photograph. But Denny went on.

“No, Uncle Vitya. She really is Elizaveta. Not Lilith.”

Viktor turned sharply, bewildered.

“What do you mean?” His voice sounded strange.

“I’ll explain. Just a moment.” Denny took a deep breath, gathering his thoughts. “By then, in the camp, I’d already lost my mind. After everything. They brought the girl in the same evening as us. Her eyes were green, like Lilith’s. So I made her Lilith. It was easier for me, I suppose. So I wouldn’t go completely mad. I kept her warm, shared my bread with her. She didn’t object, though she probably didn’t understand why I called her by someone else’s name. Aunt Toma tried to explain, but I wouldn’t listen. To me, that girl became Lilith. She was the one they killed during the escape. The one I tried to carry. But Lilith…” He faltered.

Viktor stared, his mouth open. Shock, hope, and disbelief mingled in his eyes.

“Then Lilith…” he began.

“I don’t know,” Denny interrupted. “I didn’t want to raise your hopes again. I decided to find her first, make sure for myself, then tell you.”

Viktor leaned back. After a silence, he asked:

“And Tamara? She didn’t have her with her?”

“That’s how I understood it. She tried to tell me they’d managed to hand Lilith over or hide her. I didn’t listen. I couldn’t understand then. After killing that fascist, I stopped understanding anything.”

Viktor suddenly stood, took Denny by the shoulders, and helped him up from his knees.

“Let’s go. We need to think this through. And have a drink to the new information.”

They hurried toward the car. Hope hung in the air, fragile but real.

Familiar smells greeted Denny: tobacco, old books, cologne. He stopped on the threshold. Everything was as before. His mug stood in its usual place in the kitchen. The sofa where he had slept so often had not even been opened out since their last meeting. Only now did he understand why Viktor had said nothing about the gift and the note.

He smiled and went to the table.

Viktor was already clattering about in the kitchen, taking out a bottle.

“What are you sitting down for? Get the pork fat. I’ll open the pickles and find some potatoes. Without food, it’s alcoholism, not drinking.”

Denny hurried to help. Five minutes later, the table was laden: thin slices of cured pork fat, pickles, potatoes boiled in their skins, dark bread. Viktor poured vodka into the little glasses and raised his own.

“To my sister. God rest Tamara’s soul.”

“To Aunt Toma,” Denny repeated quietly.

They drank and ate. Chewing the pork fat with relish, Viktor looked thoughtfully at Denny.

“Right. Lilith could have been hidden. Handed over to the partisans. Taken somewhere else. She could have…” He broke off. “Anyway, we start looking again. The nearby villages, former partisans, old contacts. I know a couple of fellows who can help.”

Denny nodded. Hope lit his eyes; his whole face seemed to brighten. Viktor noticed, smiled, and poured a second round.

“Come on, kid. Let’s hope she’s alive. To Lilith.”

They clinked glasses and drank. Warmth spread through Denny’s body, but his head was clear. They discussed plans, recalled the past, made guesses. For the first time in a long while, he felt the future might be bright, and the past might stop confronting him with riddles he could not solve.

Then a knock cut everything short. Hard, forceful, demanding.

Viktor tensed instantly. With a look, he told Denny to stay where he was. He rose slowly, went to the cabinet where he usually kept his pistol, and slipped a hand beneath the newspaper.

“Who is it?” he barked.

“One of ours. Open up.”

Viktor recognized the voice, but did not relax. The lock clicked. A man stood on the threshold in a long leather coat exactly like Viktor’s. Behind him were two soldiers with rifles.

“Oleg,” Viktor said calmly, though something in his voice had changed. “What is it?”

Oleg stepped forward without asking permission. The soldiers followed and spread out around the room.

“You know the rules.” Oleg’s voice was level, almost friendly, but his eyes stayed cold. “Let’s do this peacefully. As friends.”

Viktor stepped back to let him pass. Denny sat motionless at the table, unsure what to do, watching closely.

“A complaint’s come in,” Oleg went on. “To our Special Department. We had to come for you.”

“What complaint? What nonsense is this?” Viktor tried to stay calm, but his jaw tightened.

“Search and questioning.” Oleg shrugged. “You know the procedure. Lads, have a look around.”

The soldiers began methodically searching the cupboards, opening drawers, shaking out belongings. One went to the cabinet, took out Viktor’s pistol, and silently handed it to Oleg. Oleg turned it over in his hands and tucked it into his belt.

“What complaint?” Viktor asked sharply. “Who made it?”

“A certain Günter.” Oleg smiled. “Persistent fellow. Wrote to every office you could imagine. Says he was beaten and robbed. Here we are.”

Denny jerked, but Viktor gave an almost imperceptible shake of his head: silence. He gestured for Denny to sit.

“Abuse of authority, bodily harm, and theft on a particularly large scale,” Oleg listed. “Could mean up to ten years. If it’s proved, of course.”

Viktor said nothing. Only the muscles in his jaw moved.

“Say what you like.” Oleg shrugged. “If it’s slander, we’ll punish the complainant. If it’s true… you understand.”

The search went on. Viktor came to Denny and put a hand on his shoulder.

“Don’t lose your nerve. They’ve got nothing.”

Denny opened his mouth, but the words stuck. Cold sweat broke out on his forehead.

“Found it!” one soldier shouted.

Oleg went quickly to the sofa. In the soldier's hands was the familiar cloth bundle, the gold Denny had left as a gift. The note lay beside it.

Oleg picked it up, unfolded it, and read aloud, drawing out the words.

"'To... my... dear... Uncle... Vitya. Thank... you... for... everything.'" He looked at Denny. "Nice handwriting, lad. Come here."

Denny stood. His legs would hardly obey him. He went over. Oleg thrust the bundle toward his face.

"Where did it come from? Where did you get it?"

"It's... it's mine," Denny forced out, glancing at Viktor.

"Yours?" Oleg smiled, his eyes still icy. "Got papers to prove it? Don't tell me it's an inheritance."

Denny said nothing. Viktor stepped between them.

"Oleg, he's a boy. I'm responsible for him. Let's sort this out ourselves. Quietly."

"Quietly?" Oleg raised an eyebrow. "Were you asking Günter quietly when you broke his nose? He's talked our ears off about your methods."

He turned to the soldiers.

"Lads, take everything. The owner and his helper, too. We'll sort it out at headquarters."

Viktor looked at Denny. There was no anger in his eyes, only weariness and a strange tenderness.

"Kid," he said softly, so the others could not hear. "Keep quiet. You don't know. It isn't yours. Understood?"

Denny nodded, feeling tears rise. Viktor gave his shoulder a small shake.

They were taken outside and put into a black Pobeda. The car was cramped and stuffy. Denny watched streetlamps recede through the window. Viktor sat beside him, looking straight ahead.

“Uncle Vitya,” Denny whispered. “I’m a fool… Forgive me.”

Viktor did not turn. He only laid his heavy hand on Denny’s knee and squeezed.

The car pulled away, carrying them into the unknown.

In the apartment, half-finished glasses remained on the table, beside uneaten pork fat and cold potatoes. And hope, only just beginning to come back to life.

Denny was dragged out before he could properly look around. A gray building. Barred windows, sandbags filling the openings instead of glass. Barbed wire along the top of the fence.

They led them down a dark brick corridor. Dim light, a vile smell. They were taken in different directions. Footsteps echoed in the silence. Denny looked back, but Viktor was already gone, led deeper into the building.

A heavy iron door opened, and Denny was shoved inside. It was a basement room, with bare walls painted green halfway up. A single bulb hung from a wire beneath the ceiling. In the middle stood a table and two chairs. A lamp sat on the table beside an empty meat tin used as an ashtray.

They put Denny on a chair and fastened handcuffs behind his back. The metal bit into his wrists. His arms went numb at once.

He was alone.

How much time had passed? An hour? Two? The bulb flickered, throwing dancing shadows over the walls. His thoughts tangled. Where was Viktor? What were they doing to him? What would happen now?

I’ve landed him in it. My fault again. First Dad, now Uncle Vitya. What’s wrong with me? The damned gold. That bastard Günter…

He remembered Viktor’s instruction: keep quiet.

At last, the bolt clanged. Two men entered: a man in uniform with shoulder boards, and a soldier carrying an automatic weapon. The captain brought a thin folder, threw it on the table, and sat

opposite him. The soldier stood behind Denny and, to intimidate him, pressed a knee into his back.

The man was no longer young, with deep lines around his eyes and a thick mustache. He looked like a typical career officer, the sort Denny had often seen in town.

"Stepan Ivanovich Kovach. Investigating officer, Special Department of the Ministry of State Security," he introduced himself.

Unhurriedly, he lit a cigarette and blew smoke toward the ceiling. Then he switched on the desk lamp and turned it straight into Denny's face. Denny squeezed his eyes shut and turned away.

"Light hurting your eyes?" the captain asked calmly. "You'll get used to it. Now. Surname, first name, patronymic."

"Daniel Goodman," Denny forced through his dry lips.

"Goodman."

"Yes. My father was William Goodman."

The captain made a note, leaned back, and studied him with idle curiosity.

"Tell me. Your own account, to the point. What were you doing at the apartment of a certain Günter? All the details. Who came with you, when, who did the beating, who did the stealing."

Denny looked away and said nothing.

"I'm waiting." The captain drew on his cigarette.

"I don't remember," Denny said quietly.

"What?"

"I don't remember. Lost my memory after the wound."

The captain smiled, without pleasure.

"Don't be stupid, boy. Tell me nicely. Easier for everyone. I'll ask a second time. What were you doing at Günter's?"

"I don't remember any Günter."

The captain sighed heavily, rose, came around the table, and perched on its edge, very close to Denny.

“Listen, lad. I’m giving you friendly advice. You can go down as a witness. You’ll get a sentence, but a short one. Keep being stubborn, and you’ll be an accomplice. That’s a serious charge. Understood?”

Denny said nothing.

“I asked if you understood.”

“I don’t remember any Günter.”

The captain gave the soldier an almost invisible nod. From behind, the soldier seized Denny’s shoulders and pinned him against himself. Kovach swung and struck hard with the back of his hand. The glove burned across Denny’s face. His head snapped aside. Blood appeared on his lips.

“Remember now?” the captain asked calmly.

Denny shook his head and spat blood onto the floor.

The blows came one after another. Methodical, professional, meant not to knock him out but to make the pain unbearable. Cheekbone, jaw, ear. The captain stopped, lit a cigarette, asked the same question, and struck again. Denny said nothing, only shrinking back and narrowing his eyes whenever the hand rose.

At some point, he could no longer stay on the stool and fell to the floor. The soldier moved to lift him, but the captain waved him off. Leave him. He kicked Denny beneath the ribs, then again in the kidneys. Denny grunted and curled up on the cold cement, pain exploding through his body.

Kovach sat at the table and lit another cigarette.

“Bring water,” he told the soldier.

The soldier left. Silence filled the room, broken only by Denny’s labored breathing as he lay on his side. The captain finished his cigarette, came over, and crouched beside him.

“Listen,” he said quietly. “Viktor says you’re to sign what I give you. He also said he owes you. Whatever that means.”

Denny flinched. Cold sweat instantly mixed with the blood on his face.

Viktor said that? But he told me to keep quiet. Now to sign? Is he lying?

With difficulty, he raised his head. Everything swam before his eyes, but he could see the captain's outline clearly.

"I… don't remember anything…" he rasped.

The captain smiled. Not cruelly. Almost with respect.

"Stubborn one, aren't you?" He paused. "He told me to give you a phrase, so you'd know it came from him. 'When we get back, we'll wolf down some cabbage soup.'"

Denny went still. Those words. Only Viktor spoke like that. Their words, from the very first day. No one else could have known.

He gave a faint nod, as much as the pain in his neck allowed.

"Come to me tomorrow at nine in the evening," the captain said, and gave an address.

Denny fixed on the numbers and names, trying to remember. He nodded again to show he had heard. The door opened. The soldier came in with a carafe.

"Water, Comrade Captain."

"Here." Kovach took it, drank straight from the neck, then splashed some over Denny as though trying to bring him round. "Get him up."

The soldier set the chair upright, lifted Denny, and sat him on it. The captain took a sheet from the folder, laid it on the table, and turned the lamp so the words could be seen.

"Look. Your friend's statement. If you agree this is what happened, sign it."

Denny leaned toward the table, squinting in the bright light. He began to read. The letters blurred, but the meaning reached him. Viktor had written it all himself. They had gone to Günter's together, but Denny had only accompanied him and shown him what Günter looked like. He had taken no part in the beating. Viktor accepted all the blame.

Denny froze. His handcuffed hands began to tremble.

“Sign.” The captain pushed the pen toward him.

“What about Viktor?” Denny forced out. “What will happen to him?”

“Don’t waste time!” The captain raised his voice. “Sign! The court will decide.”

He jabbed a finger at the signature line.

Denny looked at the paper. If he signed, Viktor would go to prison. It felt like betrayal. But they had told him to sign. If he refused… what then? Would they kill him here? Would things be even worse for Viktor?

He took the pen in trembling fingers and wrote his name.

The captain took the sheet, checked it, and nodded to the soldier.

“Take him out.”

They seized Denny beneath the arms, dragged him from the building, and threw him outside like a sack of garbage. He hit the cold ground. Pain shot through his body, but he forced himself to get up.

It was dark. The moon hung above the roofs; a cold wind drove scraps of trash over the cobblestones. Lights shone in some windows. Inside, people lived ordinary lives, knowing nothing of what happened behind the walls of the Special Department.

Denny trudged on. His legs would hardly obey, his ribs ached, his face was swollen, but he walked. To their home. Viktor’s apartment.

The door was unlocked. He went in and stopped.

Chaos. Drawers pulled out, belongings scattered over the floor, books in a shapeless heap.

He stood looking at the wreckage, then began picking things up automatically. A book, back on the shelf. Viktor’s shirt, carefully folded. An overturned chair, set upright.

After a few minutes, his strength gave out. He sank to the floor amid the chaos, held his head in his hands, and cried.

Without a sound, only his shoulders shaking. For himself, for Viktor, for everything that had come down on them. Around him was a ransacked home, a broken life, and the frightening unknown ahead.

In his ears, the words went on:

When we get back, we'll wolf down some cabbage soup.

Denny woke on the floor among the scattered things. The first thing he felt was pain. His whole body ached. His face burned. Every breath sent a dull pain through his ribs. He sat up and looked around. Viktor's apartment resembled a battlefield.

He forced himself to stand and finish the cleaning. Mechanically, like clockwork: the surviving books back in place, what remained of the clothes folded, whatever could still be saved pushed back into the drawers. He simply spread a throw over the sofa.

In the kitchen, he found yesterday's potatoes in a saucepan. He ate straight from it, standing at the window and looking at the gray sky. His thoughts moved heavily, as though packed in cotton wool.

Viktor. What was happening to him? What came next?

He washed his face as well as his split lip allowed, combed his hair, and put on a clean shirt. In the cloudy hall mirror, lost eyes stared back at him.

I need to go to Prosha.

The canteen where she worked was near the station. Denny went in and looked around. Fried onions, meat patties. Women bustled behind the counter, but Prosha was not among them. He went to the serving counter and caught the eye of a stout woman in a white cap.

"I'm looking for Piroshka."

She looked him over - the bruises, the split lip - and frowned.

"Who are you to her?"

"Tell her Denny's here."

She shook her head doubtfully, but disappeared through the kitchen door. Soon Prosha came out, wearing a cook's apron, her hair beneath a headscarf, her face intent on work. At the sight of Denny, she stopped for a second, then gasped. She rushed to him and threw her arms around him, but drew back at once, taking his face between her palms and turning it gently.

"Denny! What happened? Who did this? Where were you?"

"Prosha." He interrupted. "Later. Can you get away?"

She looked at him, nodded, and hurried back into the kitchen without a word. A few minutes later, she emerged without the apron, grabbed his hand, and pulled him toward the exit.

"Come on. I've left everything. The boss is angry. I don't care."

At home, in their little room, Denny told her everything. Günter first. The arrest, the questioning, the beating. Viktor taking all the blame. Prosha listened without speaking, only sighing and stroking his hair.

"It's my fault," Denny finished. "Without me and that gold, none of it would have happened. How do we get him out now?"

Prosha looked out of the window, thinking. Then she turned.

"Could we pay someone? Buy him out? I've saved a little. I work. I'm careful. Take it."

Denny looked at her. The determination in her eyes was infectious.

"Thank you, Prosha. But I don't know who to give it to. I don't know anyone there. I'm meeting the captain who beat me this evening. He knows Uncle Vitya. Maybe he can tell me something."

Prosha came and sat beside him, putting her arms around him.

"I'm with you. I'm here."

He held her close and buried his face in her red hair, which smelled of the kitchen and soap.

That evening, Denny stood before a peeling door in an old house near the embankment. This was the address the captain had given

him. He had come half an hour early. Now he hovered outside, not daring to knock.

The door opened. Captain Kovach stood there, out of uniform, in a plain shirt and suspenders. A cigarette smoked in his hand.

“Come in, lad. Don’t stand about out here,” he said without greeting.

Denny stepped inside. The apartment was small but comfortable. Clean, with bookshelves on the walls and an old radio in the corner. It smelled of tobacco.

“Kitchen. Go on, sit down.” The captain nodded toward a door.

Denny took off his shoes and went through. The kitchen was tiny but bright. Two glasses and an ashtray were already on the table, beside a packet of cigarettes. Kovach opened the small window vent and sat opposite him.

Denny could not wait.

“How is he?”

The captain lit a fresh cigarette without hurry and exhaled smoke.

“All right. Viktor knows the rules.” He paused. “You’ve certainly made a mess.”

“It’s my fault,” Denny breathed.

The captain gave him a strange look, not angry, more appraising.

“Listen. I’ve known Viktor a long time. Since 1944. We got into a difficult business once. One of ours, a local man, had helped himself to a lot of things. Thought the war would wipe the slate clean. Viktor caught him. Wouldn’t let him steal. He could have looked the other way. Nobody would have known. But he didn’t. Said, ‘We didn’t shed our blood so men like you could profit from other people’s grief.’” The captain gave a short grunt. “A decent man. Not many like him.”

Denny listened, holding his breath.

“But this… Gold. Money.”

“It was because of me,” Denny said firmly. “Günter cheated me out of everything. Viktor only went with me to get it back. He wasn’t robbing him. He was taking back what was mine.”

“And Günter’s a bastard, then?” The captain narrowed his eyes.

“Worse. He saw I was a child, and took everything. The girl I was trying to save…” Denny faltered. “It’s a long story.”

Kovach nodded and stubbed out the cigarette.

“Now I understand why Viktor went so far.” He paused. “He asked me to tell you: no heroics. Keep quiet. Said you saved him once. I didn’t understand, but that’s what he said. Now it’s his turn to get you out of trouble. Everything will be all right. His statement says he did it all himself. You were just there. Knew nothing.”

“What will happen to him?” Denny asked quietly. “Will they shoot him?”

“No. Of course not.” The captain waved a hand. “He’ll live. Don’t worry. But stay free… I doubt it. They’ll strip his rank and put him away.”

He stood, took a partly empty bottle from the cupboard, and poured into the glasses.

“Come on. To Viktor.”

They clinked glasses and drank. The vodka burned Denny’s throat, but he did not even wince.

“Right.” Stepan lit another cigarette. “Abuse of authority costs him his rank. Bodily harm in the course of duty, up to three years. Robbery…” He spread his hands. “If it’s proved, up to ten. But Viktor has plenty of commendations. An excellent service record. I think they’ll cut it down.”

“Ten years,” Denny repeated. “Because of me.”

“You’re not to blame for Günter being a swine.” The captain poured another round. “Come on. Don’t lose heart.”

They drank in silence. Kovach looked at the bruises on Denny’s face and sighed.

“About that… I’m sorry. Had to make it convincing. Otherwise, they wouldn’t have believed you knew nothing.”

Denny waved it away. Nothing.

“What can we do?” he asked. “Pay someone, perhaps?”

“No.” The captain shook his head. “They won’t take it. Offer, and you’ll be locked up, too. There’s only one way. Günter changes his statement. Withdraws the complaint, says there was no robbery. Then they’ll just dismiss Viktor and let him go. But the bastard wrote it all down in detail. Wrote everywhere - the police, the Ministry, anywhere he could. They’ll summon him, wait for him to arrive, review everything… I’d say the trial will be in a month or two.”

“Give me his address.” Denny leaned forward. “We went there, but I didn’t remember it.”

The captain stood, went to the other room, and returned with a folder. He leafed through it, took out a sheet, and held it out.

“His details. And the address.”

Denny read and memorized it.

“Thank you.”

“Don’t mention it.” Kovach poured a third round. “One for the road. I’m on duty tomorrow.”

They clinked glasses and drank goodbye. Denny stepped outside. It was dark and drizzling. He stood beneath the canopy, holding Günter’s address in his memory, thinking.

Ten years. I have to find him. Somehow, I have to persuade him.

He looked at his father’s watch, took a deep breath, and set off for home.

In the morning, he went to the watchmaker’s and pushed open the door. The old man sat bent over a mechanism. He did not even raise his head, only muttered:

“Hello, Denny. I expected you yesterday.”

Denny stopped on the threshold. The watchmaker slowly finished adjusting a part, carefully put his tools on their stand, and only then looked up. His gaze settled on Denny's battered face.

"Looks as though you've had adventures." He shook his head. "Everything all right?"

"Yes." Denny swallowed. "Have you got the money together?"

The watchmaker nodded, stood, and beckoned him into the back room. There, among boxes of spare parts, he took a heavy bundle tied with string from the safe.

"Here. All of it. A little extra, as I promised." He handed it to Denny. "I hope it helps."

Denny took it with trembling hands and looked inside: neat bundles of banknotes. His throat tightened.

"Thank you so much," he forced out. "You can't imagine how much this helps."

The watchmaker shook his hand and held it a moment.

"Hang on, lad. Seems you've had a hard lot. Don't lose heart."

Denny nodded, put the bundle inside his clothes, and hurried outside. He had to be quick.

Prosha was already waiting at the station, near the ticket windows, wrapped in a light coat. She stirred at the sight of him.

"Well? Did you get it?"

"Yes, Prosha." He patted his chest, where the money lay beneath his shirt.

"Hidden?"

"Hidden."

She held out two tickets.

"I bought them. We're going together."

Denny shot her a look and frowned.

"I'll deal with it. You have work."

"I told them I was ill. I've got three days." She looked at him with that stubborn determination he knew so well.

“Prosha, it’s dangerous. I don’t want to drag you into it. It’s because of me. I have to sort it out.”

She smiled, stepped closer, and put her arms carefully around him.

“I’m with you. I want to help. That’s what loved ones are for, isn’t it?”

The words went straight through him. He grew embarrassed and looked away. He did not know how to talk about love. Even thinking of it felt awkward. But warmth spread inside him.

“All right,” he muttered. “Come on.”

They boarded the train. The carriage was old, with wooden benches and the smell of coal. All the way, Prosha tried to distract him. She talked about work, her promotion to cook’s assistant, the women at the canteen forever quarreling over saucepans. Denny nodded, but his thoughts were far away. Trees, meadows, cows, little villages flickered past the window. They drew him inward, into memories he did not want to leave.

Budapest met them with sunshine. The city breathed life: clean pavements, restored buildings, smartly dressed passersby. Barges moved slowly along the Danube. Prosha turned her head from side to side, looking at sights she had known only from pictures.

“It’s beautiful!” she breathed. “And the bridge… I’ve heard so much about it!”

“We’re going straight to him.”

“I thought…”

“Come on.”

She quickened her step to catch him. At the familiar red-brick house, Denny stopped.

“Here. Prosha, wait outside.”

“But…”

“Outside,” he said sharply.

She pressed her lips together, but nodded. Denny climbed the stairs and knocked.

Silence.

Again.

At last, a voice came from behind the door.

“Who is it?”

“It’s me. Open up.”

“Who’s me? Go away. I’m busy.”

“Denny Goodman.”

Silence. Then the voice turned vicious.

“How dare you come here? Get away from my door!”

“I wanted to talk!”

“Are you stupid? Get out!”

“I’m alone! I have an offer. I wanted to discuss it!”

“Go to hell. We’ll talk in court!”

Denny understood that pleading was useless. He struck the doorframe with his fist and went downstairs. Prosha looked at him questioningly.

“Well?”

“He won’t let me in. Won’t talk.”

“What do we do? Maybe I could try?”

“You?”

“Yes. He doesn’t know me.”

Denny considered, then nodded.

“That’s an idea. Try it. If he lets you in, I’ll slip in after you.”

“Honestly, Denny. Not now.” Prosha gave a wry smile. “He’ll know you sent me, and he won’t open the door again.”

“Let’s find a room. Come back in the morning.”

They found cheap lodgings nearby. Denny barely slept. He turned over, stared at the ceiling, listened to Prosha breathing. His

head hurt, but that was nothing beside what was happening inside him.

In the morning, they stood before Günter's house again. Prosha went up alone. Denny hid on the landing between floors.

She knocked.

"Who is it?" came the voice from inside.

"I've come about gold," Prosha said softly, almost coquettishly. "I was told you could help."

Silence. Then the lock clicked, and the door opened on its chain. His oily eye appeared in the gap.

"What do you want?"

Prosha took the bundle from inside her clothes and showed the edge of the banknotes. Günter's eyes darted.

"All right… One moment, mademoiselle."

The door shut. A moment later, it opened wide.

"Come in."

Prosha stepped inside. Günter looked her up and down, his gaze lingering on her figure, and quickly turned the key. At the click, Denny came up and tried the handle.

Locked.

His heart sank. He pressed his ear to the door.

Prosha began at once.

"I have my grandmother's savings. She asked me to buy gold. Someone sent me to you. What can you offer?"

Günter spread his lips in a sugary smile.

"I was wondering where such a young, pretty girl had got so much money. Come through. Sit down. Tea? Wine, perhaps?"

"I only wanted to buy. How much is it?"

"My dear, that isn't how business is done. Let's get acquainted. Discuss what would suit you."

He brought a tea service and sat opposite her.

“My name is Günter Hipshtein. Yours?”

“Ilona,” Prosha breathed.

Günter poured tea and moved a cup toward her.

“Drink. Don’t be shy. Such a young lady, all alone, with so much money… Aren’t you afraid?”

“They told me you were a reliable dealer,” she countered.

“What’s it for? What exactly do you need?”

“My grandmother wants to buy gold. Everything she’s saved. She’ll probably leave it to me as a dowry.”

“With a face like yours, you don’t need a dowry.” Günter watched her sidelong.

“Thank you. Could we get to business?”

“Don’t hurry. I don’t bite. These things need to be considered calmly. Sure you won’t have wine? I’ll give you a discount.”

“A discount would be good. But I don’t drink.”

Günter stood, crossed the room, and brought out a box of chocolates.

“Help yourself.”

Prosha took one, ate it, and drank some tea.

“What about the gold?”

“One thing at a time. What’s your budget? Exclusive jewelry, for instance. With stones or without? Or simply gold by weight? Many details to consider. As a wise man said, ‘Gold makes the ugly beautiful.’ To make everything beautiful, let’s discuss it without rushing. Especially as such… beautiful customers so rarely visit me.”

Prosha grew nervous.

“All right, but they’re waiting for me at home.”

“I won’t keep you long. As you wish, of course.”

Günter went into the next room. Prosha jumped up and hurried for the door, but he was back before she reached it. He carried a jewelry box.

“Here. Look. A diamond pendant, diamond earrings, a ring with three emeralds. I think we can find something to suit your budget.”

Prosha stared at the jewelry, thinking desperately.

“How can I tell what they’re worth?”

Günter picked up the pendant.

“Let’s try it on. You’ll see it’s priceless.”

He came behind her, swept the hair from her neck, and fastened the pendant. His fingers lingered at the clasp; he breathed in the smell of her skin. Prosha swayed. Her vision dimmed. She jerked away, pushed him back, and rushed to the door.

“Thought I was a complete fool?” Günter snarled, lunging after her.

She managed to turn the lock, then collapsed onto the floor. Outside, Denny heard a scuffle and pulled the handle. The door opened a little, drawing the chain taut. Through the gap, he saw Günter trying to lock it again.

“Prosha!” Denny shouted, wedging his foot in the gap. “Prosha!”

She lay unconscious. Günter rushed toward the kitchen.

Denny threw his shoulder against the door again and again until the chain gave way. The door swung open against the girl’s body. He squeezed inside and saw Günter holding an enormous old knife.

“I’ll kill you, boy!”

The knife sliced through the air. Denny stepped back, barely getting his arm up to block it. The blade cut across his forearm. Blood spattered.

“To talk! I came to talk!” he shouted, backing away.

“You can talk in hell!”

Günter lunged again.

“Money!” Denny shouted. “I’ve got money!”

Günter stopped, his knife hand motionless.

“How much?”

“Lots. That bundle. More besides.”

“Talk, you little snot.”

“Is she alive?” Denny nodded toward Prosha.

“Alive.” Günter kept the knife raised. “Are you both that stupid? Thought I’d fall for it?”

“No! I just need to talk!”

“Out with it!”

“I wanted to ask… Withdraw the complaint. Or change your statement. I’ll pay.”

Günter smiled.

“Every last coin, with interest, you little snot. Then I’ll think about it.”

“All right,” Denny breathed. “I’ll give you everything. Let us go.”

“You have until tomorrow evening. Get out!”

Denny moved sideways toward the exit, watching the knife. Blood dripped from his arm onto the floor. He hurried to lift Prosha.

“The girl stays until you bring the money. Get out of my sight!”

Günter jabbed the knife at his chest. Denny froze for an instant, thoughts racing, then rushed into the corridor.

“Don’t touch her! I’ll bring it all!”

He ran down the stairs without looking back.

He ran until his strength gave out. Then he stopped against a wall, holding his bloody arm to his chest. Everything was tangled in his head. Prosha was still with that bastard. What would he do to her? What if…

He could not think of it.

At the lodging house, he bandaged the wound as best he could, grabbed his things, and hurried to the station. On the train, he sat staring at one spot, noticing neither his fellow passengers nor the passing landscape. Prosha’s cry rang in his ears; her body on the floor stayed before his eyes. He clenched his fists and moaned softly, his forehead against the cold glass.

Morning found him in his hometown. As soon as the train stopped, he jumped onto the platform. Viktor's first. He took the house papers and went to the administration building. Too early. Still closed.

Denny trudged toward home. His father's grave.

He knelt before the cross, put his arms around it, and pressed his face against the cold wood.

"Dad…" His voice broke. "What kind of person am I? Everything's because of me. You can't even rest. But I have to. I have to save them. Proshka, Viktor, they…" He sobbed. "They'll move you. Be patient. Next to Aunt Toma. I'll arrange it. But now… I wanted to do the right thing again. I didn't know… Forgive me."

He sobbed as he had in childhood. Tore at his hair. Pressed his father's watch to his chest. His mother's bookmark, which he often carried, lay in his inside pocket.

Rain began to fall. Denny stood, tucked the papers inside his clothes, and trudged toward the gate. By the cellar steps, he met Ilona.

She stood leaning against the wall.

"Hello, Denny," she said quietly, almost gently.

"Hello," he muttered, passing her.

"They told me…" Ilona faltered. "You saved me?"

Denny waved a hand and kept going. She caught up and took his elbow.

"I'm in a hurry." He shook her off.

"I wanted… Forgive me, Denny."

He stopped and looked at her. She looked better: thin and pale, but her eyes were different. The old insolence was gone.

"Please forgive me for what happened," she went on. "Thank you for saving me. I'd have died without you. The nurse said my only chance was because of the boy from the cellar."

Denny looked at her without speaking.

"I'm alone. Talk to me," Ilona asked. "I looked for you. Couldn't find you. I've nowhere to go. I'm living here again."

"Not for much longer," Denny said. "I'm selling it all."

She looked surprised.

"Your choice. But I thought you'd never part with the house."

"Money's what matters now."

"Are you sure you're all right?" Ilona nodded toward his forearm. "What happened to your arm? Do you need help?"

She reached toward him, but he stepped back.

"Don't touch me."

"I… I'm sorry. I'm not injecting anymore. They put me on a drip. Pulled me through. Then I nearly died from withdrawal. But a priest came. I talked to him for a long time and… found faith. He came every day. Now I go to church. I want to find work. Forgive me again."

Denny stared, unable to believe it.

"Where are Karo and Feri?"

"Feri was killed in a drug den. Karo overdosed in front of me. That was when I took a full dose myself." She lowered her eyes. "Where's Prosha?"

Denny's face darkened. His legs gave way, and he sat on the ground. His temples pounded. Everything swam.

"She's in trouble."

Ilona crouched beside him.

"What happened? Tell me."

He said nothing. She put a hand on his shoulder.

"I always loved Prosha. Like a sister. I stopped the boys when they wanted to force themselves on her. I wouldn't let them touch her. She's like my own family. Tell me."

Denny raised his head and looked at her through a haze. Then he began. Haltingly, jumping from one thing to another, but he told her: Günter, Viktor in prison, the money he had to pay.

Ilona listened without speaking. When he finished, they sat in silence for a few minutes.

"I want to help," she said at last. "Prosha's like a sister to me. I owe her. You, too. Twice over. I'll help."

"No." Denny waved her away. "I'll do it."

"Your arm isn't working. How will you manage alone? What if you need something? I'll help. Take me with you. I have to repay you. I'll never forgive myself if anything happens to Prosha."

Denny looked at her for a long time, then nodded.

"As you like."

The administration building opened an hour later. Denny went in. Ilona waited outside. The reception room was empty except for a secretary at a desk.

"I need to see Mr. Horvat," Denny said. "About selling the property."

The secretary nodded and disappeared through a door. A minute later, he returned.

"Go in."

Nothing in the office had changed: heavy curtains, an oak desk, molding on the ceiling. Janos Horvat sat sorting papers. At the sight of Denny, he spread his lips in a cloying smile.

"Ah, young man! Here you are. I thought you weren't coming."

"I'm selling," Denny said without preamble.

Horvat rose and came over.

"Quite right. A wise decision. Sit down."

Denny sat. The official took some papers from the safe and spread them on the desk.

"Right. I've prepared everything for the sale. The property comes to me. I pay all your debts and give you something on top. A good sum." He showed him the contract.

Denny nodded. Less than he had hoped, but this was no time to bargain.

“One condition,” he said. “My father is buried there. I want to move him to the cemetery. Next to Aunt Toma.”

Horvat grimaced, but nodded.

“All right. I’ll give you time. A week. Will that do?”

“Yes.”

“Then sign.”

Denny took the pen, but stopped.

“The money now. I need it urgently.”

Horvat smiled, took a heavy envelope from the drawer, and held it out.

“There. Every last penny.”

Denny looked inside. Bundles of banknotes. Plenty. Probably enough.

He signed without reading the papers. The official rubbed his hands with satisfaction.

“Clever boy. Unlike some.”

Denny put the envelope inside his clothes and stood.

“One more thing.” Horvat handed him a card. “The address of a funeral business. Tell them I sent you. They’ll give you a discount.”

Denny took it, nodded, and went out.

Ilona was waiting outside. Seeing his face, she asked nothing. Simply walked beside him.

“The station,” Denny said curtly.

They walked quickly, almost running. Pain throbbed in his arm, but he paid no attention. There was only one thing ahead: to get there in time.

Before evening.

Chapter 12

The journey to Budapest seemed endless. Denny sat by the window, Ilona opposite. All the way, she whispered the same prayer, turning a knot in her scarf between her fingers. He did not listen to the words, but the rhythm sounded in his temples, mingling with the wheels.

At the station, before they went into the city, Denny stopped by a clothes stall.

“Wait,” he told Ilona. A minute later, he returned with a cheap dark-blue coat. “Put this on.”

She obeyed without speaking. Denny caught himself feeling awkward under the looks of passersby. He had never noticed that in himself before. He had not cared. Now he was ashamed of the feeling, ashamed even to be thinking of it.

He pushed it away.

Günter’s house. Ilona stayed on the stairs, pressed into a corner between floors.

“If you hear anything wrong, or if we’re gone too long, run to the police,” Denny ordered.

She nodded, looking at him with enormous eyes.

Denny went up and knocked.

Silence.

Again, louder.

“Who is it?” came the voice.

“It’s me. I’ve brought it.”

“Alone?”

“Yes. Alone.”

“Mind you. Anything happens, and she’ll suffer.”

“I’m alone. There’s nobody else!”

Denny could barely control his nerves.

Rustling, footsteps, then the clang of the lock. The door opened a crack. A knife blade gleamed in the gap. Günter looked Denny over, checked the landing, and, satisfied he was alone, let him in.

“Come in. Shut the door.”

Denny stepped inside and closed it. His heart hammered in his throat. Günter was agitated, his face red, his eyes darting.

“Where is she?” Denny asked.

“Got the money?”

“Yes.” Denny took out the envelope. “Where’s Prosha?”

“In the room. Give it here.”

Günter snatched the envelope and began opening it, checking the contents. Denny rushed into the room.

Prosha lay on the bed. At the sight of him, she tried to raise herself on her elbows, but had no strength. Her head fell back onto the pillow. Her hair had been tied in a strange bow. Bright, unnatural makeup covered her face, like a doll’s. She wore an old-fashioned child’s dress with lace.

“Denny…” she breathed.

He rushed toward her, but Günter came up behind and pressed the knife point into his side, stopping him.

“Stay there, boy!” he barked. “I said stay there!”

Denny froze, feeling the cold metal through his shirt.

“What have you done to her, you bastard?”

“Nothing.” Günter jerked a shoulder. “Listen. You go out and wait in the entrance hall. When she’s changed, you can take her.”

“No! I’m not leaving without her!”

Denny moved, but the knife pricked his skin painfully.

Günter smiled. Slowly, with relish, he brought the blade to Prosha’s throat.

“Go, boy. While she’s alive. And think where you can get more money if you want me to withdraw the complaint.”

“But I brought it all!” Denny cried. “There’s no more!”

“Your problem. Think. Go. I’ll call you.”

Denny went into the corridor. The door slammed behind him. The lock clanged.

He stood on the stairs, unable to move away. Ilona peered from her hiding place, looking at him questioningly. He gestured: quiet. Stay there.

Time stretched endlessly. Every minute seemed an hour. His imagination tortured him: rape, cruelty, the makeup, the ridiculous dress… He tried to drive the forebodings away, but they returned, burning inside him. He wanted to burst in, tear the bastard apart with his bare hands, kill him, grind him to dust.

But he could not risk Prosha’s life.

After about fifteen minutes, the door opened a little.

“Come in.”

Denny entered. Günter immediately put the knife to his back, keeping him at arm’s length.

“Take her.”

Prosha sat on the bed, her head lowered. At his footsteps, she looked up.

“Denny…” she whispered.

He went to her, put his arms around her, and helped her stand. She was terribly weak. Her legs would not support her.

“What have you done to her?” he demanded, turning toward Günter.

“She’ll sleep it off. Won’t remember a thing.”

They took a step toward the door.

“Wait,” Günter said.

Denny stopped, clenching his teeth.

“What now?”

Günter approached Prosha and reached for her neck. Denny saw his mother's pendant. The one with the green stone. The bastard had forgotten to take it off.

"I'll do it," Denny growled. "Get away from her."

He sat Prosha on a chair and stood before her. Günter waited in the doorway, playing with the knife.

"Quickly. Then get out. Come back when you have the money."

Denny tried to open the clasp. His hands shook. It would not give. Prosha sat listlessly, staring ahead.

"Playful little thing, yours," Günter giggled. "And what a body. Send my regards to your friend, by the way. They love former servicemen in prison."

Denny's anger grew, but the clasp was stuck.

Then a click.

He looked at the chain, then turned.

Günter was on his knees, clutching his neck. A dark red stream ran between his fingers. Behind him stood Ilona, motionless, a bloody folding knife in her hand.

Günter wheezed and fell. Blood spread over the parquet in a dark pool.

Silence. Only his dying rasp and the measured beat of the large clock's meter-long pendulum, deafening in that emptiness.

"Ilona…" Denny breathed.

She stepped over the body, straight into the dark pool, and came to help him raise Prosha.

"I had to," she whispered. "He raped her, Denny. I understood when I came in." Her voice shook. "The way he stood over her. The way she lay… I knew at once. She feared that more than anything in the world. I couldn't let him live."

Denny stared at her, unable to take in what had happened. Prosha hung against him, barely standing on her unsteady legs.

Ilona rushed to the body, pulled the money envelope from Günter's pocket, and thrust it at Denny.

"What are you doing?" He tried to draw away, but she had already disappeared into the room, leaving bloody footprints. He heard boxes opening, paper rustling. A minute later, she ran out with bundles full of jewelry, pushed some inside Denny's clothes, and stuffed the rest into his pockets.

"We have to go!" Denny nodded at the prints. "Wipe them!"

Ilona looked at her feet, at the marks, and shook her head.

"I'm staying. You go."

"No! We'll wipe them away and leave together. I won't leave you!"

"Denny," Prosha called softly, raising her clouded eyes. "Go. Leave us. Call the police."

Ilona nodded.

"She's right. Disappear. Call anonymously. We'll tell them everything. The rape. How I came to save her and did this. Maybe it'll count as self-defense. If not, I killed him. I'll answer for it. It's my cross to bear. And no one will connect us with you."

He found the police station and sat on a bench opposite it.

Waited.

An hour, two, three… Night came, then morning, then day again. He sat there for almost eighteen hours, unable to leave, unable even to think. He only watched the doors behind which Prosha waited.

At last, she came out. Denny ran to her and held her close.

"Prosha… my girl…"

She broke into sobs against his chest. For a long time, she wept uncontrollably, her whole body shaking. He stroked her back, her hair, whispering things that made no sense.

"Come on," she said in his ear at last. "I want to wash."

"What about Ilona?"

“They’re keeping her for now. Deciding whether it was self-defense. I gave my statement. I’m the victim. The investigators will decide.”

They took a hotel room with a bath. Denny ran the water and helped Prosha undress. She stood before him, thin and defenseless, traces of makeup on her face, bruises on her wrists. He asked nothing. Said nothing about what had happened. He simply took the washcloth, soaped it, and began to wash her, carefully, gently, as though she were the most fragile vessel in the world.

Water ran over her body, washing away another person’s smell, another person’s dirt. Prosha closed her eyes and rested her head against the edge of the tub. Denny stroked her with his palm, silently, his heart breaking with pain and guilt.

“Forgive me,” he whispered. “Forgive me.”

She opened her eyes and looked at him for a long time. Then she slowly raised her hand to her neck and found the chain. The pendant with the green stone, which Günter had put on her, gleamed in the lamplight and cast a bright reflection on the wall.

Prosha tugged, trying to tear it off.

“No.” Denny gently stopped her. “Don’t.”

She looked at him in bewilderment.

“It was Mom’s,” he said quietly. “My mother’s. Let it stay with you. Always.”

Prosha went still. Tears shone in her eyes. She said nothing, only lowered her hand and closed her eyes again.

The pendant shimmered on her chest. In that flickering light was something warm and familiar. Denny put down the washcloth and simply sat beside her, holding her hand. Only her quiet sobs and the steady beat of his heart broke the silence.

“You’re very strong,” he whispered.

She gave the faintest smile and, with a quiet sigh, sank deeper into the water, letting it enfold her. The pendant at her neck was a reminder: even in the darkest times, there was room for light.

Chapter 13

Prosha said nothing on the walk from the hotel to the embankment. Denny kept an arm around her waist, never letting go, and felt her shiver now and then. He was silent, too, afraid to speak. Guilt gnawed at him.

They stopped at the parapet. The Chain Bridge shone with lights, their reflections winding like streamers across the Danube. Somewhere, music played and people laughed. The city went about its ordinary life, knowing nothing of what this fragile girl had endured.

“Denny,” Prosha said suddenly, without turning. “Let’s stay. A couple of days, at least?”

He looked at her. She stood motionless, gripping the rail, watching the current. A strange, unnatural cheerfulness sounded in her voice.

“I want to forget for a while…”

“As you like,” he said.

She turned, and he could see how hard she was trying to smile.

“I want to walk around. See how people live here.” She nodded toward the lively crowd enjoying themselves and dancing on the other side of the river.

“Anything you want.” Denny put his arms gently around her.

“And a restaurant? Could we? I’ve never been to one.”

He watched without speaking, feeling everything turn inside him. To go through so much, then ask for a walk around the city.

“Of course,” he said. “A restaurant, too. As long as you’re happy.”

Prosha nodded and looked at the water again. Denny stood numb, feeling utterly worthless. He had failed to protect her. And instead of shouting, accusing, she asked to stay together?

It was hard to know what was in her heart. But he marveled at her strength, her endurance, and that damned practicality that let her think, in any situation, about how to go on living.

"Prosha…" he began.

"Don't." She interrupted. "Just stay with me. All right?"

Denny nodded and drew her close. She leaned against him. For a long time, they stood looking at the lights of the bridge.

For two days, they walked around Budapest. Prosha pulled him toward parks, cathedrals, embankments. Looked into shop windows, bought cheap postcards. Denny walked beside her, doing whatever she asked, silently and obediently, while remorse seethed inside him.

On the second evening, they found the little restaurant a cook at Prosha's work had told her about: small, with a creaking door and the smell of fried onions. Prosha ordered wine. Denny did not even touch his food. He could not eat.

"What's wrong?" she asked.

"I don't want any."

"All right." She shrugged and took a sip. Then she set down the glass and looked at him, long and searchingly. "Denny. Stop eating yourself up."

He flinched.

"I know what you're thinking," Prosha went on. "You think you're to blame. That because of you…" Her voice broke for a moment, then grew firm. "You're not. I'm alive. We're together. And he's gone. That's what matters."

"Prosha…"

"I don't want to talk about it anymore." Suddenly, she was serious. "Not now. Perhaps someday. But not now. Just let me be with you. All right?"

Denny nodded, took her hand, and gently kissed it.

They returned to the station late that evening. On the train, Prosha slept all the way, her head on his shoulder. Denny watched lights pass the window and thought of Viktor.

Günter was gone.

He took Prosha to their room, put her to bed, and waited until she slept. Then he went out, toward the investigating officer's home.

Captain Kovach's house was dark. No lights in the windows. Denny sat on the entrance steps, leaned against the cold wall, and waited. The minutes dragged endlessly. His thoughts tangled, his eyelids closed, and he drifted off without noticing.

"Hey!"

A hand seized his collar and jerked him upright. He barely had time to open his eyes before he saw the raised fist. His head instinctively sank between his shoulders, but the fist stopped centimeters from his face.

"Fuck," the captain breathed, lowering his fist. "Kid, you nearly got it. Give a man some warning!"

"Sorry," Denny mumbled, his heart hammering in his throat.

"Come in."

They went upstairs. The same little kitchen, the ashtray on the table, the smell of tobacco. The captain sat opposite him and lit a cigarette.

"Well? What is it?"

Denny could no longer hold it in.

"Uncle Vitya…" His voice broke. "How is he?"

"All right." Kovach exhaled smoke. "Alive, for now."

"That's not what I mean." Denny shook his head. "Hipshtein… Günter's gone."

The captain choked on the smoke and stared at him.

"What do you mean? What are you talking about?"

"He's gone. Killed."

Kovach put down the cigarette and clenched his fists.

“Don’t tell me it was you!” His voice turned threatening.

“No! Not me!” Denny waved his hands. “There… Anyway, he’s gone. But it wasn’t me.”

The captain let out a long breath and leaned back.

“You’ve made me nervous twice this evening, kid.” He paused, thinking. “That changes a lot. Wait. Let me work it out.”

He stood, took a bottle from the cupboard, and poured into the glasses.

“Come on. To the news.”

They drank. The captain lit another cigarette, frowning.

“The old statement’s no good, of course. Günter’s dead, but the case still exists.”

He rose abruptly, went to the other room, and returned with paper and a pen.

“Write.”

“What?”

“I’ll dictate. ‘I, Daniel Goodman, testify that on the day we visited Günter’s apartment…’” Kovach paused. “Go on. ‘I was there with Viktor Andreevich N. I used no violence. The gold and money belong to me, inherited from my mother, which I can substantiate with documents.’ Understood?”

Denny nodded and carefully wrote every word. He asked everything five times over, afraid of making a mistake.

“Now sign and date it.” Kovach took the sheet and scanned it. “That’ll do. If the papers haven’t left the office yet, I can replace them in time. We’ll sort it out with Viktor, too.”

“How can I thank you?” Denny looked at him pleadingly.

“Forget it.” Kovach waved a hand. “Viktor’s covered for me often enough. I don’t need anything. Just use your head next time.”

Denny lowered his eyes.

“All right.” The captain poured another round. “Here’s to everything turning out all right.”

They drank. After a silence, Kovach asked directly:

“What happened to Günter? Tell me.”

Denny hesitated.

“He was… killed. I don’t want to go into it.”

“That won’t do, kid.” The captain narrowed his eyes. “Want me awake all night, wondering what happened? Come on. Tell me.”

Denny said nothing, gripping the glass. Then he drained it, and began to shake.

“He… he was a pervert. Got a girl inside. Her sister… with a knife. Because of it.”

“All right.” The captain raised a hand to stop him. “I understand. No details.”

Denny nodded, feeling nausea rise in his throat.

“Go on.” Kovach patted his shoulder. “Things look clearer in the morning. I’ll call if there’s anything.”

Denny went outside. It was dark, but a strange, timid hope had taken hold inside him. Along the empty streets, he imagined seeing Viktor again. Sitting in the kitchen. Uncle Vitya saying his familiar, “Got some grub ready?” Beginning the search for Lilith, properly this time, with renewed strength.

He stopped and raised his head. The stars glittered coldly. The moon was enormous and bright.

“Lilith,” he whispered. “Perhaps it’s just as well you’re far away. All I bring is suffering.”

Chapter 14

Prosha sat at the little table in their room, with a heap of banknotes, coins, and jewelry before her. Denny stood by the window, looking at the gray sky, not daring to approach.

“We don’t need gold anymore,” she said without turning. “We’ve tried that. Go to the watchmaker. Exchange it all.”

Denny took the bundle and went out. At the sight of so much jewelry, the craftsman whistled, but asked no questions.

“Here, lad. Hope it goes to good use.”

Denny returned and silently tipped the bundles of banknotes onto the table. Prosha already had a notebook covered in small, firm handwriting. Having learned to read and write from Denny, she now set down numbers confidently, sorting the money into piles, working things out, her lips moving.

“This is for food. This for rent. This for studying,” she murmured. “And this…” Exactly half the money moved to one side. “This is for Ilona.”

Denny was about to speak, but Prosha looked up. Her gaze was firm and matter-of-fact, without a trace of doubt.

“She killed him. Without her…” Her voice faltered, but she mastered it. “I don’t know what will happen to her. But if she gets out, she’ll have a chance to start again.”

Denny nodded and put his hand on her shoulder.

Prosha called the police station every day. Sometimes they answered; sometimes they hung up. There was no news. The investigation continued. Ilona remained in custody.

“We have to be ready,” Prosha said. “For anything.”

After three days, she went back to work. She could no longer bear sitting idle. A week later, she told Denny:

“I’m going to study. Cooking classes.”

“But you have a job…”

“The job can wait. I want a business of my own. Remember that little restaurant in Budapest?” For the first time in a long while, she smiled. “There isn’t a decent place in our town. We could do it. I’ll learn to cook better than anyone. We’ll open our own café. Comfortable. Live music.”

Denny looked at her in wonder. After everything she had endured, she was making plans, counting money, drawing up budgets, going out to ask about some kind of securities. A fire burned in her that he had not seen before.

“What about school?” he asked.

“Evening school. Work in the day, study in the evening. You taught me to read and write. I can take it from there.”

She spoke, and he listened, feeling warmth spread inside him. Prosha was charging straight ahead.

They no longer had sex. Denny did not press her. He understood. Sometimes, at night, she moved close, laid her head on his shoulder, and went still. He stroked her hair. That was enough.

She threw herself into her plans. Drew up a budget for the year ahead, found a woman who promised to help with the paperwork, hurried from office to office, asking questions. Denny stayed alone and often went to his father, to the house. One day, he took down the mailbox. Broke it, tore it from the ground, cursing himself.

The reburial was set for Sunday. Denny chose a place beside Tamara’s communal grave, so they would be close. He ordered a handsome dark wooden cross and a plain but sturdy coffin. The undertakers did everything quickly, without unnecessary talk.

That morning, he went to the cemetery alone. It was cold and drizzling, but he did not notice. He stood beside the fresh grave, holding his mother’s bookmark.

“Forgive me, Mom,” he whispered, lowering it into the grave. “I don’t know where you are. Perhaps they buried you in an unmarked

pit. Perhaps you stayed in the house and burned… I don't know. But let this be with Dad. You're together now."

He covered it with earth, straightened the flowers, and lit a candle, sheltering the flame from wind and rain with his hand.

Denny sat beside the grave and began to talk. He told his father and mother everything: Viktor, Prosha, Günter, Ilona, selling the house to save them all. He asked forgiveness, over and over.

"I love you," he said at last. "Thank you for being in my life."

The candle burned out. The rain stopped. Sun appeared in the sky.

Denny sat, unable to move. Suddenly, a hand rested on his shoulder. Warm, heavy, familiar.

He turned.

"Uncle… Vitya?"

Viktor stood behind him in his usual coat, his hat a little askew. His face was drawn, with dark circles beneath the eyes and deeper lines, but his smile was the same: kind, a little sly.

"Well, hello, kid."

Denny jumped up, and they embraced. Hard, until bones creaked, until it hurt. Viktor held him as though afraid he would disappear. Denny buried his face in his shoulder, unable to hold back his tears.

"Ow, ow," he croaked. "Uncle Vitya, you're strangling me!"

"Why are you so feeble?" Viktor loosened his grip, drew back, and looked him over. "Doesn't Prosha feed you?"

"Uncle… my dear uncle…" Denny wiped his eyes with his sleeve.

"Enough. You'll get me started. Pack it in." Viktor gave his shoulder a light shove.

"How? When?" Denny breathed, hardly believing his eyes.

"This morning. They let me out. Changed all the papers. I'll tell you later."

Viktor turned to the grave and laid down the flowers in his hand.

"You have a wonderful son," he said, looking at the cross. "You can be proud of him."

They stood without speaking. Then they went to Tamara.

They spent the whole day at Viktor's. In the kitchen, they drank tea, then vodka, then tea again, and talked without stopping. Viktor told him about the questioning, the cell, Captain Kovach's efforts to replace the papers in time.

"Günter's gone, but he did a thorough job of sending those complaints," he explained. "Your statement settled it. They let me go. But my reputation…"

He fell silent and knocked back his vodka.

"They're dismissing me. Stripped my rank. This apartment…" He waved around the room. "I have to give it up in two months. Comes with the job. After that, God knows."

"Uncle Vitya…" Denny began.

"Don't lose your nerve. We'll get through." Viktor smiled. "While I'm still here, handing things over, I can get everyone I know involved. Old contacts. Partisans. The underground. We'll look for Lilith. You dig in the archive. Hospital records, children's homes. We haven't much time, but we have to try."

Denny nodded.

"I'll do everything."

"One more thing." Viktor took a paper from his pocket. "Go to the department tomorrow. Remember where they took us? Collect the gold. Turns out it's yours."

Denny stared.

"They'll give it back?"

"They will. What else can they do?"

Viktor smiled, but his eyes stayed sad.

They sat drinking and talking about Prosha, Ilona, the future. Denny told him about Prosha's café, her studies, how she had worked everything out.

“A woman with a will of her own,” Viktor said approvingly. “You won’t go under with her.”

Then he suddenly began a song. An old Russian song, long and slow, one of those they had sung in his village. Denny did not know the words, but joined the tune. They sat with their arms around each other and howled - yes, howled, not sang - putting into the sound all their pain, all they had endured, all they had lost and found.

The neighbors must have heard, but no one came to knock. Perhaps they were crying, too.

Outside, darkness gathered. On Denny’s wrist, the watch ticked steadily, marking the time of a new life.

The days settled into a rhythm, filled with purpose. Denny returned to the archive. The place, with its smell of dust, old paper, and a silence almost magical, had become familiar, almost home. He arrived at opening time, greeted the potbellied guard, who now nodded like an old acquaintance, and went up to the room of shelves.

Mikosh always greeted him the same way, pushing his glasses onto his forehead and squinting.

“Ah, here you are. Come in. Today, I’ll show you how to work with military hospital records.”

They sat together in a silence broken only by the rustle of pages and the creak of chairs. Mikosh showed him where to find lists of evacuated children, how to decipher old German entries, what to look for in the children’s-home registers.

“The main thing is not to hurry,” he told him, tracing a yellowed page with his finger. “One wrong move, and you miss a name.”

Denny took in every word. He sorted cards, studied faces, copied surnames into a notebook. Progress was slow, but he felt he was getting closer. Somewhere among the thousands of names might be hers. Lilith’s.

After a couple of weeks, he knew he had to thank the old man. Mikosh gave him time, taught him, advised him, even stayed after work. Denny remembered him mentioning once that he liked port. Good, aged port.

"Prosh," Denny began one evening as they sat in the kitchen. "I need some money."

She looked up from the notebook in which she was calculating expenses for the café.

"What for?"

"Well… the archivist. He's helping me so much. I want to thank him."

"Take him some pastries." Prosha shrugged. "I'll bring them from work. Fresh, with meat. He'll be pleased."

"Prosh, he doesn't like pastries. He likes port."

"Port?" She put down her pen and stared as though he had proposed buying diamonds. "Do you know what port costs?"

"Well… Not really."

"I do. I count every penny. There's the café, our studies, money to live on… And you want port!"

"Prosh, the man does so much for me. I'm not just…"

"What's wrong with pastries as a thank-you?" She planted her hands on her hips. "I'll choose them myself. The best meat!"

"Prosha…" Denny sighed. "Will you give me the money?"

She looked at him. Two forces struggled in her eyes: her inborn thrift and her love for this stubborn young man.

"How much?" she gave in at last.

Denny named the sum. Prosha rolled her eyes, reached into the hiding place beneath a floorboard, counted out the notes, and handed them over as though tearing them from her heart.

"Mind you, Denny," she said sternly.

He kissed her cheek and ran to the shop. Prosha shook her head, but a smile hid at the corners of her mouth.

At the sight of the bottle, Mikosh was touched.

“Thank you, lad. You can’t imagine how welcome this is.”

He put the port in his desk and locked it.

“I’ll save it for a special occasion.”

Denny nodded and returned to the cards with fresh energy.

There was still no intimacy between him and Prosha. He did not press her or ask, only stroked her red hair and waited. When the time came, she would tell him. For now, each had work: Denny the archive, Prosha her studies, her job, her calculations. They lived beside each other and breathed the same air. That was enough.

A month later, a summons arrived. Prosha was called to testify at Ilona’s trial.

She went pale as she read it, then sat for a long time, staring at the wall.

“You won’t go?” Denny asked quietly.

“No.” She looked up, determination in her eyes. “I will. I have to. For her. She saved me.”

“Then I’ll buy tickets. We’ll go together.”

“Thank you, Denny. That’ll make it easier.”

When Viktor heard about the summons, he decided to come, too.

“I’ve put in a word wherever I could,” he told them in his kitchen. “She shouldn’t get much. With the right judge, they might even call it self-defense. What matters is that Prosha confirms everything she said in her statement. And that the court believes her.”

Prosha listened, gripping a handkerchief.

“I can do it,” she said firmly. “I’ll do everything.”

Later that evening, she began talking about Ilona. How, in the cellar, when the others turned away, Ilona sometimes shared her last mouthful. Drove off the boys when they tried to take advantage of Prosha’s helplessness. Once brought her an almost-new dress, probably stolen somewhere, but gave it to her because Prosha had nothing.

“She was like a sister,” Prosha said, looking out of the window. “Until she started on that stuff. Then… everything broke.”

Denny listened and thought how complicated people were. Ilona had almost killed him, driving the bookmark into his stomach. The same Ilona had spent years protecting a little red-haired girl from rapists.

“We’ll get her out,” he said. “We will.”

Budapest met them with a leaden sky and drizzle. The courthouse was enormous, with gray columns at the entrance and tall barred windows. Inside, it smelled of floor polish. Tools clattered somewhere; repair work was going on. The court had recently moved from its old building.

They sat on a wooden bench in the courtroom, waiting. Prosha worried the lace on the sleeve of her dark-gray dress, the only decent one she owned. Denny held her hand. Viktor sat beside them, arms folded, looking straight ahead.

When the door opened and Ilona was brought in, Prosha flinched.

Ilona looked very small in the shapeless gray prison dress. But her features had changed. Thin and drawn, yet somehow peaceful. Her eyes no longer darted or hid. She looked toward them, and for an instant something warm flickered in her gaze. She gave the faintest nod and sat in the dock.

Prosha gripped Denny’s hand until his knuckles cracked.

The judge entered. Everyone stood. The hearing began.

The charge was read, then the witnesses’ statements. There were few. A downstairs neighbor who had heard noises and screams. Another woman who had seen Günter in the yard. At last, Prosha was called.

(At the time of the incident, Piroshka was over eighteen.)

She stood, straightened her dress, and drew herself rigidly upright. Her gaze became distant, her lips a thin line. Even her

freckles seemed to fade. She went to the witness stand, put her hands on the cold wood, and began.

Quietly at first. Then more firmly.

"He invited me into the apartment. Said his name was Günter Hipshtein. Said he could help with the gold. Poured tea. Gave me a piece of candy. I suspected nothing."

She spoke clearly, without faltering, as though reciting a lesson. Details, times, sequence. Denny listened, feeling everything grow cold inside him.

"I lost consciousness. When I woke, I was wearing an old-fashioned child's dress. With lace sleeves. He stood over me, painting my face. I couldn't move. I could only hear and feel."

Prosha took a breath. The room was so quiet they could hear people calling outside.

"He spoke to me as though I were little. Pushed hard candies into my mouth. Then he began touching me. My breasts first. Then he put his fingers between my legs. He took out children's toys and put them inside me. Then he undressed and raped me. Afterward, he lit a candle and poured hot wax on my skin."

The judge grimaced. The stenographer froze, pen in hand. Someone gasped. Prosha went on without pausing, her voice level, as though reading a book aloud.

"It lasted for hours. He changed positions, made comments, laughed. I thought I would die. He wouldn't stop. He heated a piece of metal and burned me. Burned me there. It only stopped because of Ilona. She came in and stabbed him. Without her, he would have killed me. Or I would have gone mad."

She stopped, swayed, and clutched the stand. Her eyes clouded, her eyelids fluttered, and she fell.

Denny rushed to her, lifted her, and carried her from the courtroom. In the corridor, he laid her on a bench, supporting her head. Viktor hurried after them with water, wet a handkerchief, and laid it on Prosha's forehead.

“Breathe, sweetheart. Breathe,” Denny whispered. “It’s all right. You did well. You’ve done everything.”

Prosha opened her eyes. At first, they were clouded and unseeing, but soon they focused on him.

“Denny…” she breathed, scarcely audibly.

“I’m here. I’m with you.”

Viktor went back into the courtroom. Denny took Prosha outside, and they sat on a bench by the entrance. Sun broke through the clouds, lighting the pavement wet with rain. She rested her head on his shoulder, and they sat in silence.

A crowd of students passed with placards, chanting:

“Russians, go home! If you’re not with us, you’re not Hungarian!”

Prosha flinched and pressed closer.

“Now you know everything,” she whispered. “Will you leave me?”

Denny stared in surprise. He looked at her wide, wet eyes, the freckles golden in the sunlight.

“What are you saying, Prosha?” He held her face between his palms. “You silly girl. My dear girl. I’m with you. Always.”

“Then kiss me. If you mean it.”

He kissed her, slowly, tenderly, carefully. Prosha kissed him back, leaning against him. Sun warmed their heads; wind stirred her red hair. For the first time in a long while, Denny felt the world would not fall apart. They would manage.

They stayed like that, hands joined, until Viktor came out. His face looked strange: tired, but with a satisfied spark in his eyes.

“Time to celebrate,” he said. “She’s been acquitted.”

Prosha jumped up.

“When? Where? How?”

“Hold on. Don’t get carried away. Acquitted. Community service, but that’s nothing. What matters is she won’t go to prison. They’ll probably let her out tomorrow.”

Prosha went still, then threw both arms around Viktor and sobbed. Tears of relief this time. He held her in return.

The students' cries could still be heard in the distance, but no longer mattered to them. Here, on a bench beside the gray courthouse, was a happiness of their own. Small, hard-won, but real.

The next morning was sunny. Prosha rose before dawn and hurried out, calling over her shoulder:

"I won't be long. Get packed."

When Denny came down to the hotel lobby a couple of hours later, she was waiting with a large bundle. Walking quickly had flushed her cheeks; red hair had escaped from beneath her scarf.

"The secondhand market," she explained, seeing his look. "She needs something to wear when she comes out. Not that prison dress."

They waited outside the prison for about half an hour. Prosha tugged at the edge of her dress, sat, jumped up again. Denny held her hand and felt her fingers tremble.

At last, the door opened. Ilona came out in the same gray clothes, but without an escort. She stopped on the top step, squinting in the sun and smiling.

"Ilona!"

Prosha ran to her. They embraced, and Ilona burst into tears, loudly, helplessly, like a child. Prosha stroked her back and whispered something. Denny stood aside, feeling unnecessary.

"There. There." Prosha drew back and wiped Ilona's tears with her palm. "Come on. I brought you clothes."

They took her to the hotel. While she washed and changed, Prosha paced nervously, straightening chairs, tugging at curtains.

"Will you sit down?" Denny said at last.

"I can't."

Ilona came out in the plain dark-blue dress Prosha had bought. Her clean hair was neatly arranged. The look of doom that had filled her eyes in court was gone. She studied herself in the cloudy mirror and ran a hand over the hem.

“You shouldn’t have, Prosha,” she said quietly.

“Yes, I should. Besides, I got a good price.” Prosha smiled, but nervously.

They sat on the bed. Ilona took her hands.

“How are you?”

Prosha breathed out and began to talk. Her studies, work, plans for the café. Quickly, stumbling over herself, but with the determination Denny loved so much.

“Little by little, it’s coming together,” she finished. “And you?”

Ilona looked at the floor without speaking. Then she raised her eyes.

“I’ve decided. I’ll do the community service at a convent outside the city. They’ll give me shelter. Afterward… I’ll stay there. For good.”

Prosha went still.

“A convent? You want to be… a nun?”

“Yes. I spoke to the priest. He’ll take me in. This is my path, Prosha. I want to serve Christ.”

Denny and Prosha exchanged a look. Neither knew what to say.

“I’m happy for you,” Prosha said suddenly, firmly. “I mean it. If it’s what you want…”

“Yes. I’ve thought a great deal. I know what I should do.” Ilona nodded. “I’ll pray for you, too.”

Prosha reached into her pocket and took out the bundle. She opened it. The money she had set aside for her friend.

“This is for you,” she said. “For your new life.”

Ilona barely glanced at the notes and gently pushed Prosha’s hand away.

“No. Keep it. I have everything now.”

She took Prosha’s palm and pressed it against her chest.

“Thank you, sister. For everything. But I won’t need money anymore.”

Prosha tried to object, but Ilona stopped her with a gesture.

“Truly. I’ve made my decision. Atonement.”

They embraced for a long time, tightly, as though parting forever. Denny stood at the window, looking over the gray roofs, feeling an ache in his chest.

Then they drank tea. Talked of small things, the weather, the journey. When it was time, they gathered their things and drove out of the city.

The convent stood on a hill, ringed by half-ruined walls. Bricks had fallen in places; holes gaped. But a clean, new cross shone above the entrance, as though it had only just been put up.

Ilona got out of the car and looked around. There was no fear in her eyes, only peace.

“Well. I’ll go.”

Prosha nodded, swallowing the lump in her throat, and held her close once more.

“Write if you need anything. Come and see us. We’ll always be glad.”

“I will.”

Ilona turned to Denny. Awkwardly, he stepped forward and embraced her.

“Thank you,” she whispered in his ear. “You saved me then… and that other time…”

She drew back.

“By the way. The cellar. In the brickwork. Look. There’s something there.”

Denny did not understand, but nodded.

She went. The dark-blue dress flickered between the trees as her small figure climbed the path to the gate. A priest was waiting: tall, gray-haired, kind-faced. Ilona turned for a moment, waved, and disappeared behind the heavy door.

Prosha stood motionless, tears running down her cheeks. Denny held her.

“It’s right,” he said. “Everything will be all right.”

On the train, after the city lights had fallen behind, Prosha looked out of the window in silence for a long time. Denny let her be. He knew she needed time to take it in.

At last, she turned.

“Denny.” Her voice was serious. “If you really love me, if you still want us to be together after everything… let’s have a baby?”

He choked, coughed, went red.

“What?” he managed.

“A baby. Think about it. We’re together. There’s enough money for a little apartment and a café. We can manage it between us. I’ll have the baby. You’ll help… Or don’t you want to?”

Denny stared, his mouth opening and closing without a sound.

“Prosha…” he said at last. “Could we discuss it at home? Not in front of everyone?”

She looked around the carriage and snorted.

“All right. But mind you, I won’t leave it alone. You know me.”

“I understand.” He nodded. “We’ll talk at home.”

She leaned against him and rested her head on his shoulder. They sat like that for a long time, watching the fields pass.

Back home, Denny took Prosha to their room, kissed her, and said he had to go out for a little while.

“To Viktor’s?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“Go on. I’ll unpack.”

He went out. But instead of heading straight to Viktor's, his feet took him to the place that had once been his home.

The yard was cleared. The trash had been taken away; burned beams lay stacked in a corner. Workers moved about the cellar entrance, clearing rubble. Denny passed without noticing them and went down.

Damp and smoke, as on that first day.

He looked around the walls, remembering Ilona's words. Went to the far brickwork and reached into a gap.

His fingers found a bundle. Small, wrapped in cloth. He pulled it out, tucked it inside his clothes, and hurried away.

On a bench outside a neighboring house, he sat and unwrapped it.

His mother's glasses.

Thin, with metal frames. The lenses were scorched and blackened, the arms bent, the paint blistered by heat. Denny pressed them against his cheek: cold, slightly rough.

"Mom…" he whispered. "Mom…"

He held them, rocking back and forth, tears running down his cheeks. Few tears, a man's tears, but unbearably bitter.

She had stayed there. In that fire. In that hell.

Then he noticed envelopes in the bundle. Several, yellowed with age, bearing addresses.

He made out the first:

To Daniel Goodman, town of N, … Street…

Dated 1949. The return address: Novosibirsk, Lenin Street…

His hands shook as he opened it.

"Dear Denny,

"It's your future wife! You weren't hoping I'd forget, were you?

"I'm in Novosibirsk. I'm well. The family is wonderful. Tell me how you are, what's happened to you, how your life has turned out. Please tell me about my mother, too. I've written to every address I

remembered, but no answer. Not from Belorussia, not from the address where we lived. I miss her so much. And you, my faithful, kind friend.

"I'll never forget the bits of food you brought, or how you saved the rabbit. I hope you and Mom are together and alive.

"She sent me to the partisans. After the war, a soldier took me from there. He's a good man, looks after me, calls me his daughter. We have everything we need, thank God. I speak Russian with hardly any accent now. They're kind people. You'd like it in the USSR.

"Ask Mom to send word if you're in touch with her. And please answer yourself. At least let me know you're alive.

"I can't wait to hear from you.

"Your Lilith."

Denny sprang up as though struck by electricity.

Lilith was alive. In Novosibirsk. She had written!

He seized the second envelope. 1950.

"Hello, dear Denny,

"This is my second letter. I'm sending it in the hope you're alive and will answer someday. It's your friend Lilith again.

"I'm still in Novosibirsk. Still trying to find out how you are, how Mom is. If you're reading this, please answer. I'll keep writing. I believe we'll hear from you soon. I'm writing to every address I can remember, but there's only silence.

"Tell Mom I'm here and I'm well.

"I hope you're alive and healthy, and the letters are simply taking too long.

"A hug from your Lilith."

The third letter. 1951.

"Hello, Denny,

"This is my third letter. I write, and I believe you'll answer.

"I'm still in Novosibirsk. The address is on the envelope. My name is now Liliya Sergeevna Orlova. If you're alive, please answer. If Mom's alive, tell me about her. Tell her about me. Tell her where I am.

"I often think of you and your kind heart. The time we spent together. Our games. Remember how you stole the lemons, and how we agreed I'd be your wife? We were funny.

"I write in the hope you'll read this and answer. I live in the hope of seeing you and Mom again one day. I can't come. Dad Seryozha says the Ministry of State Security won't let us go to Hungary.

"I'm in college. Forgive the mistakes. I write Russian better than Hungarian now. I wanted to say I'll never forget you.

"Forever your Lilith."

Denny sat, unable to move. The sheets trembled in his hands. Lilith was alive. For three years, she had been looking for him, sending letters to an address that no longer existed.

He jumped up and ran.

Viktor was not home yet. Denny rushed into the apartment, put the vodka he had bought on the way on the table, brought out food and cigarettes for Viktor. The letters went in the very middle. Beside them, his mother's glasses.

He sat on a stool and stared at the envelopes, unable to look away.

Time dragged endlessly. He heard his watch ticking, someone moving beyond the wall, the stairs creaking beneath other people's footsteps.

At last, a key turned in the lock. Viktor came in, took off his coat, and threw it over a chair as usual. Seeing Denny, the laid table, the look on his face, he frowned.

"What's wrong? Something happened?"

Denny silently nodded toward the letters.

Viktor came over and picked up the top envelope. Read the address. Opened it and drew out the sheet. He read for a long time, then read it again. Without speaking, he took the second. The third.

When he finished, the room was so quiet they could hear the lamp crackle.

Viktor looked up. Tears shone in his eyes.

“Alive…” he breathed. “My niece is alive.”

They looked at each other, unable to speak. Then Denny reached out, and they embraced. Firmly, man to man, but with the tenderness of people who had lost hope and suddenly found it again.

Denny left Viktor’s. But instead of going straight home, his feet carried him to the watchmaker’s. He knocked. The door opened almost at once, as though he had been expected. The craftsman stood there, his usual magnifying glass on his forehead, machine oil on his hands.

“Ah, you.” He nodded, letting Denny in. “Come through. Something wrong with the watch? Or selling again?”

“No.”

Denny took out his mother’s glasses. They lay on his palm, light, almost weightless, yet painfully heavy on his heart.

“These. Can you restore them?”

The old man took the frames, held them beneath the green-shaded lamp, and turned them in his hands. The lenses were scorched and blackened, one cracked. The arms pointed in different directions. Paint had blistered and flaked away. He examined them so gently that Denny’s heart tightened.

“Difficult,” he said after a long silence.

He ran a finger over the frame as though stroking something alive.

“But I’ll try. New lenses. Straighten them. The paint… Well, it’s peeling. We’ll clean it off. Better leave it as it is. Show it’s a thing with a history. Objects like this should bear the marks of time.”

“Thank you,” Denny breathed. “What do I owe you?”

The watchmaker looked over his spectacles and smiled with the corners of his mouth.

“You’ve brought me so much, I’ll owe you for the rest of my life. Go on. Come back in a week.”

He carefully wrapped the glasses in soft flannel and put them in a workbench drawer. Denny shook his dry, warm hand and went outside.

He walked toward the apartment in excellent spirits, whistling a lively tune. Prosha was not back yet. Probably held up at work. Their little room was dark, with pale strips of streetlight across the floor. Denny lit the kerosene lamp and set it on the table.

He laid the letters out, three yellowed envelopes in a row, straightening them like little soldiers on parade. Then he went to the kitchen. Small, shared by several rooms, it was empty at this hour. He took out the heavy cast-iron frying pan, its sides blackened with age. Cut the potatoes into thin slices, the onion into half-rings, the pork fat into small cubes so it would render quickly.

Oil hissed. The smell of frying filled the kitchen. Denny caught himself humming, some tune from childhood, perhaps, or simply a melody that had come to him. He even smiled, for the first time in a long while.

Lilith was alive. Far away in Novosibirsk, but alive. Now they knew where to find her. And his mother’s glasses would be repaired.

The potatoes browned. The onions turned golden. Denny stirred with a wooden spatula, breathing in the rich smell, feeling something warm and almost forgotten spread inside him.

Hope.

He lifted the pan from the stove, set it on a wooden trivet, and carried it toward the room. Already, he imagined their dinner together. Telling Prosha about the glasses, the craftsman doing the

work for nothing, Viktor crying over the letters. The happiness of finally knowing Lilith was alive.

He pushed the door with his shoulder and went in.

Prosha sat on a stool. Before her, the letters lay open. All three. Read.

She had moved the lamp closer, its light falling straight onto the yellowed sheets, drawing the uneven lines from the dark. Her face was chalk white, her eyes swollen and red, shadows beneath them. She looked at him with so much in her gaze - fear, guilt, pleading, despair - that he stopped on the threshold, unable to take another step.

The pan became impossibly heavy.

“You found them?” Her voice shook and broke. “Who told you?”

“Ilona.”

His voice sounded muffled, as though from inside a barrel. He set the pan on the table but did not sit. He stood gripping its edge.

“And… you…” He faltered, looking at her. Suddenly, the pieces fitted together. “You knew? You knew about these letters?”

Prosha lowered her eyes. Her fingers clenched and opened convulsively. She said nothing, and the silence was worse than any scream.

“Prosha.” Metal entered his voice. “Did you know?”

“Yes,” she breathed, barely audibly.

The word fell into the silence like a stone into a well.

“How long?”

“The postman came almost every winter. Karo took the envelopes, pretending to be you. Thought there might be something valuable. When he saw it was only paper, he threw them away. I hid them. Only Ilona knew.”

Denny swayed, stunned. He leaned against the doorframe, feeling the ground give way beneath him.

"You… You knew all this time?" He could scarcely believe it. Each word hurt, as though pulled from him with pincers. "Knew Lilith was alive? Writing to me? And said nothing?"

"I was afraid."

Prosha raised her eyes. Large tears rolled down her cheeks and fell onto her dress, leaving dark marks.

"I was afraid you'd go to her. You spoke of her so tenderly… I thought, if she was found, you'd choose her. And I… I couldn't bear it if you left me."

"Prosha!"

Denny stepped toward her, clenching his fists until the knuckles cracked. His voice rose to a shout, then fell to a hoarse whisper.

"I looked for her for so many years! Viktor and I tried so hard! Did you see what I went through? My nightmares, my tears, my pain?" He stopped, trying to breathe. "And you knew. All that time. Knew and said nothing."

"I didn't want to lose you," she whispered.

"I didn't want to be lied to."

He said it quietly, but with a terrible seriousness. Dead silence filled the room.

"The others…" He waved vaguely toward the darkness outside. "Strangers. Ilona, Karo, Feri, anyone. But you. You're the person closest to me. I shared everything with you. Hid nothing. And you…"

He stopped, breathing hard. Prosha sat huddled, her arms around herself.

"I never expected it," he said more quietly. "Not from you."

"Forgive me…"

She reached toward him, her thin hand trembling. He stepped back.

"You know I hate lies more than anything."

He crouched before her and looked into her eyes. Through the anger came pain, so sharp it seemed almost tangible.

“You knew everything, Prosha. You didn’t tell me. You lied.”

“I love you,” she breathed.

Tears kept running down her face, smearing over her cheeks, dripping onto the dress.

“You don’t lie to the people you love,” he answered, very calmly and gently.

She sobbed and covered her face.

Denny stood. His legs felt like cotton wool, but he made himself reach the coat rack. Snatched his jacket and threw it over his shoulders. His movements were sharp and broken.

“Dinner’s on the table,” he said without looking at her. His voice sounded distant, as though from another room. “Eat.”

“Denny…”

She sprang up and ran after him, hands outstretched.

But he had already opened the door and gone, without turning.

Outside, the air was fresh but not cold. A light wind stirred his hair and the leaves, driving dust over the pavement with the smell of approaching autumn. Denny walked quickly, almost running, hardly seeing where he went. People jumped aside. Someone shouted after him, but he did not hear. The world narrowed into a tunnel with nothing at its end but pulsing pain.

His breathing grew quick and ragged. Thoughts raced, caught on one another, raised questions without answers.

Why? Why lie? Why her?

He tried to find an excuse, but could not. Every attempt broke against the wall of lies. Sometimes a single act, one small lie, destroyed trust forever. He felt it in every part of him.

Yet deep inside, something else remained: tenderness for that red-haired, freckled, stubborn girl. He wanted to turn and run back,

hold her, forgive everything. But he could not. Did not know how to believe her now.

The contradiction tore at him. Pain and love tangled so tightly that his heart seemed unable to bear it.

Without noticing, he reached Viktor's building. Climbed the stairs and knocked. Viktor did not open at once. He had apparently been getting ready for bed. He stood in the doorway, tousled and sleepy, in an undershirt and long underwear. At the sight of Denny, he frowned.

"What is it? Something happened?"

"Can I stay the night?" Denny asked dully.

Viktor stepped aside. Asked nothing. Nodded at the sofa.

"Lie down. We'll talk tomorrow."

Denny dropped onto the cushions in his clothes. Stared at the ceiling, where streetlight shadows trembled.

Viktor went to his bedroom, but left the light on and the door ajar, as on their very first meeting. A warm yellow strip cut through the darkness.

Denny lay listening to the silence.

Inside him, everything screamed.

Chapter 15

Denny woke with an aching shoulder. He had spent the night in one position, still dressed. The moment he opened his eyes, Prosha rushed into his mind. Then the thoughts began to flow, murky, catching on one another. He lay looking at the blurred patches of morning sun on the ceiling, unable to find the strength to move.

Dishes already clattered in the kitchen. Viktor was making breakfast. The smell of fried bread and eggs filled the apartment, reminding him that life went on even when everything inside was burned away.

Denny got up, padded over the cold floor, and washed his face in icy water from the faucet. A stranger looked back from the cloudy mirror: red eyes, rough stubble. He ruffled his hair and went to the kitchen.

Viktor sat at the table with steaming tea and a plate of eggs fried with pork fat. He was reading a newspaper, spread so wide that it hid his face.

“Sit down. Eat,” came his voice from behind it.

Denny sat, pulled his plate closer, but could not eat. He aimlessly pushed the eggs with his fork, lost in himself.

“Uncle Vitya,” he said after a minute. “Day off?”

The newspaper slowly lowered. Viktor looked over his spectacles. He wore them only for reading, and Denny was always surprised by the difference they made: older, wiser.

“No,” he said calmly. “I’ve been dismissed already.”

Denny froze, his fork halfway to his mouth.

“How?”

“Like that.”

Viktor folded the newspaper, set it aside, and took a sip of tea.

“An entire era of my life is over. That’s it.”

He stared out of the window. Something in his eyes made Denny forget his own troubles for a moment.

"Tell me, Uncle Vitya."

Viktor sighed and rubbed the bridge of his nose.

"What is there to tell? Thought they'd dismiss me over that business. Turns out…" He smiled without pleasure. "The MGB's gone. Disbanded. Stalin died, and everything changed overnight. They've set up the KGB now. Written us off."

He was silent. Then the corners of his mouth lifted, though his eyes stayed sad.

"Maybe I'll go back to a village. Drive a tractor. Come with me? We'll plant potatoes, build a house. An outhouse in the yard. Romantic."

Denny did not catch the sarcasm at once. When he did, he smiled back.

"They just dismissed everyone? You can't transfer to this KGB?"

"No." Viktor shook his head. "They need different people now. Fresh blood. We've done our time."

He picked up the newspaper again, but did not read it, only turned it in his hands.

"Uncle Vitya, perhaps we can think of something here?" Denny began cautiously.

Viktor narrowed his eyes, not angrily, almost as a father might.

"Sort out your own life first, bright lad. Then decide for everyone else."

"You won't leave, will you?" Suddenly, Denny was frightened. "We still have to find Lilith. Get her to come. Then… we'll all work it out together."

Viktor sighed and put the newspaper down for good.

"You're an idealist, Denny. That's no bad thing. But understand: she has a new life. She's been with another family since she was

fourteen. Nearly eight years. Think you'll write and she'll come running? Drop everything?"

Denny said nothing, looking at his plate.

"I'd bring her myself," Viktor went on more quietly. "But the people who raised her… That makes it harder. Even if she agrees, where would she come? I have to give up the apartment in a week. God knows what's happened to the house in Belorussia. Where would we bring her?"

He paused, looking at his work-worn hands.

"But write. You must write. We'll see what comes of it."

Denny nodded. Hope stirred inside him again.

"What's this, anyway?" Viktor suddenly grinned. "Decided to torment her? Let her suffer a bit now. Wait for letters?"

Denny snorted, then laughed, quietly but sincerely.

"That's right. We suffered. Her turn now."

"All right. Write."

Viktor pushed a clean sheet and a pen toward him.

"I can see you're worn out with it."

Denny took the pen and thought, but did not begin.

"Why did you come rushing over so late last night, by the way?" Viktor looked at him closely. "Prosha throw you out?"

He winked. Denny did not smile.

"She knew everything," he said dully. "The letters. Lilith. Knew and said nothing. Lied."

Viktor whistled.

"Prosha? Our Prosha?"

"Yes." Denny cut in. "I still can't believe it myself. But she did."

Viktor was silent, taking it in.

"Well," he breathed at last.

"And she started talking about children the other day," Denny added.

Viktor whistled again.

“That’s serious. Children aren’t a joke.”

“I don’t know how to forgive her now. How do I trust her after that?”

Viktor looked at him for a long moment, then leaned back.

“Think, Denny. Everything she’s been through. All she’s endured. And she stayed with you. Seems clear enough to me. Your decision, of course. But Proshka’s a woman with a will. Pushes through. Stubborn. To tell the truth, I thought she was a quiet little thing. Look at her now.” He smiled. “You won’t come to grief with her. And you won’t get away with much, either.”

Denny thought, and suddenly knew Viktor was right. Prosha had done so much for him. Been there so often, pulled him from the darkest pits. And he…

He could not forgive the lie, but he could try to understand.

“You’re probably right, Uncle Vitya,” he said quietly. “I’ll go and make peace. Then write the letter.”

He stood and began to dress.

“Listen.” Viktor stopped him. “Go to the department first. Collect the gold before it ‘disappears.’ Here’s the paper for it.”

He went to his room and came back with a stamped sheet. Denny read it and raised his eyebrows.

“Where did you get this?”

“From there.” Viktor smiled. “Good people helped. You owe me a bottle of decent whiskey.”

“Done!”

Denny shook his hand and hurried out.

They kept him at the department until evening. Checking documents, searching the storeroom, completing the release papers. He sat on a hard corridor bench, watching uniformed people pass and thinking of Prosha. The children she had

mentioned. Was he ready? Did he want them? He had never thought about it before. Now he suddenly understood that he did.

With her.

She would be a wonderful mother. Of that, he was sure.

By the time they finally gave him the heavy bundle of gold, it was dark outside. Denny put it in his inside pocket, buttoned his jacket, and set off home. On the way, he bought flowers from an old woman at the corner. Simple wildflowers, fresh, smelling of morning. Already, he pictured Prosha's smile when she saw them.

He climbed the stairs and opened the door.

The room was empty. Bed neatly made, table, chair. On the windowsill, a stack of his things: folded, ironed. His heart lurched. A note lay white on the table, a little sheet torn from a notebook.

He read it once. Twice. Three times. The meaning would not settle in his head.

"Don't look for me. I've thought it through. I don't want to live with your past. I'll start again. I hope you'll be happy. Goodbye."

The flowers fell from his hand, scattering bright patches over the floor.

"What is this… a joke?" he whispered.

His own voice sounded strange.

He hurried about the room. Threw open the wardrobe. Prosha's things were gone. No dresses, no notebooks, no favorite mug. Everything that spoke of her presence had vanished. Only his neatly stacked things remained, with his mother's pendant beside them.

He seized it, rushed into the corridor, looked into the kitchen. Empty. Ran to Nina.

She opened at once, as though expecting him. At the sight of his face, she only sighed.

"Come in, boy."

Denny went in and collapsed into the old, sagging armchair where Prosha had so often liked to sit.

"Auntie Nina. Where is she?"

The landlady sat opposite him and took a moment to gather her thoughts.

"She's gone, Denny. Came in, paid the room a month ahead."

She held out a couple of banknotes.

"Asked me to give you this. Said it would cover your ticket."

Denny did not even look at the money.

"Where? Why?"

"So serious. So determined. Made up her mind, I suppose. You know her. Once she decides, that's it. A will of her own, that girl."

Nina shook her head as though in admiration.

"Said you had a past. Some Lilith… She could manage by herself. Then she went. To Budapest. I offered money. She wouldn't take it. Said she had enough for a new life."

The old woman paused.

"And asked me to tell you not to look for her. She's on her own now."

Denny sat motionless, questions turning in his head with nowhere to go.

"A little drink?" Nina asked.

He nodded. She filled two glasses, one for herself and one for him.

"To Prosha," she breathed. "I liked her very much. May she be happy."

They drank. Then another. Denny stared at one spot, his thoughts moving slowly and heavily.

When they parted, he embraced Nina tightly and went back to the room. Packed his things into the old army bag, picked the flowers from the floor, and laid them on the empty table. Let them stay in the place where they had once been happy.

He slung the bag over his shoulder and trudged back to Viktor's.

Darkness had fully fallen, but he did not notice. He walked, looking straight ahead, moving his feet automatically. In his head, one thought pulsed.

Prosha was alone. Gone to Budapest, alone. With money, but alone. How would she manage? What would she do?

Yet somewhere deep inside, another feeling stirred.

Calm.

A peace he had not known for a long time.

She had chosen. Made her own decision. If it was better for her, let it be.

“May she be happy,” he whispered, looking at the first stars in the dark sky.

His soul was empty and quiet. As after a long storm, when the wind at last falls still, leaving wet earth and the smell of ozone.

Denny returned to Viktor. The old army bag dragged at his shoulder. Viktor opened the door and glanced at him, at his belongings.

“Come in, poor soul.”

The sofa was his, as before. Denny dropped onto it. For a minute, he lay staring at the ceiling, where the same streetlight shadows danced. Then he took out his mother’s pendant, the one with the green stone, and turned it in his fingers, catching light on its facets.

His father’s watch ticked on the cabinet beside him. Denny looked at it, then back at the pendant.

“Oh, Prosha,” he whispered. “You’re wonderful. I’m sorry I made you suffer.”

Viktor had gone to his bedroom. As before, the door was ajar, the familiar strip of light cutting through the dark. Denny watched it for a long time before sinking into heavy sleep.

At first light, he jumped up. Made up the sofa quickly. Did not even unpack; they would have to move soon anyway. He threw on his jacket, grabbed the gold, and hurried outside.

The watchmaker was already there. Light shone in the shop windows; the door was unlocked. Denny rushed in, breathless, as though chased, but happy.

“I’ve come for the glasses!” he blurted from the doorway.

The old man looked up from his workbench, smiled beneath his mustache, and set aside the magnifying glass. Unhurriedly, he rose, went to a cupboard, and brought out a case: dark-brown leather, with an embossed pattern.

“Here, lad. Done, as promised.”

Denny opened it. The glasses lay on velvet, utterly changed from the ones he had brought a few days earlier. The frames had been carefully straightened and covered with a fine layer of gold, gleaming softly in the morning light. The new lenses, clean and clear, looked back at him with the warmth his mother’s eyes had once held.

“Thank you,” Denny breathed. “They’re… like new.”

“Old,” the watchmaker corrected. “Just looked after. Things like this should live a long time.”

Denny took out the bundle and pressed it into his hand. Without a word, the craftsman understood and went into the back room. Five minutes later, he returned with a heavy stack of banknotes.

Denny impulsively embraced him, warmly, holding the dry, wiry body close. The watchmaker patted his back.

“All right. All right. Go on, before you strangle me.”

Denny put the case in his inside pocket, took the money for the gold, and hurried outside. The sun was up, filling the town with warm light. He almost ran toward Viktor’s, feeling something new catch fire inside him. More than hope.

Certainty.

Everything would be all right.

“Uncle Vitya!” He burst into the apartment. “Paper and a pen!”

Viktor sat in the kitchen with his usual newspaper and mug of tea. Slowly, he raised an eyebrow.

“Well, you’re full of energy today. What’s got into you?”

“Wait. Just a moment.”

Denny was already settling at the table, tapping his fingers against it.

“I have to write a letter. Before the thought goes.”

He smiled, took the pen, dipped it into the inkwell, and began:

“Dear Lilith,

“This is my first letter. Your uncle Viktor and I have been looking for you for a very long time. Years of searching. There’s so much to tell.

“Sadly, Aunt Toma is gone. She died in the camp. I’m glad you weren’t there. Viktor and I visit her once a month.

“I’m so happy you’re alive. I won’t write too much. Just wait for us. We’ll get tickets and come. I’ll try to persuade your uncle. How would I go to the Soviet Union without him? I know a couple of phrases in Russian, no more.

“Expect us.

“Your Denny.”

At the very bottom, carefully forming the Russian letters, he added:

До свидания!

Until we meet again.

He put down the pen, reread the letter, gave a satisfied grunt, and handed it to Viktor.

“Here. Read.”

Viktor took it and scanned the lines. His eyebrows rose.

“What have you got into your head?” He set the newspaper aside for good. “Off to the Soviet Union?”

“Don’t even start, Uncle Vitya.”

Denny stood and began pacing the kitchen.

“I’ll buy the tickets. There’s money. Ours, you might as well say. We’ll go together. Decide what to do when we get there. I can’t manage without you. You can help me get the papers, too, if need be.”

He grinned from ear to ear. Viktor looked at that smile, those bright eyes, and, without noticing, found himself grinning back.

“Well, why not?” he said, lighting a cigarette. “Since I’m mixed up in it already… You win. On one condition.”

“What?” Denny grew wary.

“You’re making the grub!”

He held out his open hand. Denny slapped it and embraced him.

They laughed, loudly, wholeheartedly, as in the old days when they had first begun living together. Their laughter flew through the open window and out across the yard.

The sun was fully up, filling the kitchen. The pendant gleamed, catching the world in different colors, while his father’s watch steadily counted the seconds. An unbridled happiness filled them. Their shared anticipation of the future bound them more tightly than any oath.

They were together.

And a new, momentous journey was beginning.

A message from the author

Alexander Vladimirovich Sukhoviev

With respect for you, the reader.
I would welcome your reviews and reflections.

Open The Story of a Good Man. Be ready to feel.
Enjoy my book and the emotions it brings.

Warning from the original edition

The unlawful use of narcotic drugs, psychotropic substances, and their analogues is harmful to health. Their illicit trafficking is prohibited and carries liability under the law.

Original-edition record

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18+

Original Russian edition: UDC 82-3; LBC 84-4; C91.

Sukhoviev, Alexander. The Story of a Good Man: The Story of a Good Man / Alexander Sukhoviev. - [Place not stated]: [Publisher not stated], 2026. - 312 pages. [No number supplied.]

The original edition credits ParaType for its typefaces.

The original edition's age-classification notice refers to Federal Law No. 436-FZ of December 29, 2010.